Can't outrun your fate

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34982815.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), The Adjustment Bureau (2011)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), The Chairman, Light Hope (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Drama, Drama & Romance, Destiny, Fate, Fate & Destiny, Politics, High Politics, Alternate Universe - Real World, Conspiracy, catradora, New York City, I mean I will literally show you real places in real New York because it's fun, POV Adora (She-Ra), It's always autumn here, Canon Lesbian Relationship, Fate keeps pulling Catra away, Adora's fate is determined, But since when has Adora ever listened to anyone?, And who the fuck is the chairman?, Strangers to Lovers, But it looks like they aren't allowed to be in a relationship, We will race New York, Hurt/Comfort, Hurt/Comfort in a loop, Oh boi I'm going to play with your hearts, Love will be crushed several times, Action & Romance, Angst, Fluff and Angst, Pining, so much pining

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by 21st_tikonda

Summary

"My name is Adora Grayskull, and I'd like to be the next Senator from the great State of New York!"

It's 2022, and Congresswoman Adora Grayskull runs for the Senate of the United States. With her campaign manager and best friend Glimmer at her side and a bright future ahead, there's nothing stopping her. But when she meets a beautiful stranger on election night, both their paths, as well as the path of humankind, deviates from everything that has been planned for her. Destiny keeps the woman away from her, but: can Adora outrun her fate?

OR: Drama, destiny, high politics, romance, fate & a conspiracy from high above? Can't get any better.

Notes

This story is fully written out, nine chapters, around 70k of words.

Thank you at mattiedoodles for the amazing cover art they made (see below). Their account deserves a look, and has more cool stuff there. Working with them was a delight.

For those who know the original material, it's pretty obvious what this is. And it is, until it isn't. I'm mixing the main source with other ones. So, don't trust your knowledge if you have any. This plan is not going the way you think it is, because the Chairman decided to make some adjustments. I'm just carrying it out, okay? All credits to the original material will be properly given in the afterword.

Be aware that all characters are grown-ups and in their late 20s, acting as such. This is no clumsy teenager drama, there's no idle chit-chat, and every sentence counts. This is a drama as much as it's an action movie.

This story is accompanied by certain pieces of music. They fit exactly to the following scenes and are meant to create and increase immersion. I link them throughout the story at their respective place, and they are meant to be started immediately. Using them will be worth it, I promise.

Please, enjoy.

Enter stage: Adora Grayskull


VOGUE
VP HARRIS:
'SHE'S AN INSPIRATION FOR THE COMING GENERATION.'
GRAYSKULL: CAN'T OUTRUN YOUR FATE.
THE YOUNGEST CONGRESSWOMAN IN HISTORY:
HER AIMS, DRESSCODE, AND DIET.
ADORA GRAYSKULL
REPORTING FOR DUTY

“Four elections” (Deezer / Spotify)

She waits.

But it will be time soon. The hallway is dark, only sparsely lit by light falling in through some tainted windows at the end of it. It's uncomfortable, and the air is chill in the stone building. But she knows these halls. Been here long enough. As always, her appearance is immaculate. It was then, and it surely is now. Of course, it is. Even if this is not her own skirt, nor her shoes, nor her necklace she’s wearing. Looking good is important, she knows that, and because she has no hand for it, she leaves it to the experts. She doesn’t have to like it, though.

She waits.

Her hands are only shaking a bit. It’s not the first time she’s doing this, and it won’t be the last one. She nervously fumbles with some of her notes, though. It’s a habit, leftover from her first public appearances, when she wasn’t used to it so much. Her experience grew, but the nervousness before a speech stayed. It's still exciting her, like before rushing into a battle. Yeah, she's ready for the battlefield. It lays before her, right outside. She'll take it.

She waits.

She internally rehearses her speech. It’s actually not so hard, because she’s done this one twenty times by now, and the words are always the same. She rearranges the sentences, from address to address, because she knows it’s important to sound authentic and not memorized. Rearranging them helps. And of course, she wants to *be* authentic, too. That’s why she’s doing this. This is not so much for herself. It’s for her dad, for her mum, for her sister. She wants to make them proud, even if they can't be here. This is for everyone who counts on her.

She waits. And listens.

"Future's Bright" (Deezer / Spotify)

The door before her is pushed open a little by a helpful soul, waving at her to come, and now she can hear the crowd howling and clapping, as the announcer outside calls out excitedly: "Let's welcome our favorite alumnus, and the next Senator from the state of New York, ADORA GRAYSKULL!"

Waiting is over. She got this.

Adora walks through the door and is right on the podium, her blonde ponytail bouncing, and for a short moment she's blinded by the light, by the sunshine, and by all the applause and clamor from hundreds, no, rather a thousand or more people. The crowd is so big that it reaches beyond the huge paved square over to between the trees and the meadow to the next buildings, two hundred meters further. All the people cheer up in a deafening noise, it's just crazy. She absolutely hasn't expected so many participants.
But okay, this is a home run, because it's her alma mater, and she still knows people here, even when it's been a few years since her graduation. But her campaign manager must've done her best, clearly, to amass so many folks on this autumn day. She has to thank Glimmer, yeah, she will.

She jogs to the front of the stage and waves at everybody, using both hands. *Not too enthusiastic, but of course excited.* She smiles and her blue eyes beam in excitement, because to be cheered like that is invigorating, it makes her lively, and the sight of all these people is just *WOW*.
Brushing a strand of her hair aside with one hand, she lowers the other one to pick the microphone from its stand, collects her mind one last time, and speaks up: "Thank you! Thanks! Well hi there! Wooo!" The audience is whipped.
She waves them down a bit. "Thank you! Thanks! My name is

Adora Grayskull, and I'd like to be the next Senator from the great state of New York!"

People are screaming, and like she told herself, it's a home run. In the background, Glimmer shouts in content excitement.

She will win this. Adora Grayskull, 27, soon a Senator.

It's three months later, and six months till the election. Adora's campaign is in full swing, and the longer it goes, the less Adora remembers. In hindsight, most days and weeks are just blurry, because every day there are so many events to attend, so many people to meet, so much things to do, to decide, to hide, to cheer, to greet, to walk, to talk and never to sleep.

And Adora, who never sleeps, is made for this. She was *born* for this. And would fight in her sleep, if she could.

The election war machine is running, its gears screeching at full speed, making everyone sweat. The campaign grows from day to day. Had there been five of them in the beginning, the incoming donations enabled them to hire people and to gather volunteers. Two weeks later, thirty people, two weeks later fifty, two weeks later eighty. The hiring of PR people followed, media, advertising, talk shows, meetings, oversight. All of this not exploding is thanks to Glimmer Brightmoon, campaign manager, queen of New York, menace to society, evil mastermind, and the strategic head behind Adora's *previous* election. Despite being senior partner of ASI Venture Capital, Glimmer told the board to hold its breath, handle things without her for a year, reported for duty, and put herself into getting Adora *a seat*.
In the Senate.
Of the fucking United States.
Because Congress is not enough.

Sometimes, Adora reminds herself of the first real talk they had about it.
"I don't even know how to pay you, Glimmer," Adora had said hesitantly, looking down at her plate with her half-eaten meal still on it. Her ambitions were by far greater than her means, financially speaking, but when on Earth had this triviality ever stopped her from *wanting* it. She yearned to do this for years, since her first step onto the ladder, and when she allowed herself to really think about it, her motivation had its spark way before. But this was not the time for ruminating, because they had to talk this out, and somehow, Adora will be able to hire her. Senatorial election campaigns need plenty of money, and Glimmer was key to setting up an action committee that will actually *work*.
Adora needed this *alliance*, and she knew it.
Keens Steakhouse in downtown Manhattan seemed to be a good place to talk about it, and Glimmer glanced at her friend over her expertly roasted, fine Angus Beef. Then she shoved another piece in her mouth, chewed, swallowed and took a sip of the excellent red wine that stood before her in a chiseled glass. After letting Adora wait for a few more cruel seconds, she asked: "Do you think I'm doing this for money, Adora?"
Said Adora frowned shortly, then replied: "Uhm, not really, okay, but I assumed you'd at least want to get adequately rewarded for this job. I wouldn't expect you to work for free. I would feel bad."
"Oh really, I never guessed!" Glimmer scoffed, because she remembered - vividly remembered - their last campaign for the House.
Adora groaned. "I know, Glim! But the Senate is different. We need five times the money and a broader campaign, much more people, volunteers and donors alike. We need a real headquarters, not my living room. Look, I made a plan." She hands Glimmer a sheet of paper with dozens of lines and many numbers at the right side. And a large number at the end. Many zeros. A frightening amount of zeros, actually. "Ask me anything," Adora says proudly, because she'd prepared and condensed her battle plan into this one perfect piece of paper.
While her friend studies it, she took a sip, because her throat was dry. "It will be strenuous, you know that. It's going to be a lot

worse than the previous campaign, and I can’t—"
Glimmer set the plan aside and cut her short, asking: “Do you want this? I mean, with all your heart and soul? Will you put everything of yourself into it? Fight for every voter? Take my advice? Work your ass off?” Adora vividly remembers how eagerly she nodded and whispered, “Yes. I want this! To make a difference.” She gulped before admitting: “I want to matter."
Glimmer rolled her eyes and shook her head. This trait of Adora is something she was more than just familiar with. "You already matter, Adora. It doesn't need a seat in the fucking Senate to make sure of that."
"You know what I mean. I'm aware that I matter to some people, you included, of course. How could I think otherwise? Okay? That’s not it. I know this sounds pretentious, but I think I have some good ideas on how to run things better. And I want more than just a seat in the House—"
“Just a seat in the house? Do you even hear yourself?” Glimmer scoffed, but she put a hand on Adora’s one and added “Just a seat, the woman says, like it’s nothing.”
Adora rolled her eyes. “Don’t be rude, Glim. You know that being a Senator is way more important than being a Representative. And an important step."
"Don't jinx it, Adora. First things first."
Adora noded, but then confirmed: “I want this, Glimmer. And I will put everything into it.” She was a bit shy to ask, but she did it anyway: “Will you help me?”

Glimmer retracted her hand, cut off another piece of her steak, ate it, then replied with a smug smile: “I already informed the board about my absence for the next year. They’ll live with it. As will mom.” She leaned back, crossed her legs, was somewhat too relaxed in Adora’s opinion, and continued. “It’s not like they can do much about it, huh, but it will be good to have them on board, you know? For funneling donations and such. They install a Super PAC on our behalf and I advised them to provide it with a, lets say, good amount of seed capital…, uhmm... donations, yes! And here’s what you’re going to pay me for my service.”
Glimmer smugly shoved a little piece of paper across the table

that had been lying next to her plate all along. Her eyes were sparkling of joy when Adora took it, unfolded it, and shook her head in disbelief: “3,400 Dollars? What for a weird joke is that, Glimmer? Do you mean this per day or what? Maybe I can afford __"
Glimmer wiped her mouth clean and chimed happily: “It’s the price of the dress that you're gonna go and buy for me when we attend your inaugural address, Senator. I had it put back. You’re welcome.” She giggled self-satisfied.
Adora tried to comprehend and failed miserably for a few seconds. But she wasn’t dumb. She looked into Glimmer's face and found nothing but a genuine smile.
“You’re serious, aren’t you?”
Glimmer nodded, joked again about if after taking Congress, the Senate would be enough, then they had a teary evening at the bar afterwards, and Adora’s campaign took off ever since.

For nine months, Adora only remembers so much. Glimpses. Pieces.

They are on tour, and she smiles at the baffled woman before her: “I’m going to go through Yonkers, from door to door. That’s how I win this election!” The woman blinks at her in disbelief, but Adora takes both her hands, and thanks her for listening, even if they barely had a minute. Speaking to as many people as possible and making a good impression is paramount, and Adora does it.

The news anchor on the television screen in the hotel bar tells them: “The recent endorsement from the firefighters union is tailwind for Grayskull. She's now leading with six points over her opponent." And he doesn’t even sound surprised. Adora’s gonna win this by a landslide, and she high-fives with Glimmer while her whole team is cheering upon the good news. “Woo-hoo, baby. I’m so gonna rub this in *someone’s* face,” Glimmer hollers excitedly. Adora guesses she means her rival and friend Lyn - whom she often lowkey calls Evil-Lyn, because the mean bitch leads the campaign of Adora’s opponent. When Glim and Lyn are not yelling

at each other, they tend to make fun of Adora, or whoever pitiable prey comes before them.

Adora's on a boat with the US Coast Guard, they're rushing over the Hudson River at high-speed, and she *squeals* with joy. The officers of the guard are amazed how the tall, blonde woman squeaks when the boat paces over a wave, coming from one of the ferries before them. It jumps, falls back into the water splashing, and Adora screams like a little girl, because this is so much fun! Her ponytail twirls and whips, as she grips the railing to steady herself. They will have serious budget talks later, because she's still an honorable Congresswoman, but sometimes, even an election campaign can be fun. This is super!

Adora guides a school class through her campaign headquarters and tells them how an election works. The children can't vote, but their parents can, and if the little ones gush about the nice blonde Congresswoman-soon-to-be-Senator, how could the parents resist? It's only good that Glimmer's in charge of the strategy, because Adora would never use children just like that. Glim, on the other hand, is not so shy in her means, and she makes Adora do this. It's not so hard, because Adora loves these kinds of events. They are more relaxed, less formal, and she can be more herself. Glimmer has sparkling eyes while she watches Adora sitting on the floor, in a circle with the children, and answers them questions.

Standing behind the chairman of the party, she listens to him with an earnest face. "Adora Grayskull represents Brooklyn, New York City, and America for the last two years. Now she's running for the Senate of the United States, and we are proud that such a good woman…" She has heard this ten times before and will hear it ten times after, but this is necessary. The support of the party members and all these possible voters is what will make her win, and even if she has some difficulties sharing every point of view of her party, she knows that this is the way compromises work. She waves and smiles at all the people before she says her selected words, and the applause is sure.

They are in a bar in The Bronx, meeting said voters, while Adora's sitting on a barstool and talking to them. Adora points mockingly at Glimmer, who leans at the bar and just ended a talk on her phone: "This is my campaign chairman, Glimmer Brightmoon. Hey Glimmer, these are voters." She's nearly glowing with joy, and Glimmer has a hard time not rolling her eyes on the shiny golden retriever before her, but she also can't keep the good news in. She is loud enough for everyone to hear: "According to the surveys, we are ten points ahead." And everyone beams, because everyone loves winners.

She's at a rally, and there are literally thousands of people, it's the largest crowd she ever attracted. Her soaring campaign of course contributes to this, because everyone likes to be seen with the up and coming winner of this election.
But she has to be careful and realistic, and so her speeches stay still humble: "This is not going to be easy getting there. I have some real opposition, and what they're saying about me is that I'm too young to hold this office. But that's okay because these are the same people who say that young people don't vote, that young people don't care about politics. But I'm here to tell you, your future is about *your choices*, not theirs. You set the course for your future, not them. So today I'd like to put them on notice, because come November, I want them to KNOW that it was young people like you who kicked their asses!"

The crowds are going mad when she talks to them like that. "A-DO-RA! A-DO-RA! A-DO-RA" they chant and holler.
People haven't heard someone encouraging them like Adora believes it is necessary for a long time. Adora often speaks straight from her heart to them, mostly with smaller crowds or at community gatherings. She's strongest in discussions with a handful of people, because then she listens, gives advice, shows compassion, strength and most of all: she shows leadership.
She has strong opinions about how to use her influence for the best of the citizens, and people actually like it. They like the still young woman with the blonde ponytail and the funny hair poof, the casual yet immaculate appearance, and the clever yet casual mind. And if she's honest with herself, she's basking in it, in the

praise, the cheering, the approval.
“Thank you!”, she screams at the crowd and is thrown hand kisses at in return. “A-DO-RA! A-DO-RA! HEY HEY HEY” She wallows in the praise and attention.

This. Is. Awesome!

When we got knocked down

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It’s awesome until it’s not.

Four days before the election, Adora wakes up after a short night, and her body is still tight. It’s not because the last weeks have noticeably ramped up her daily duties. She’s out in the battles - the campaign appointments - from seven in the morning until ten in the evening. May Americans call this neverending endeavor an ‘election campaign’, but it’s like Glimmer phrased it: “These always too gravely Germans have a better wording, because they call it ‘Wahlkampf’. Which literally means ‘election battle’. And that’s what it is, Adora. It’s a battle. For votes, for the people’s minds and hearts. It’s fought with arguments, persuasion, money, loudness and good looks. Good for you that we have all of that.” Then she snickered to herself and shoved Adora out of the campaign bus for another rally.

During the last weeks, Adora won most of the daily combats, but today she wakes up with a bad conscience and a heavy heart. Because she did something very dumb last night, and only got to bed three hours before, after the police interrogation finally ended. But she needed at least a bit of sleep before being able to deal with the fallout.
She hasn’t slept in her apartment for the last four weeks, instead she stays in a hotel room right above their campaign headquarters. Spare time has become nonexistent, and every hour counts.
Putting down her bare feet on the fluffy carpet soothes her a bit while she wiggles her toes between the soft material. She indulges briefly and enjoys the beautiful feeling. Then reality crashes back, Adora sighs, puts her hair tie back in, and reaches for her clothes. Luckily, she always showers before going to bed, so a cat wash and a splash of cold water in the face are enough

for now.
She draws it out on purpose today, though, because she dreads what will inevitably follow in a few minutes.

Her fears are confirmed, as the headlines of today are not as friendly as they were yesterday. Unfortunately, Adora had her hands in it.
Literally.
She has the 'New York Times' under her arm, while she balances two cups of very hot coffee she fetched from the breakfast buffett, and pushes the door to the campaign HQ open with her butt. She wears her gray suit and a false smile, as she enters the main room. Half past seven, it's already buzzing with people, and her slim hope of handing one of the cups over to Glimmer, *before* the pink-haired menace to humankind caught up with a particular headline, is crushed by said Glimmer screaming "AAAAADOORAAAAAAAA!" upon her sight.
She is loud and shrill, which is never a good sign for no one in a radius of 50 kilometers around the epicenter. Presumably, NORAD is sounding the alarm for the NY metropolitan area right now.
"WHAT IS THIS? *'Congresswoman Grayskull involved in a bar fight.'* Explain yourself, *WOMAN*! NOW!"
Glimmer's standing before her, with crossed arms and panting heavily. The angry, grim countenance makes Adora wince, because she actually feels guilty and ducks her head. She should've stayed in bed today. And yesterday, obviously.
Unfortunately she is here, and holds out one of the coffees to her friend, who ignores the gesture and stares her down angrily, despite being a head shorter.

Adora is a grown-up woman, yep. She's educated, mostly funny, looks good, is kind and an experienced politician. Of course, she is. She's a grown-up Congresswoman! At 24 years she became the youngest Congresswoman in the history of the United States, stripping poor Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez of the title held until then.
Adora Grayskull, 28 now, policymaker on behalf and for the people of New York's 10th congressional district in the United States House of Representatives, thank you very much.
Adora is no child.

The problem is that Glimmer isn't *aware* of all these facts when it comes to berating Congresswoman Grayskull whenever she likes and feels entitled to do so. Which is often, and according to Glimmer Brightmoon, Adora Grayskull "IS AN IDIOT. How could you? A pub fight in the week before the election? Oh my god, Adora, I don't know what to say. This is the dumbest thing you ever did. And I'm counting in the time when you stole that… ugh, never mind. This isn't just bad. It's… it's…. it's uber bad!"
Again, Adora reluctantly hands Glimmer the coffee as she replies: "Nobody says *uber bad*, Glimmer. This isn't how people talk. It's not even proper wording. Sounds like bad writing."
Glimmer shoots her daggers and growls: "Oooh, but I do. I single-handedly made twenty percent of New York's female population between 18 and 30 wear *pink* last year's season just because I didn't want to lose a bet, Adora. I'll make it a saying, mark my words. And while I'm doing that, explain to me - pleeeease - why did you do this? Why did you ruin two years of my work just like that?"

"One year," Adora whispers, then gulps, because Glimmer actually could do that and is actually right. It's creepy how much this woman can influence others by just running around and angrily *telling* them what they want to do. Or threaten them to.
Sometimes Adora wonders why she's the one running for Senate and not Glimmer. On the other hand, democratic nations don't like to be ruled by someone who would clearly rather fit into a monarchy. Like Glimmer. As a ruthless queen, obviously.
Back to the topic at hand, Adora manages a weak: "It was nothing Glimmer. Just a brawl at a bar. Some patrons got handsy, and I stepped in to help. It got a bit out of hand, but nobody was hurt."
Glimmer's face is red. "Nothing? Nothing, Adora? It's not NOTHING WHEN IT'S THE FUCKING HEADLINE OF THE FUCKING WASHINGTON POST AAAH!!"
"Them too?" That's terrible, and Adora winces again, because yeah, she knew immediately she should've called Glimmer on the spot and told her. She just hoped… nah, it's time to repent, because the pictures are awful.

“Yeah, I know. I’m sorry Glimmer. I should’ve told you.” If anyone needed a picture of a Labrador with ears flat and head hanging low, he could take it here. Adora’s arms hang limp at her side, and she feels terribly ashamed. *I’m such a disappointment.*
Glimmer ruffles her own hair in despair. “You should’ve stayed in your room, for fucks sake. Why didn’t you stay in your goddam room? Nah, don’t tell me, I already know, Missy.” Then she calms herself down, and it works instantly. It’s unsettling for Adora to see how Glimmer’s able to go from full madness into a cool, calculating mood within seconds. She secretly guesses that Glimmer just likes the dramatics, but now it seems she’s rather… disappointed.

“Glim?” Adora asks quietly and lays a hand on her friend’s arm. The smaller woman heaves a deep breath and purses her lips in an attempt to smooth her words. “I will try damage control, but it’s only four days, and your opponents are going *to use* this, Adora. Lyn will roast us. I would, if I was her and it’s already everywhere. We need to prepare for the fallout. Tell me everything.” She forcefully taps Adora's chest with her index finger. “Everything, Adora.”
And Adora spills it out like a fountain. She maybe learned how to make a poker face in front of everyone and how to keep quiet when required. But not to Glimmer.

Unfortunately, damage control can only do so much, and the media pounce on her faux pas with verve and very, very eagerly. The news is everywhere, and even worse is that there are photos. They are bad, they are shady, they are just telling a very little part of the story.
But the problem is that they show Adora grabbing some wincing guy by his collar. More so because it’s right after she dealt him a nice first blow.

They don’t show him grabbing a woman’s ass before, and they don’t show his nasty comments on said woman when she complained about it, and they also don’t show how his fellows rallied against *one single woman*. And also not how Adora stepped in first in an aim to calm everything down. It hadn’t worked, they

all were a bit tipsy, got handsy, and Adora stood her ground, like always, after she took the first blow. She didn't take a second one.
The fucking pictures don't show the truth, just like they seldom do, because they are pictures and not the fucking reality.
Pictures are mostly lies, but these are perfect lies.
It's only that it's unimportant, because important is, what is shown on the front pages, on the internet, the talk shows and the news.

And these pictures show how Congresswoman Grayskull hits a poor fellow.

It's election night, and Adora's sitting on her bed in a room at the Waldorf-Astoria, where her campaign booked the ballroom for the celebration when everything looked so shiny. Now, it doesn't anymore. If anything, it's going to be a very tight race. Adora's alone for a few minutes for the first time in weeks, watching TV, and her favorite comment is actually Trevor Noah saying: "Adora Grayskull, until recently she was way ahead in the polls, but what a surprise. Such political promise and the compelling story: grew up in a rough neighborhood in Brooklyn - some call it Red Hook, others call it the Fright Zone - suffering from the loss of her entire family, her mom and her sister when she was ten, her father before she got to high school. And she got over it. She had such promise. She was the youngest person ever elected to the House of Representatives, with 24, the youngest Congresswoman in history. But a bar brawl, right before the possible election into the Senate of the United States? It reeked of some level of childish and immature behavior, of uncontrolled impulsiveness. And despite my better judgement, people want maturity, they want adults in the Senate. As much as I disagree with this opinion. Personally I think it would've been a good thing if Grayskull woke up some fellows there with a punch. Figuratively

speaking. Not… not the other thing.” He winks and slams his fist on the table, and Adora hollowly chuckles a bit, and if it wasn’t herself that this is all about, it would’ve been more funny.

It seems that her fall is as quick as her rise was. Because people like winners. And a whole nation picking on you for fighting around in a bar doesn't make you look like a winner.
She lays back down on her bed, and bobs her feet, tries to concentrate and to feel a little less miserable. It doesn’t work, it just makes her feel lonely, and it’s a feeling she’s just too familiar with. Then Glimmer knocks on her door and calls her down into their headquarters for tonight.

The mood isn’t so good, despite the many people running around in the campaign HQ. Glimmer lays a hand on Adora’s shoulder, who’s standing before one of the TVs they set up everywhere. “Hey babe, still watching CNN? They called this way too early.” Adora nods and manages a weak smile, but CNN has already called out a very clear lead for her opponent, and it’s all a result of the devastating news of the last three days. One of her fellows at the telephone lines to the election offices holds up a hand and calls in: “Suffolk County: Grayskull 370 to 415.”
It’s another lost county for Adora. She tries to keep some of her hope, because it’s not *over yet*, but then a staff member approaches them and hands Adora a paper, saying: “Brooklyn just came in.”
Adora draws in a sharp breath, takes the paper with a nervous feeling, because the woman doesn’t sound good. Brooklyn is her home district. She takes in the numbers on the paper and mouths: “Wow. I didn't even win Brooklyn. That’s going to be a disaster.” Fuck. She will lose this, she disappoints all her fellows because of one fucking mistake. This is all her fault.

“NBC has us up next” the staff member says, and right there Adora knows it’s over. They wouldn’t be here so soon if there was still a chance. She doesn’t even get to win her home district, and that’s the final nail on the coffin of her ambitions. It’s a punch in her gut. Glimmer looks at her with a worried face, and Adora can’t stand that look now.

“I'll go back over my speech,” she hears herself saying like it’s another person doing it, and starts to walk away.
“Adora. Adora! Hey!” Glimmer calls after her, but Adora’s mood is plummeting. She raises her head shortly, looking at her friend and says quietly: "I'm sorry Glimmer. I wasted your time. I’ll get you the dress for another occasion." She doesn’t want to cry, not yet, she can’t right now. She has to be brave for her team and the people that will gather in the hall now, to hear her concession speech. There will be time for crying later, for crying about a lost year, about disappointing so many people who trusted her, who put all their best work into this, only for Adora to let all of them down because she got *handsy* and couldn’t control her temper.

She has to collect herself and redraw her speech.

Behind her, on the screens, she hears CNN’s anchor calling out the winner of the election, and it’s not her name. “After a shockingly poor showing in both Suffolk County and her home county, Kings, it now appears that Adora Grayskull will lose this election badly.”
She grits her teeth and walks out of the HQ, trying to steady herself. This is what is left from her ambitions: a footnote in the Wikipedia article about the 2022 Elections for the Senate of the United States, where the losers are mentioned.
Fuck it. She's going to hold a concession speech, and then… she'll ask Glimmer for a job, maybe. After getting drunk for a day or two, obviously.

Of course, the women's room isn't empty. The chattering dimwits inside two of the booths won’t go so quickly, and it's unnerving her. Adora stands in the oversized and lavishly decorated hallway before the restrooms and shoots a quick look over to the men's room. She needs some space to breathe, a splash of water in her face, and some silence, she needs it now and her decision is quick. When she pushes open the door, it’s delightfully silent.

“Hello? Hello?” Her voice echoes through the ridiculously large room. There's no one answering and no noise when she walks in front of the booths, where she exhales audibly. The room is void of people, of course, because men just have it easier, huh? Sometimes she wishes she were a man herself. Half the prejudices about herself running for the Senate would be gone, if she just belonged *to the boys, uh huh.*
Okay, she’s maybe unfair, because losing this, she did that to herself. *This is so fucked up.* How could she even lose? Just because of a stupid bar fight with an asshole over a pat on the butt at all? Fuck it. It’s so unfair. If she were a man, a fight actually might have helped. But for her, it was unwomanly, unbecoming, immature, of course. All these comments on the social networks, from people who knew nothing about the actual situation, but just saw a lying picture… disgusting.

"Fuck!” Adora shouts, leans against one of the half a dozen beautiful sinks and splashes some water into her face. Breathing in and out for a few times helps to calm down. After another look into her own face at the mirror, she starts talking to herself, to practice the speech she never thought she would have to give. Muttering lowly for a minute or two is easy, she did it hundreds of times. But the last sentence is harder, and she mutters it louder: “Today’s not about me. It’s about coming together and welcoming the newest Senator for the great state of New York… ugh… Lucius Hordak.” She rolls her eyes and sighs.

Something clacks behind her, in one of the cells, and it makes Adora freeze. Then she hears a silent “Shit.” And then some more “Shitshitshit.” It’s a quiet, but an unmistakably *female* voice, which startles Adora out of her self-pitying. She calls out another “Hello?” and only then the door to one of the toilets opens slowly, and a… beautiful woman comes out and heads for a sink and mirror. She’s a tad smaller than Adora, wears a black dress that shows her shoulders and *much* of her cleavage, indicating firm breasts. Shortly, Adora’s eyes are tied to the bare skin, the indicated valley in the middle, but then she snaps her eyes back to the woman’s face. Her dark brown hair is curly, voluminously flowing over the bare skin of her shoulders. It’s rather a mane

which suits her perfectly. The stringy figure looks trained, but not too much. She's a beauty, and said beauty doesn't look into Adora's eyes while rushing to a sink, where she puts down a bottle of champagne that she holds in her hand, as well as her shoes which were in the other one.

What the fuck? Adora thinks and is still frozen. *She's been there the whole time! She heard everything. Oh my god, NO!*
"It's the men's," she accuses the woman lightly with a tone of disbelief.
"Yep. And yet, here we are", the brunette whirs and is still looking into the mirror, then she washes her hands shortly. For a second it looks like she wants to stay silent, but the disbelieving look on Adora's face must've done something, because the stranger spins to Adora and starts rambling: "Sorry about that. I didn't mean to eavesdrop. I just didn't know what to do, because I heard you come in and say 'Hello" and I probably should've said 'Hi', but then I thought that would be weird because it's the men's, and then you started talking to yourself and… and it was obviously very personal, so I was kind of stuck in a no woman's land and... then it all got to be too much, so I came out."
"You came out?" Adora repeats incredulously after a few seconds, smitten by the wall of text that'd been thrown at her. And the sight of the woman. Nah, nought!
"Yeah, not as early as you, but still," the stranger suddenly smirks, and Adora actually *gets* what she's talking about, and the woman is so beautiful, and Adora is so intrigued by her, and her voice is so alluring, and Adora… but that's NOT the point right now.

"That's not what I... Ugh! What are you doing in here?"
The brunette snorts and it sounds as adorable as it sounds 'none of your business'. But Adora continues to stare at the woman with questioning eyes, until she finally admits: "I'm just…", she sighs, "I'm hiding. From security." She looks a little uneasy, shoots a glance at the door, but Adora senses immediately that it must be a rather trivial stuff. This woman isn't a criminal, that's for sure, and she's curious. "Uhm, why?"
It seems the answer is embarrassing her, but she presses out: "I crashed a wedding, upstairs."

A huff makes it out of Adora's throat. The beauty doesn't look like someone who's up for such immature shit, but on the other side, this smirk… "People still do that?"
The woman shrugs her shoulders, and the small movement looks enticing."It was a dare."
Adora's getting more and more confused about this alluring stranger. "Who dared you to crash a wedding?"
There were a few seconds of mutual glancing. "Me."
The curt, precise, and self-accusing answer makes Adora bark out a single loud laugh. "Oh. Haha. Eh. I crashed a wedding once, when I was in High School. I mean... no, I never did that."
"Did you?" The woman laughs, and it sounds so nice. It's balm on Adora's tortured soul, so she admits: "Yeah, I did, but I got caught and got into a brawl."
It gets her a smirk, but it's not without some compassion. "I think that happened more than once, from what I've heard. You're that woman running for Senate, aren't you?"
"Yeah, I am that woman," Adora answers, and is beguiled more and more by the stranger's appearance. The wrecked totality of today's fuck-up isn't even lingering in the back of her mind now, but just gone. Some part of her mind tells her that she came here for a reason. But she doesn't listen, she just wants to stare into the beautiful, mismatched eyes before her.
"And judging from your speech, you're not winning." The stranger sounds sympathetic, but there's also a little tease in it.
"No," Adora admits, and it doesn't even sting anymore.
The woman breathes out: "Oh man, it's too bad, the other guy is such an idiot."
It gets Adora chuckling and giggling. "He's an idiot." She smiles, and now they're both giggling. Looking at the woman just lets her, throwing her despair about the loss out of the window. "I wish I could've made that clear in the campaign ads."
"Yeah, I personally think that beating up strangers in bars who try to grab pussy is no big deal—"
"The Post didn't have to run the photo—""
"No, at least not full page—"
"Yeah, no."

Both of them fall silent, then start to giggle and laugh again, because despite all of it, it sounds somewhat funny now, and Adora's still thinking she did everything right then, regardless of what Glimmer or whoever says. She stood up for another person, and she would do it again. Point. Now, both their tones are light and amused.
The stranger saying "It was my favorite moment of your whole campaign, really," gets Adora answering: "I could've used you on my team a couple of months ago."
The woman slips onto the sink with utter elegance. Her feet dangle down and Adora can't help but to glance at her legs when the slit in her skirt allows it. They look so smooth, yet slightly exercised, and her skin is perfect.
Touchable. She can barely hold herself back from doing it.
"Yeah, I could help poll tests of every word that comes out of your mouth before you say it".
Adora takes a risk. "Oh, so you like politicians?"
"I like when they do stuff I can relate to," the stranger affirms, her voice getting lower.
"Like bar fights?" Adora teases. This forth and back is making her feel so good, it's outright crazy.
"I love that," the woman sultry says, and both giggle again. Adora's suddenly so happy. She didn't feel as light in the past months, but now, in her darkest moment, it's all fine. "See, that kind of candidate wouldn't even get elected to the student council."
The stranger's look hovers over Adora's face, seems to linger on her lips for a moment, then she leans forward and touches Adora's tie slightly. "My woman would know how to tie her own tie."
"Your wom… It's a clip-on," Adora retorts, barely able to force the words out.
"Oh, I wish," she whispers, so enticing, her face closer. "That would've been my other favorite moment of your campaign." She cocks her head slightly and looks more serious. "Do you still have a chance? Is it over?"
"He— he crushed me." Adora admits, but unlike before, there is no edge to it anymore. It's like the mere conversation with this

beguiling stranger has changed something about how she thinks about it. About the future. Five minutes before, there was only a dark path leading from here into nothingness. Now, tomorrow has so many alluring possibilities.
The woman exhales, sympathetic. "Sorry."
Adora has to come up with a good reply that doesn't crush the mood: "Well, losing has its advantages."
"Like what?", curly girl wants to know. She still sits on the sink before Adora, her feet dangling down and lightly swaying, which looks un-be-lievable tempting. But she clearly can't want Adora to run down her hands over that lascivious body.
So Adora shrugs her shoulders and manages to not look at the cleavage before her eyes. "For one thing, as a politician, you're never really alone unless you're asleep or in the bathroom - usually," she smirks at the other woman on that, "and that gets… that gets old."
"Really?" Mrs. Cleavage doesn't sound so convinced.
"Yeah, I guess I'm mostly just looking forward to having some time by myself." Again, she shrugs her shoulders in an attempt to brush it aside.
The woman leans forward, looks at her, and it's deep, piercing, as she whispers: "I don't buy it. I think you love it."
And that is true. It's like she looks directly into Adora's soul. She knows that Adora loves being a politician, being with people, leading them, and being a guide in uncertain times. There is a connection between her and this woman, Adora feels it, as if they've already met before and knew each other from long ago. It can't be that they haven't ever…
Adora asks flustered: "Do I know you?" and gets no answer but a nervous chuckle. They stare at each other, and she wants to touch the stranger. But she can't, of course, so she steps back one pace to bring some distance between them, then scratches her neck. "Yeah, I guess I could've been more convincing."

The woman glides off the sink with the same flowing movement, and closes the distance again, is standing before Adora very near: "Okay, you don't have to worry about being convincing till the next election."

Adora's getting giddy, because the vibes are hell of a thing now. Despite the stranger being a tad smaller than her, it seems that she's towering over her. The woman is so close. She manages a nervous: "Are you a registered New York voter?"
"Do I sound like I am," is the whispered answer, followed by a lick over her only half-closed lips, and she's even nearer now.

Adora is under a spell, she's so drawn to this woman, can't resist, and it seems, she's not the only one. And despite her better judgement, she shifts herself a little bit forward, her arms down, to which the stranger immediately answers by shifting forward herself, opening her posture. They are so close to each other. Adora is just falling. Her heart pounds so fast.

So near.

Her lips part a little. As does the stranger's one. *She wants it too,* both women know simultaneously, and a moment later they are in each other's arms, kissing and caressing the other one. The woman has put her surprisingly strong arms around Adora's neck, drawing her in, and Adora holds her shoulders softly with her arms having been put under them. The lips of the stranger are damp, and soft, and so, so kissable. They kiss each other eagerly, with passion, but after whatever time has passed Adora finally parts, leans back slightly and murmurs "Holy shit," and it puts a smile on the stranger's face.
Her eyes meet fluttering mismatched ones, but then she's drawn in again. This feels wonderful, kissing this beautiful, enticing stranger. Everything about this is so familiar, so intimate, as if they've done it before, already met. How can this be?

"Adora?"
Glimmer bolts into the room, and the stranger immediately withdraws, still not quick enough
"Adora, you… oh, wow, sorry guys. Sorry." She looks confused - understandably - and doesn't really get what happened here. Hell, even Adora doesn't get what happened, and she is superbly flustered.
The stranger jumps, mouths "Sorry, I got to go", gets her shoes

and starts running out of the room.
Still distracted and startled, Adora needs a second to gather herself, then she collects her mind and calls after the already vanished woman: “Wait!”
Glimmer lets out a low “Wow,” but as Adora runs by, she asks, “Are you giving your speech now?”
“Hang on”, Adora says to Glimmer, because she has other intentions and darts behind the kissable stranger, calling “Hey!” as soon as she’s in the hallway. There are a man and a woman from the hotel security at the other end of it, twenty meters away, and they start approaching them, or rather, the brunette, because one of them calls “Madam!" at her.
The strange and yet so familiar beauty before Adora stops shortly, whispers “I got to go,” ruffles Adora’s tie loose and says: “That is so much better.”
“Ma’am!” the security shouts, and there she leaps off for a staircase and is followed by the security. Only in the last moment, Adora catches that a little tattoo adorns the woman’s shoulder blade. It’s a cat, a tiny black cat, sitting and watching, her tail curled around herself. Adora hears the woman giggling, then she’s gone.

And Adora is stunned. She touches her lips with her fingers, then looks at them stupidly, and can still feel where the damp lips met hers. *What the fuck happened there?*
“What was that?” Glimmer asks incredulously. She stands beside Adora and can’t believe it as well. Adora isn’t the type for occasional hook-ups and never has she seen the blonde doing something like that.
“I don’t know,” Adora whispers, and she doesn’t. She has no fucking clue, but she grins so wide for the first time this day.
Glimmer has a pout on her face. “Why doesn't this happen to me? Maaan!” But then she pulls at her friend’s hand. “Are you ready, Adora? People are waiting for you. There’s a ballroom full of people waiting for you.”
“Yeah.” Adora nearly sighs, shakes out of her freeze, and despite the woman being gone, and despite her better judgement, because nothing has really changed, she feels… light. Good,

actually.
She balls her hand into a fist, takes this feeling, because the next thing she has to do needs all her strength. And now, she has it. She's ready.

The ballroom is huge, full of people, and this is going to be hard. The hall should've seen her victory speech tonight. Now she's going to admit defeat to that idiot. But Adora was never shy of cutting through the hard stuff, and she won't run away today. She is fueled by energy of which she thought she lost it an hour ago. The encounter with the woman—
The words, "Congresswoman Adora Grayskull!" cut into her thoughts, announce her to the hundreds of supporters and trained as she is, she waves at everybody, like always. People cheer and holler back, some whistle, and even if it's not the sound of victory, it's energizing nonetheless. These people still have trust in her, and the thought soothes Adora. *Yeah, the stranger was right. I love this.*

"Hello! Hi! Good to see you again. Thank you!"
She waves the people down, because she wants to get her words out: "I grew up not far away from here, in Red Hook."
Someone shouts "BROOKLYN!" and a woman screams "I love you, Adora!" Another woman yells louder, "I love you more!" and people laugh and chuckle.
The antics still put a smile on her face, and she waves again into the crowd, replying: "I love you both!" It gets her more hollers and cheers from the audience, but then Adora gets serious: "We had a rule in my neighborhood. When you got in a fight, it wasn't whether or not you got knocked down, it's what you do when you get back up." She emphasizes the last words very much, because she's good at this. And now, she really believes it. The crowd cheers, louder now.
"So, we didn't win tonight, and that's of course not what we

wanted. We lost that fight, but I came here to tell you tonight, that I. Will. Get. Back. Up!"
It rallies the audience more and more, she clearly has them. But then, the noise is suddenly silencing. It's just happening in her mind that everything gets quieter and quieter, but it makes her lose the thread of her trained, memorized speech. The people are still clapping, but all the words sound hollow to herself. Because… they are. They are memorized, they are trained, they are rehearsed, and it's exactly what she doesn't want to do at all. She never wanted to sound like Hordak. Or whoever. She wanted to sound like herself.

She looks down on her notes, and as Adora has stopped talking, the people stop cheering. It's getting silent in the large ballroom, because everyone waits for her. The people sense that something is shifting. They aren't idiots, even when they are her followers. They follow her because they have trust in her, and everybody gets that Adora has stopped for a reason, stopped walking one track of the road and is turning, in this very moment, and going for another path. They literally prick up their ears.
Because, actually…

"Uhm, it's bullshit. We didn't have that saying in my neighborhood." The admission lets Adora smile. "It's just one of those phrases that, uh, had some traction with the focus group, and so we kept using it, but not true." Adora takes a deep breath, because she sees Glimmer's concerned look when looking to the side, where her team stands beside the curtains with worried faces.
But Adora knows what she's doing: "You know, in 2020, I did a cover story for Vogue. The title was *'Youngest Congresswoman Ever'*. And since then, every story has tried to explain how I got here so fast. And the word that people kept eh… using was *'authentic'*, uhm."
Some people start clapping. It's not for long, Adora waves them down, because she wants to get to her point.
She tugs at the hem of her skirt. "But here's the problem. This isn't even my skirt. This skirt was selected for me by a group of specialists in Mystacor, New Jersey, who chose it over fourteen

other skirts we tested. In fact, our data suggested that I have to stick to either a skirt that is dark red, or a skirt that is dark blue. So creative, huh?", she grins lopsided and points with her thumb back over her shoulder at the very large flag of the US of A behind her. There's some chuckling down below, because, yeah, because people aren't dumb.
"A yellow skirt made it look as if I was taking my situation lightly, and I may in fact get into a bar fight again at any moment."
People laugh more, and when shooting a glance at the side where her folks stand, she sees that Glimmer looks… more and more concerned.
But Adora got this, and she smiles at her before turning back to the audience.

"A *silver* skirt meant that I'd forgotten my roots. Too aloof. My shoes… you know, shiny pumps we associate with high-priced lawyers and bankers. If you want to get a working woman's vote, you need to scuff up your shoes a little bit. But you can't scuff them up so much that you alienate the lawyers and the bankers, because you need them to pay for the specialists back in Mystacor."
Again, chuckles are to be heard, but the audience is gripped, taken. They are listening, eager, because everyone - everyone! - in this hall understands that Adora is speaking from her heart now. Without any fuzz. Without a veil. Just raw, as a person, not the politician.

She is just Adora now.

Glimmer is surely having a heart attack and will throw a fit at her for hours later on because Glimmers loves her from all her heart, but for now she has to take it, because Adora's listening to her gut - and her gut tends to be right.
The audience is intrigued.
"So what is the proper scuffing amount? Do you know we actually paid a consultant 7,300 Dollars… Was it 7,300, Glimmer?" Adora turns to Glimmer and the pink-haired woman is fidgeting with her hands, drawing lines over her throat and snapping for air, but she doesn't intervene.

Of course, tackling Adora down from the podium would look bad on the headlines.

Adora's not struggling when she takes off one of her pumps, which is a beautiful black piece of art that gives her another little advantage to her height, and holds it before herself. "7,300 Dollars for a consultant to tell us that *this* is the perfect amount of scuffing."
Cameras click, people stare in awe, and the mood of the hall is something completely different from before, when the *loss* was perceptible. Adora no longer gives a speech anymore, but she's talking to her friends, to her most important supporters, straight from the heart. To the people that will keep her back for the next years. When she's going for *another* campaign again. Adora talks for half an hour, and at the end, no one in the hall goes home with the feeling that Adora lost this election. They go home, conscious that this woman will come back, that she won't stop fighting, that they haven't been let down, despite the loss.

And they'll talk about it, because no one has experienced something like this in their lifetime. Adora is 28, and for the first time in her political career, she got knocked down. She got a punch in the gut, but she took harder ones in her life. And tomorrow she will get up again - as funny as the coincidence is, given her speech - because she is Adora Grayskull, and Adora Grayskull will never give up.

This may also be due to the fact that giving up is something that was never on the table for Adora Grayskull, because it isn't, and never was a part of the plan. The man and the woman with the gray hats who sit on the bench in the park before Adora's apartment building will continue in their endeavors to make sure of that.
Adora is *not allowed* to give up, she never was.

Now that they succeeded in getting Adora back on track after her mishap at the bar that caused this fucked-up mess, they are quite content with their work. What are a few more years in the grand scheme? They will make good use of them. The next time it will work according to plan.

Chapter End Notes

> The next chapter is called "The girl on the bus" and will be published next Friday, November 19th. As always, comments are greatly appreciated.

The girl on the bus

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"... for energy efficient technologies. Alliance Strategic Investment announced yesterday, that Adora Grayskull's going to become a senior partner with ASI. After failing to win last month's Senate election, she decided to join her former campaign manager and CEO of ASI, Glimmer Brightmoon. Both of them are expected to form a striking team on ASI's behalf, given their connections to politics and business alike. The leading investment company already has a renowned track record in the district. Brightmoon is a childhood friend of Grayskull and was the chairman of her unsuccessful senate campaign.
However, Grayskull's concession speech on election day was considered, by many, to be electrifying and has made her the obvious candidate for the next Senate race. People attending described it to be the most compelling speech they ever heard, and it sparked great support within the party. Meanwhile…"

The phone rings, it's Glimmer, and so she chimes into it: "Hey Glim!"
Her happy approach rightfully earns her a groan. "Ugh… I hate getting up early. Just wanted to remind you that Mermista Seaworthy's assistant calls you in a few minutes, for the appointment. If you get her investing with us, I'll buy you a pony."
"What shall I do with a pony?" Adora asks with a frown.
"Whatever. Just gave her your number."
"Ah, yeah, thanks, I'll take care of it. Give her my private number, I'm not carrying two phones around, okay?"
Glimmer scoffs and Adora can literally see how she furrows her brows: "No, I can't!? You'll talk about business related stuff, joining ASI, her investment and such. Business stuff has to be done on a company phone, you know that."
"Do I?" Adora asks, while she fumbles with her damn pair of tights, because she had the dumbness to opt for a skirt today. It

nearly lets her fall off the bed, as she squeezes the phone between her shoulder and cheek.
"Sarbanes-Oxley? I mean, you voted for that, gal. In fact, you even co-sponsored its revision last year, Adora. Stars, were you actually a Congresswoman during the last years, or was this just some kind of scheme to allure pretty brunettes?"
"Glim!"
"Adora!"
She feels caught. Yeah, she actually did co-sponsor it, but it seems like that is something that happened so long ago. But on the other hand, after more fumbling she finally got her tights up and now slips into a white blouse and a blue jacket.
"Ok, I remember. But hey, I just saw you on TV." Glimmer's always easily to distract when it comes to her being on the media, and Adora is not shy to use this. Being cunning may not be her strength, but that doesn't mean that she won't use any advantage to stop Glimmer breathing down her neck.
"Really?"
"Yeah!"
"What did they say?"
Adora giggles. "Your hair's so rainbowy. Which was weird, too, because it was a financial show. But they were really captivated by your changing hair colors." Glimmer groans upon the mockery.
"Yeah, thank you, I got to go, you idiot."
Proud of herself and being so backhanded - for Adora - she giggles more, says "Bye", and they end the call.

Adora takes the bus. Besides that it's just the clever thing to do, because of the shitshow that is *downtown Manhattan traffic*, walking to the bus station and using the public transport has always been a good way to avoid taking off, to stay grounded, and just to get outside a bit. She always went by foot, back in Red Hook, and when she moved right around to Madison Square Park, she wanted to keep this habit. Breathing in the morning air - okay, the city air - was always calming, Madison Park is really nice to walk through in the morning, and she admired the sight of the Flatiron Building. She avoids walking past it when wearing a skirt because the treacherous wind currents around the building still

tend to blow them up unexpectedly. A picture of her exposed butt is something she doesn't really need, especially after what ruined her election. And she clearly isn't Marilyn.
Also, occasionally having a little chat with passers-by, *voters* in the park, has been another reason. Not that this is important now, because her political career is on a hold for the moment, but she stays with the habit and her new office is just a few bus stops away. Buying a car for riding it four kilometers a day would be just idiotic, and ASI is actually an investment company that *invests in environmental* acceptable projects.

Despite the call she's not late, because Adora is never late, nor is she early, but she arrives precisely when she means to. So, she gets herself a coffee at the coffee stand in front of the park, which the fellow nicely fills into her own cup, and immediately walks into the occasional stranger. She stops as an elderly man greets her friendly: "Congresswoman! I have to tell you, I really admire you for your speech last month. In my humble opinion, it's a pity you didn't win. Such a waste, really."
"Oh, thank you very much," Adora replies kindly, smiles, and means it. She always liked these short interactions, even if it's not so important right now.
"I wish there would be more politicians like you, madam," the man says.
"Thank you, but I'm retired for now. Had to get a real job." She winks.
He laughs shortly and tips his head. "You'll do well, ma'am. Next elections will surely come. We count on you." She nods gratefully, and they part, each one to hurry forward into the day.

"The Girl on the Bus" (Deezer / Spotify)

She notices a tanned man in a gray suit and an alike hat, who's sitting on a bank, seemingly sleeping. He has a little notebook in his hands, and dozes. He will only wake up two minutes later, when a ray of sun which falls through the leaves above him hit his eyes. Then, Adora has already got onto the bus. He will be angry with himself then, because he missed his duty to prevent exactly that, and then he'll start running after the bus, but he won't catch

up. It will set in a series of events, like a badly timed snowball initiates an avalanche. It will be a threat to the plan.

Balancing her coffee cup in one hand, Adora enters the bus and looks for an empty seat. There is one three rows further, beside a sleeping woman.
A familiar woman.
Brunette.
Curls.
“No way. You've got to be kidding me,” it slips out of her mouth. Because there she is: the woman with the cat tattoo and the kissable lips. She’s dozing, her head laying against the window, and she looks adorable. Adora gets a smile on her face and her heart makes a jump. She carefully lowers herself on the seat beside the woman she’d been thinking about so many times in the last month, and didn’t even imagine meeting another time and yet, here she is, Cat-girl, sleeping, looking so kissable again.
The woman stirs, presumably sensing the presence of someone next to her, and wakes up with a little groan. She turns her head towards Adora, who’s already looking at her with a very large smile, then Cat-girl’s eyes pulls wide, and she mouths: “Oh, my god.”

Adora grins a lot, as she asks mockingly: “Have we met?”
It earns her a wide smirk and a tease: “You look vaguely familiar, yeah.”
“Waldorf men’s room!" she shoots back.
“You got it,” and then: “Were you just staring at my legs while I slept?”
Adora absolutely was, and she doesn’t deny anything: “I was defenseless against the small… dress there.”
“It’s a skirt,” the woman waves it away, chuckling and Adora huffs: “It’s a belt,” because it’s exactly that. Cat-girl’s skirt is so short that it barely covers her hip and a few centimeters down of them. If her legs weren’t covered by some disturbingly transparent black pantyhose, it would be outright scandalous. Actually, it’s still scandalous. Beguiling scandalous. The woman is laughing, and Adora want’s to kiss her right there, but that may not be

appropriate without forewarning and such, and so she just asks what she wanted to ask since the Waldorf.
“What is it with you and the cat tattoo?”
She gets no answer, because the woman counters: “What is the deal with you and the boring shades of blue?”
“My clothes match?” Adora argues and tugs at the hem of her jacket, because they do. She looks professional, and that’s about it. Also, it’s not that she spends hours of thinking about her clothing every day, like Glimmer presumably does. She’s more the practical type when it comes to that.
“Did your team pick that out for you?”
“No team, team’s gone,” Adora replies with the slightest hint of chagrin. It gets her a simple “Wow,” to which she answers: “I did it all by myself.”
Cat-girl changes the topic. She’s quick with that, it seems: “I saw your speech. Quite a hit on Youtube, huh?”
“Yeah, the speech,” Adora murmurs. “Something must have gotten into me, huh?”
“You don’t say? Judging from the comments, you must be the idol of every single in New York, I would say. Maybe the married too.”
They look at each other, sinking into their stare and Adora knows, they are thinking the same. It’s...

Adora’s phone starts ringing, and it is loud. She wonders why it’s ringing at all, because who on earth has this number already? It’s her first day with ASI, and she’s yet to be introduced to everybody. And Glimmer would call her on her private phone.
“Wow, that is something,” Cat-girl mocks her, and Adora makes an apologetic smile. “Really augments the moment,” she says and takes it quickly out of her pocket to silence it at least. The number is unknown, a glance at the display shows, so she just answers it with a “Hello?” But nobody speaks. “Hello? Hello?” There’s only silence.
She puts it down. “Didn’t even work,” she says and adds, “it’s a new phone.”
Cat-girl looks at her and snarls: “Could that ring get any louder, or do you have that maxed out?”
Adora chuckles and pockets the thing again, still a bit irritated

about the call. So she's rather unprepared when Cat-girl asks: "Are you gonna go to run again?"
"Don't know. I'm starting a new job today."
"Oh man! You have to run again, you can't do that, the country will end up being run by tools like Hordak."
"Kinda is." And despite the reply is just automatic, the typical blah-blah you give to supporters and people who already like you, Adora actually believes that she could've made a difference. That - as pathetic and presumptuous as this may sound - her service would be for the better for all of them than having some idiot - she giggles mentally - like Hordak in charge. She hasn't lied about that she doesn't know yet. Today, she's starting a new job, but that doesn't mean that she's out of the race. She still wants to matter, and in one year, many things will happen.
Huh, fuck it. It doesn't need a year. Many things can happen in ten minutes. Ten minutes before, she hadn't even thought about the possibility of meeting Cat-girl again, and yet here she is, right by her side. It's like fate and already made this day great, and maybe it can get even better if she gets her number. "Can I have __"

Something jolts at Adora's wrist and makes her spill some of her coffee over Cat-girl's very, very short belt, uhm, skirt, and her thighs. Luckily, it's not hot anymore.
"Sorry! I don't know what just happened," Adora apologizes in a fluster, and she really doesn't. She didn't do anything. "I'll pay for the cleaning."
"No, it's really fine," the brunette replies, and maybe it should be okay, because when she rummages through her purse, all Adora finds are seven dollars. It's typical. She's still used to have people taking care of this stuff, and she really needs to change that habit sooner than later. As she said, the team is gone.
"Seven bucks will probably cover it?" she jokes lightly, making Cat-girl giggle again, and thinks that she could do this all day long.
"You keep that, you might need it more than I."
Adora has a great idea. "You know what? Here." Adora hands her a card upside down. "You write your number down, then I can call you and come pick up your skirt. Or, whatever." She grins her best

grin while doing so and is so proud of herself, even if it's fucking obvious, and is rewarded with another smug smile. "Oh, my goodness, me. That is very smooth. Why don't you let me spill some on you, and then we'll be even?"
"That's a terrible idea," Adora fake-terrified replies.
But Cat-girl doesn't give up easily, it seems. "I think it's a great idea. Just one bit because that's not fair!" The then stringy woman tries to go for real and grabs Adora's coffee cup, making Adora call: "You actually are crazy," while they scuffle for it.
"No, now it all makes sense," the woman laughs, then Adora's phone goes off another time, and Cat-girl snitches the noisy phone out of Adora's hand with a quick draw.
"Okay, hang on. Oh, goddess!" Adora doesn't know if she should be annoyed or enticed, and watches in disbelief as Cat-girl takes the call and says without listening: "She's not here. I know, I'm sorry," then ends the call immediately, making Adora demand loudly, "Who was that?"
"I don't know. Who cares?" A shit-eating grin plasters the brunette's face who's still holding Adora's phone.
Adora wants to… "It'll be on the… Can you just…"
"NO!"
Adora tries to sound a little bit upset or at least serious enough to be taken so when she says: "Okay, now we're in the third grade. This is great," but Cat-girl only cackles at her. And it makes Adora smile so much she can't believe it. This is so… fucking sweet. She. She is.
Adora's phone goes off another time and in an instant, Cat-girl puts it into Adora's coffee cup with a *blubb.* The phone doesn't give up ringing despite being drowned, and the woman says: "Eh, it's a sturdy little fucker, isn't it."
Adora can't believe it, her mouth falls agape, and she glares at the madwoman with widened eyes. Did she just throw her phone into her coffee cup? What. The. Hell?
The lunatic beside her apologizes giggling: "I'm sorry. I don't know what happened, it just happened. So, why don't we move on?" And no, she isn't sorry, and again, this smile she has on her face and with which she grins at Adora, it's just making her so warm and light, she can't be even mad at the woman. This is

ridiculous.
Adora takes the soaked phone out of the cup, holding it between thumb and index finger. “Okay, that was a new phone. Let’s wipe it off.” And then she wipes it off at Cat-girl’s belt, uhm, skirt and smirks devilishly with a broad grin.
The woman looks at her with narrowed eyes for a moment, seemingly stunned by Adora’s malicious move, then she breaks out in a laughter, and when she finally dies down, she says: “I’m Catra, by the way.”
“I’ll surely remember that,” Adora smirks back. They grin at each other and again, Adora wants to kiss Cat-girl right there. Catra! She wants to kiss Catra. Can’t, obviously, that would be reckless.

But then she makes the smart move, by taking out a pen from her bag, handing it over to Cat-girl - Catra and asks: “Your number?”
The alluring madwoman scribbles her number on the card Adora gave her before the little mishap. Handing it back to Adora, she says, “That’s my number.”
And Adora is glad. Super, super glad. That’s the best thing that happened to her since… whenever. “Terrific. Thank you.”

Catra motions Adora to stand up. “My stop,” she says, as the bus approaches the next station, and adds mockingly, “and I have to get a new belt.” Adora grins until they come to a halt and Catra steps out on the street and turns around.

Adora has followed her to the exit, and says, “I’ll call you,” only first, but when the doors start to close, she blurts out what lingered in her mind the whole time: “The morning after the election, I woke up thinking about you!”
It just tumbles out of her, and Cat-girl - Catra goddammit - looks stunned for a split-second, her facial expression shortly derailed with a hint of awe, then she smiles, then the doors are slammed shut, then Catra smirks, and she finally flips Adora a middle finger, mockingly, presumably.

The bus starts moving and Adora lets out a deep sigh. *Wow!* Had she been too bold to say that? Maybe that comment had been too much, overstepping even. But then again, she gave Adora her

number, didn't she? Adora looks down at the card and realizes that she has her number, she can call her! Not right now, because that would be awkward and… yeah… too early, too fast, but she can call her. Tonight! No, tomorrow would be better. At the weekend would make most sense, wouldn't it? But… maybe, a message tonight? Just to make sure that it's the right number, and that it's in her phone?
Turning the card in her hands around and around, the spike of angsty feeling is quickly covered by joy. Adora has cat-girl's number, and now she even knows her name! Catra. *Huh?* Cat-girl's name is Catra. How… fitting, she only gets now.

Back on her place, she remembers her private phone - the one not soaked in coffee - quickly calls Glimmer and is greeted with "Hey woman, what's up? We have a meeting in, like, half an hour."
Adora blurts: "You're not going to believe who I just ran into."
"Who?"
"The girl from election night."
"WHOA! TELL ME EVERYTHING!"
Adora has to shush Glimmer down, because she's still on the bus, and even the driver should be able to hear her now, given the volume. Glimmer asks a little quieter, still buzzing in excitement: "The one you kissed?"
"She kissed me!" Adora uselessly tries to defend herself, but it's not convincing anyone.
"You're still sticking with that story?" Glimmer mocks her.
"It's the truth," she doubles down, knowing it's a blatant lie.
"Tell that to yourself, girl, I know what I saw. You were like octopuses in a mating dance." And when Glimmer decides for relentlessness, Adora can just change the topic.
"What are the odds, Glimmer? It's amazing."
"That's great Adora. Just don't take her advice on speeches anymore, okay? First time worked, it's not going to work again."
Adora giggles because that's bold. "Awww. Are you actually jealous because it's the best speech I ever gave, and you didn't write it?"
Glimmer laughs. "I demand all dirty little secrets tonight", then changes the topic herself, because there is work to do: "Just so

you know, I think I'm coming down against your solar panel thing."
"Why?" Adora's genuinely surprised. She worked that project out the last two weeks, and was positive about the acceptance by Glimmer and the rest of ASI's strategic investment team. She knows the supplier from her campaign visits, how to gather some governmental research funding, and the project would be a fitting introduction of herself into the investment scene.
"I just don't think the research is there where it has to be, and the price point is too high on these things? We need more margin on that to keep up, girl. This stuff doesn't work like sprinkling taxpayer's money on it with a watering can."
Adora groans. "Of course it's too high, you idiot. But if we don't get involved in this, who will? Mass production will cut your precious price point down to a fifth of the current one, even if we don't go to China with it. Robotization will do that, that's how this works today. You remember the factory we visited in Buffalo? I made that pretty clear in my resume, which you should've read."
"Convince me in the meeting," Glimmer says, indicating that she has, and Adora knows, it's going to be a hard fight. "I will. See ya buddy."

Glimmer's announcement dims the mood a bit, but all in all, Adora's sure she can convince the folks. She knows most of them already, and after a discussion, they'll surely see it her way. Adora doesn't yet know that the hard fight won't be about this. Because she didn't miss the bus, as the man with the gray hat that ran after her was supposed to make sure of. But he hasn't, so she didn't, so she's two buses too early.
It's only ten minutes, but unfortunately ten minutes is a lot of time.

Adora arrives at the headquarters of ASI which is located on three floors of a ridiculous tall skyscraper in the financial district of downtown Manhattan, walks through the glass doors, takes the elevator to the 18th floor and leaves on the ping. She's in a hurry now, because the meeting will start soon, and she wants to take down a few more notes to convince the other team members of

her investment idea. Glimmer giving her a notice up front was actually nice, but now she has little time left to prepare, though.

Square One Reset (Deezer / Spotify)

Because she's in a rush, she doesn't really notice how quiet everyone is. Actually, the other people aren't moving at all. Adora greets Janet at the counter absent-mindedly, walks down a few steps to the floor where the conference room lays, passes Susan at the reception before it and greets her as well. Susan doesn't greet her back.

Back in her mind, Adora wonders why everything is so quiet, but she rushes forward into the meeting room. There are her fellows, colleagues, Glimmer… and half a dozen weird men and women in black suits and with gray hats, using strange-looking devices pointed at all of her future fellows. Glimmer looks frozen, and this feels threatening, all of this.
She hears one of them saying: "We just got approval for a recalibration on the Lasalle case." Another one voices loudly: "Two minutes!" and she hears her phone call with Glimmer from minutes before being replayed, her own voice saying: "But if we don't get involved with stuff like this, who will?"
Her voice sounds weird to herself, but then she sees how someone holds an odd stick at Glimmer's head, and she yells: "Hey, what the hell you're doing to her?!"
On the other side of the long table, a black-haired woman with long tails looks up from a talk with a collaborator of hers, sees Adora and is obviously fucking surprised, but she quickly gathers herself.

She points at Adora: "Grab her!"
Several of the black suited henchmen start to approach her.

Adora spins and runs, back through the hallway. WHAT THE HELL? She's chased by the people in the black uniforms, some of them wear helmets like a SWAT commando, but these guys aren't SWAT, that much she knows. Adora paces past Susan who hasn't moved yet, jumps up the stairs back to the hallway, past Janet

and calls at her "911, Janet, 911!!", but Janet doesn't react also. In fact, Janet seems frozen in time, doesn't move a bit. She's still holding the telephone in the same position as a minute before.
"Oh shit," Adora gasps, and gets it. Janet is… no help. She runs further down a hallway, when suddenly the woman with the hat approaches her from the front, coming out of a room.
How is that even possible? "You can't get away, Adora!," the woman says in a relaxed way.

Adora spins around, runs down another hallway to the side, followed by two of the henchmen, and it's right before a crossing where the woman is *again* coming towards her again, now leaning on the wall like a casual bystander. WHAT THE FUCK HAPPENS HERE?
"Adora, I really wish you'd just listen to me," she hears her saying, but the hell Adora will do, being chased by weird, threatening looking strangers that somehow were able to take over and freeze… what? Freeze?

She reaches Glimmer's office, hammers the door shut and locks it, then checks for the other door that leads into a conference room besides, and locks that as well. Now she trapped herself, because it's a corner office, but Adora guesses she's safe for a few seconds. So she jumps to the desk, takes the phone and tries to get a line. To no avail. Dead. Fucking nothing. Silence.
She gasps, and rings for air, but now the door is being knocked at, and the voice of the strange woman calls: "Adora! You really are making this harder than it has to be!"

It distracted her for a second while she leans against the door, making sure it stays shut. So she is a second too late to note that behind her, the door to the conference room is unlocking, and she's also too late to stop the henchmen pushing it open. Two, three, four of them pour into the office and immediately tackle Adora down to the floor. They don't have faces, because they're masked, and all of them wear black gloves, but there's a man with a gray hat, and he has a piece of cloth in his hands.
"All right, take it easy, guys. Take it easy." Adora's hands are held down, her body is pressed to the ground, she grunts in pain and

struggles hard, screams “NO!”, but then the man puts the cloth on her mouth and nose.
Chloroform. They want to drug her, she has to…
“It’s okay Adora. Just breathe, it’s okay.”
Everything happens so quick. She’s panting so hard, and her head is spinning, her limps feel so numb, everything dulls quick, gets black, and then she’s just out.

“Yes ma’am. Yes. Yes, it’s being taken care of. No ma’am. I understand. I’ll take care of it.”
The bright voice is the one of the woman with the hat, who ordered to grab her.
Adora takes in her surrounding, and gets that she’s sitting on a lonely chair in a large parking deck, or a water storage or whatever the fuck this weird bunker should be. There’s no light beside that of the bulbs hanging down, and the walls, floors and ceiling are all concrete. She stills feel dizzy, but she’s getting it back together by the second. But, *ugh*, the taste in her mouth is... bah, bad.

The talking woman is somewhere behind Adora and talks to someone beside her. Adora can’t see both of them very well, because her sight is still blurry, and she has to twist her neck to be able to look around, which is painful. But there’s also the man with the hat who had benumbed her. He stands before Adora, a few meters away, and is fidgeting with his hat.

In the background, a dozen henchmen surround them, a few behind the man, the others around her in a circle. It’s a threatening feeling, being surrounded by so many armed and masked people, all of them looking very serious. As she follows the conversation, Adora gets the sense that the talking women behind here are the one’s in charge.

“What a mess,” the woman groans, and the other woman with the hat asks: “Upstairs?” The first one nods, and she asks: “What do you wanna do, Casta?
The woman called Casta answers, “We have to reset her. Call for a

briefcase."
"You're kidding? It's going to take a signed order from the Chairman."
"Well, get legal on it," Casta demands loudly, and Adora looks at the man before her, who has a very worried face now.

Loud steps from somewhere behind in the hall approach them. This figure came seemingly out of nowhere, but Adora gets a feeling that this is something that these weird people just can do. She can only see the form of the newcomer, it's just the impression out of the corner of her eye, but the woman is dressed in a flowing dark cloak, has hair of the same color, and a mask that covers her face.

When she speaks up, her voice is piercing and also a bit frightening as she calls upon the others: "Legal just arrived. There's no way the Chairman approves a reset of Grayskull. This is your fault. There's no way you get a briefcase. We need her to stay on plan."
Casta, still before Adora, groans and walks around her to approach the other woman, asking her: "Ugh! What are my options?"
"Hey," Adora shouts and tries to turn her head, but is completely ignored by everyone.
"Just bullshit her," the woman says.
"Bullshit this one?", Casta asks, but it's not a question.
The conversation riles said Adora up. "Hey, what's going on here?" she asks again, with the same result. They don't even recognize her.
"Look at this," Casta seemingly shuffles through her notebook, because Adora can hear the paper turning, while she explains: "The questions will burn in her until the day she dies. She won't stop searching for an answer. She won't quit. Here, and here, and here. See? We literally have to watch her forever, make sure she doesn't talk, doesn't search for her, doesn't deviate. Endless ripple effects. This will be hell."
The other woman's voice is low and firm when she asks: "You remember the *Mara case* 40 years ago?"
Casta is seemingly shocked, because her voice is flattened. "Wow.

It’s not that bad?” but after a few seconds, she adds, “Is it?”
“In the end, they just leveled with her,” the other woman states.
“Completely?”
“Looking at that,” and Adora just feels how she’s pointed at while she struggles with her ties very obviously, “I don’t see you have a choice.” The comment gets a huff from Casta. “Choice, huh? That’s… ironic, isn’t it?”
Still, Adora feels completely neglected, which she actually is. The whole conversation in her back about *herself* doesn’t involve her. These people are just talking over her head, and that makes her angry. So, she shouts: “What the hell are you guys.”

Finally, it gets the woman named Casta acknowledging her. She places herself in front of Adora and grins at her with a condescending smile. “We are the people who make sure things happen according to plan. My name is… you can call me Casta.”
“Oh,” Adora breaths, then she jumps and starts running towards a door. The ties are still binding her hands, but she can surely run. Would be a laugh if she couldn’t outrun these guys. She’s fast, and the folks behind her aren't really going for a charge.

Turns out, they don’t have to. Before her, a tile of the ground shifts, making her trip *hard*. She lands on her chest and hands. “Ow. Ugh.” That hurt, and she has to catch her breath. The dizziness from before returns.
Suddenly, she’s been dragged by two henchmen back into the chair she sat before and pushed down not too softly. These henchmen don’t fuss around.
“You really think I couldn’t see that coming?” Casta huffs. “I can read your mind, uh huh, yeah, really. Pick a color? Blue. Pick a number. Seventeen. Now, why are you still thinking about running?”
Adora stares at her in disbelief. This can’t just be. The woman looks literally in her mind, clearly reading her thoughts. How can that be? She pants and gasps, maybe she’s still dreaming, knocked out from the Chloroform. Or maybe the whole day is just a weird dream, and she never woke up in the first place?
“I don’t really know what’s going on here.”

Casta huffs again. “You’ve just seen behind a curtain that you weren’t supposed to know existed in the first place. Must be jarring, I know, and it’s not your fault. Your path through the world this morning was supposed to have been *adjusted*.” She looks at the tanned man before Adora, who still fidgets with his hat and rolls his eyes now. ”You were supposed to spill your coffee as you entered the park this morning. Then you would’ve gone back upstairs to change, you would have missed the bus, and you would’ve arrived at work ten minutes later than you actually did, and we would’ve been gone.”

Casta had emphasized the words ‘ten minutes’ very much, like they are important, but Adora can only think of one thing. “I was supposed to spill my coffee?” It sounds so misplaced, so unreal, and it reminds her of spilling her coffee over Catra’s thighs. What has that to do with anything?
“We call that an adjustment,” Casta nods, and she’s a bit kinder than before. “See, sometimes, when people spill their coffee or their internet goes out, or… or they misplaced their keys, they think it’s chance. And sometimes it is, but sometimes it’s us. Nudging people back on plan.” Her tone gets more serious. “Sometimes when nudging isn’t enough, management authorizes a recalibration. We deploy our intervention team, and they change your mind for you, like we did with your friend Glimmer.” While talking, Casts scurried around Adora and circled her, but now she comes to halt in front of her and crouches down on her heels. For some reason, it feels a bit threatening, that she is so near.
“She’s fine, by the way. You don’t need to worry about her. Now... there is something I need you to understand if I’m going to let you go.
“Okay.” As if Adora could say something else. She still has little clue what’s going on here, but she’ll take her chances.
“Very few humans have seen what you’ve seen today, and we’re determined to keep it that way, so, if you ever reveal our existence, we’ll erase your brain. The intervention team will reset you. Your emotions, your memories, your entire personality will be expunged. Your friends and family will think you’ve gone crazy. *You, you* won’t think anything.”

She stands up. “You understand?”
Adora nods.
“Not *one* word about us,” Casta emphasizes.
Adora nods again. Slowly. And says: “Okay.” Are these people idiots? She told her all of that, and now they’re just letting her go?
Casta, on the other side, seems pretty content with herself. “Oh, one more thing. You bumped into a woman this morning on the bus. Catra?”
Adora doesn’t really get the question, but it unsettles her immediately. “What does that have to do with anything?”
“Well, you were never supposed to see her again.”
That… that can’t be, and the bad feeling suddenly has a very real reason. “What does that matter?”
“Because it matters,” Casta just replies, and that’s no answer, but Adora doesn’t get any other.
“It’s in her jacket,” the other woman with the nearly white hair says.
Quickly, Adora’s taken by two of the henchmen, dragged up, and her arms are bowed backwards, while the woman who spoke last reaches for her jacket. Adora calls, “Hey, hey. Stars. Hey!”, and as the woman takes out the card with Catra’s number, she shoots an apologetic look at Adora, but hands it over to Casta immediately.
“Oh, come on,” Adora shouts, and when Casta sets the card on fire with a lighter, she yells. “No! No! What the hell?”
The card goes up in flames, erasing Catra’s number forever. “What the hell?” she repeats, “Really? Why?”
Casta looks at her again. “Okay. Don’t search for her. Enjoy the rest of your day. And, you know, Fight Club rule number one.”
“Ugh! Did you really say that?” She’s pushed forward by the henchmen. “I can walk. I’m capable of walking,” she shouts, but to no avail. The men push her through the very door from before, and she stumbles back into the office, tripping and landing on the floor on her stomach.

Behind her, the doors closes, only to be opened again *one - fucking - second - later* by Glimmer, who rushes in and looks down on her incredulously. She has a very questioning expression on her face, furrows her brows and wrinkles her nose. “Girl, what are

you doing on my floor? You know, I called you like ten times, you could've picked up."

Adora's not really sure if this is a dream or reality. It should be reality, because her hands and knees hurt from tripping and typically, you don't feel pain in your dreams. But this doesn't feel like reality, because everything's so unreal.
Glimmer takes out her phone, calls her assistant, saying: "I found her, round up the fellows, we're going to do the meeting now." Then she takes Adora's hand, helping her up. Adora closes the door Glimmer came in, opens it again, but everything is just normal. No hall behind, no weird people with hats, just the floor. She repeats her action, but nothing changes.
Glimmer requests, "What the hell are you doing, Adora?" but gets no answer. Instead, Adora asks: "You have a headache?" She remembers how these folks messed with Glimmer's head - her brain, presumably, given what she heard - and there just must be something leftover from that. Mustn't it?
"What's wrong with you?" Glimmer replies, and sounds like she doubts Adora's brain. "Are you brain-damaged?"
Adora opens and closes the door again in a ridiculous attempt to get another result than in the first tries, but of course nothing changes. Glimmer takes her hand and drags her into the hallway. "We're in the big conference room on 17. Let's go."

When they walk down the stairs and pass the reception, Adora's greeted - finally - by Susan, who has awakened from her freeze. "Morning, Congresswoman." Adora can't help but to stare at the woman, and Glimmer notices it. "You sure you're okay?"
Adora gets that she needs to calm herself and get ready for the meeting, because obviously, she seems to be the only one who has experienced what actually happened. And she shall shut up about what happened.
Or is she just going to be crazy? Maybe the last few weeks were too much for her? But then again, she met Catra. Today! And now she doesn't have her number anymore. The emptiness inside the pocket of her jacket is a very palpable proof of what happened. No, she's not crazy. But she can investigate this later on. Now's

time for business, the other stuff can wait.
Presumably.

"Yeah," she replies, and adds, "You?"
Glimmer looks at her, pursing her lips a little. "I'm great, why?
"You don't have a headache or anything?" Adora glances at her from the side, and Glimmer seems to be okay. She's like always, a bit bossy and full of energy.
"No, I feel fantastic, woman. Is it me or is this an odd conversation?" This makes Adora shut up, because she doesn't want to sound weird, and they have a meeting right before themselves. So she just shrugs, then they reach the conference room.

Minutes later they are in the middle of their meeting, talking about Adora's initial project, and she barely listens. Luckily, she doesn't really have to, because Glimmer has her back.
One woman comes down against with all the concerns she already knew were coming: "On Adora's solar panel deal, our tech fellows have serious doubts about the efficiency ratings they're claiming. They'd need a 20-fold improvement over anything anyone else has been able to manufacture at that price point to really be a game-changer."

Another fellow cuts in: "You're opposed to this anyway, Glimmer. And with these financial—"
There, Glimmer cuts in unexpectedly: "Whoa, whoa, I know it's a risk, but, if our company doesn't take a chance on something like this, then who will? I mean, I'm willing to take a fire on something that could… uh, change the world."
Adora looks up at her friend, her eyes piercing her quizzically, but Glimmer just walks around and babbles further. "Not to mention, be incredibly lucrative." Glimmer glances at Adora, questioning her, "Adora?"
"Yeah. I mean, that's why I took the job here," she just replies, rather quiet, because all of this is totally weird. An hour ago, Glimmer wanted to shoot this down, and now?
Glimmer looks just fine when she says: "All right. Let's do it."

Cool, huh? Glim just approved a two-hundred-million-dollar investment that Adora suggested. And that will help the environment. And possibly make them money. A lot. Like, a fucking lot, if the panels will work the way they've been promised. The problem for Adora is that all of what Glimmer just said sounds exactly like something Glimmer would say. The woman has always been willing to take a risk, get herself into trouble, to rumble. The damned woman presumably didn't even know the meaning of *stand-down*.
Unfortunately, Adora also knew very well that these words weren't Glimmer's. They'd been Adora's, from before *the adjustment*. And even if she got her project approved, and they were going to do a good thing, and it's all fine: she doesn't like the taste of it, though. And so she can't feel much joy and stays very quiet.

The meeting has ended and Adora walks at Glimmers side, back to her office, when Glimmer asks: "Come into my office for a second?" Adora nods and follows her, though she has a bad feeling about it.
As a CEO, of course, Glimmer has one of the nice corner offices. It overlooks a good part of downtown Manhattan, and the Hudson River, but on the other side, it's not that this is extraordinary. Around them, other skyscrapers rise up high. One World Trade Center isn't far away, lurking over everything else around. Glimmer props herself on her own desk and stares at Adora fiercely. "Something's wrong. A couple of hours ago, you miraculously reunite with the girl of your dreams. Explain to me why you don't have an ear-to-ear grin right now?"
Oh! It's about that. Glimmer still remembers her talk. Of course, she does, Adora scolds herself. She only doesn't remember being frozen and *adjusted*, of course, but besides that, all seems well with her. And Adora told her about the encounter with Catra. Only that she can't tell Glimmer what happened then. What really happened. That she hasn't Catra's number anymore. That she has been told to not search for her. The fuck. Fuck Fuck. Fuck.

Adora fumbles nervously with her fingers under Glimmer's gaze. "I lost Catra's number."
"What?"

"The woman on the bus. Her name's Catra, and I lost her phone number, and all I have is her first name, so, I'm never going to see her again."
"Oh." Glimmer's stare falters, and now she looks apologetic, worried. They've been friends like, forever, and she got how enticed Adora has been of the mysterious woman she never thought to see again after *the event* one month earlier. They talked about it, like a lot, and Glimmer got it. "Oh, I'm sorry." She wraps Adora in her arms. "I'm really sorry. That is… unfortunate." Adora tries not to cry upon the sudden embrace, but she's grateful for Glimmer's care. Their friendship had been rough sometimes, but they always had each other's back whenever really needed. Maybe now she'll need it more than ever, despite the fact that she can't exactly let Glimmer know why.

A month has passed since Adora had been dragged into a mysterious, dark, concrete hall where revelations had been made that shattered her view on the world and which she isn't allowed to share with anyone.
And she doesn't. She'd always been good at keeping secrets about herself from everyone, and now she carries this newest one, and tries not to think about it. Because if she does, the world seems like a place that is darker and more controlled than before she knew. She always thought that knowing things was better than not. But in this case…

Besides that, she *tries* to remember Catra's number from the two glimpses she threw on the card from when she still had it.
The work of the day is done, and like so often in these past few weeks, she's sitting at the bar of Brooklyn Ice House. The nice little corner bar in the middle of Red Hook is one of her eldest hiding spots. Her familiarity with the place goes way back into her teenage years, when it became a point of meeting friends for a drink, for dating, and a round of playing darts or whatever. Today,

she knows the bartenders and the owner by name and whenever she needs to collect herself just for an hour or so and is nearby, she takes place at the bar for a beer and sometimes a burger or else.
For the last few weeks, Adora is in dire need to collect herself. So here she is, alone, and tries to remember.

But it doesn’t work. It hasn’t for the whole time.

What contributes to the blur in her memory is her drinking. She’s sitting at the wooden bar and today, she has just a cup of coffee before herself, unlike other times, when it’s a Samuel Adams Boston Lager. The ale isn’t strong enough to make her drunk, even three of them aren’t. But the occasional shots she gets afterwards, when it becomes late, clearly are. She’s not addicted enough to getting herself really wasted, and it doesn't show, not yet, but she has taken the first steps on this certain kind of road.

Knowing things sometimes just doesn’t help.
Sometimes, knowing is outright devastating. Knowing is dangerous.

Adora sighs, while she scribbles around at the paper, her head in her hand and the elbow propped on the bar. She knows about her helplessness, and she also knows that she isn’t doing well. And can’t do anything against it, though. She’s weak, at least on most of the days. Today, she’s a little less weak, so she sticks with the coffee. And tomorrow… will be another day.

This behavior of hers hasn’t gone unnoticed.
So it’s no chance when suddenly a stranger approaches the place beside her, and when she looks at him, it’s the man with the gray hat.
“Your entire world is turned upside down, and you’re thinking about a woman.” He puts down his hat on the counter, then takes place, leaving one free seat between them. His tanned skin doesn't really match with the gray hat and suit, and he has a

friendly face. It's a distinction from the other ones, was it even back in the hall. Adora senses that he wants to give her some space, to make her not feel threatened. It only works half-way, because being ambushed in her bar just like that doesn’t bode well, though.
He points at the paper Adora had been scribbling on. “Even if you could remember the number, you’ll never get through. Lost cell phone, changed numbers, lines not working. We know how to do our stuff. Mostly.” He smiles a bit. “My name’s Bow, by the way. I’m the one responsible for the failed coffee adjustment."

Adora takes a breath. “You were in the park, on the morning I ran into Catra on the bus. I remember you sleeping there.”
Bow nods. “Yeah, dozed away. Didn’t wake up until you were already on the bus. That was… my fault. I’m sorry for that. We could’ve spared so many ripples if I’d just done my job right.” He sounds genuinely sorry. "We always try to cause the fewest ripples."
“The fewest ripples?” Adora shakes her head slowly and tries not to shout. “Yeah, didn't work so well, obviously. You freeze people, for fucks sake. You froze my friend.”
“It wasn’t that bad. And we need special authorization to—"
“...poke around in people’s brains? What the fuck? You make them think whatever you want…?”
He frowns, waves her down and mouths: “Be quiet, Adora,” then orders water from the bartender, then replies: “Your friend will be fine. Recalibrations make tiny changes in the way people reason. It doesn’t work on emotion or personality. That’s too intrusive."
“You said authorization. Authorization from who?
Bow looks up with his eyes shortly as he says: “The Chairman.”
“The Chairman,” Adora parrots way too loud and is shushed by Bow immediately. “That’s just a name we use. You use many other names.” He sighs shortly, and Adora can’t really comprehend it. Is he really talking about what she thinks he’s talking about? It can’t… it can’t be. No. No way. Because if, it would mean—

“We can’t talk here,” Bow adds quietly, and drags out a prospect of a tourist ferry that travels around the Hudson River. “Meet me on the 5 pm boat, and I’ll answer what I can.”

Adora is a bit surprised, because she hasn't expected an offer like that. But just to ruin it, of course, he has to continue with a threat: "If you reveal us, even if it's unintentional—"
"I know, You'll bump me on the head," she scoffs, frustrated, clenching her fists and gesturing at herself.
His next words are very serious. "Casta can get authority to reset you on that."
Adora rolls her eyes on that. It doesn't really feel like a threat, coming from the guy and with his voice. It sounds like a warning.
"You mean lobotomize me."
He nods. "Try not to forget it. Be on the 5 pm boat."

The Hudson River is as gray as the sky. The ferry is rather empty. It may be due to the bad weather, because it had been raining and even now it's still drizzling a bit, and it's also not warm on this winter day. So, there are very few people on the viewing deck, and all of them stay below the ceiling or just inside. Adora sees Bow lingering at the - huh - bow of the ship, and walks towards him. Both are clothed warm enough and wear raincoats, so at least this is okay. It's not a really freezing winter day, but the air is chill, and the wind of the speeding boat adds to it.

Bow is taut when he says: "Ask your questions, I'll tell you what I can."
"What were you doing to Glimmer?"
"Just changing the way she weighs investments risks, which will subtly shift the way the direction of her company in the way upstairs wants. It will not be to your detriment, I promise."
Adora shortly thinks about that. It's not that she's ungrateful for Glimmer's change of mind. The approval of her project was a good start and got her many work to do for the next months. The solar panel project could be a game changer for a good part of the energy supply industry of the United States, the world, even. They have the potential to kill carbon-based energy production by undercutting cost-per-unit to a scale, conventional power generation can't compete anymore. The icing on the cake is that if they work as intended, they will all get rich beyond sanity. What good she could do with it wasn't something she allowed herself to

think about.
“Upstairs? What does that mean?”, Adora continues.
“That’s something I won’t elaborate on,” Bow states, and it sounds final.
Adora lets out a breath, because she was actually afraid to ask and maybe even more to get an answer.
“So, Casta could read my mind?”
It gets her a smug smile. “Casta was trying to scare you.”
“No, she knew the number I was thinking of, the color.”
Bow shakes his head. “Because she set it up as a choice. Choose a color, choose a number. We can’t read your mind or hear your thoughts. When you make a decision, your mind weighs options. We can perceive these options and sense the path you choose. We know when you’re going to go off the plan or not because if we’re close enough, we can sense when it’s going to happen. Our plan books can, too. We’re just here to keep you on plan. That’s all we’re authorized to do.”
All of this sounds absolutely crazy, but the calmg sincerity with which Bow is speaking leave no room for doubting him. “Are you allowed to be telling me this stuff? Are they following me now?”
Again, he shakes his head in denial. “We have to monitor the entire world, and don’t have the manpower to follow everyone all the time. We focus on certain subjects of importance.” He shortly lingers, as if to rethink his words, then continues: “And there’s something about water. It blocks our ability to read your decision tree.”

“My decision tree…,” Adora draws it out, “You know that’s something we learned back in university? How decisions can be split up, displayed, weighed and broken down into smaller or collected into larger ones. We learned that forecasting along a large decision tree is nearly impossible. So, are you an angel?” It’s only half joking.
He grins. “We’ve been called that. I would say, we’re more like case officers,” he says, huffs lowly, and continues, “who live a lot longer than humans.” Adora looks at him disbelievingly, but he says it in all honestly, and maybe he believes it. It’s just that *believing that way* had never been on Adora’s plate. She shakes

her head to get out of her freeze, and her blonde ponytail whirs around. “Why are you telling me this?”
“You’re important to me, and I have my reasons,” Bow admits and admits nothing.
“And why won’t they let me be with Catra?”
“All I know is, the amount of resources they use keeping you from her, it’s pretty damn important to them. Do you think that something like Casta did with you in the storage is usual? We do this maybe once in a decade, Adora. And telling people who we are? Twice a century, if at all.”
“The storage?”
“Just a name for the place we brought you to. It changes over time, to stay… intimidating. Efficient. And to keep up with the present”
Adora snorts: “Yeah, it nearly worked on me.”

Bow shoots her a hard glance, and he seems to read her mind, despite what he just said about water. “You’re going to look for her, aren’t you? You won’t find her, though. They’ll make sure of. Even if they weren’t trying to stop you, there are nine million people in this city. You’ll never find her.”

Bow makes a deliberate pause in this little speech, and then he lays a hand on Adora’s shoulder, a pleading, requesting gaze on his face.
“Please, Adora, forget about her. Focus on what you have. Move on with your life.”

His voice is kind and his eyes are assuring.
It's still a punch in the gut.
It is, actually, the hardest blow she has ever taken.

Chapter End Notes

> The next chapter is called "None of them were you" and will be published next Friday, November 26th. As always, comments are greatly appreciated.

None of them were you

Chapter Summary

Glimmer gets her hands dirty.
Adora has a date without knowing.
Fate lurks above everything.
Because none of them are you.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"None of them are you" (Deezer / Spotify)

Three

Years

Later.

"Move on with your life."

Bow's words still echo in Adora's mind, after all the time.

The man had fallen silent after saying them, but Adora had also run out of questions. What should she even do or ask anymore? It's easy to say to *move on*, but how is this actually possible? Adora had just met Catra twice in her whole goddam life, and yet it had seemed like she'd known her for so much longer. Everything just clicked. And still she doesn't know why these… higher powers or whatever they are, want them to be kept apart.

Higher powers!? If there were an all knowingly god who made humans, she should be pretty pissed that they made them so stupid, huh? Adora always thought of herself as an atheist, maybe

with being mentally open to the possibility that there are forces in the universe that are way beyond her understanding. She rather deemed them beings far more developed in their own track of evolution, and if an encounter would happen, they would appear to humankind as godlike or something similar, if they would even engage with us. To them, we must appear like ants or silverfishes, not worth another thought. But real… ugh… angels? On earth? Messing with the ways of humans. Of Adora's?

Unlikely. That doesn't sound like something that would actually happen. It sounds more like fiction. But still, she had proof it happened. At least, she thinks she has proof, if she's not already lobotomized. Or maybe she's dreaming, in a coma, and all this is just happening in her mind. But on the other side, even if it is, would it be less real? What could she even do then?
When she and Bow had parted, back then, Adora knew more but was none the wiser. This being made clear, there was no way for her to be with Catra. Because Catra was gone, and there are forces that take care that it stays this way.

Three years have passed. Leaves had fallen from the trees and began to green again three times. Three years later, and all she knows is, that the hole in her heart is still there, like it had been yesterday, and that there would be no way to fill it.

Adora, as is her nature, moved on with her life, it's successful, on track and her life is… well, it is.
Every morning she wakes up, makes her bed, straightens her ponytail, does her exercises, makes a little breakfast, gets a coffee, takes the bus, arrives at work, greets her colleagues, talks with Glimmer, fetches more coffee with Glimmer, develops her projects, earns good money, meets with people, goes out with friends, eats a dinner, showers warm, brushes her teeth, unties her ponytail, falls into her bed, and is alone.

She's alone and she doesn't mind.

It's not that she misses someone in her life. She just misses Catra. Laying in her bed and ruminating about the events of the day, of a week, of a season often leads her back into the men's room of the Waldorf. And into this certain bus. Only two times, not even an hour of her life.
One kiss.
One damned perfect kiss.
Sometimes someone makes a move on her, but she isn't interested at all. It just rolls off her. It's been three years, and nothing about the whirlwind of feelings for the enticing woman she was forced to let go has really changed. The flame still burns, less intense and not so consuming, but still strong enough though, so that nobody else stands a real chance.

Mermista had been at the receiving end of this reality, when she asked Adora out. Or rather, was pushed into a date. Mariam "Mermista" Salineas, old nobility of the New York society, heiress of *Salineas Roll-On-Roll-Off Carriers*, long-established and funny, as long as she put her snappy comments in check.
Adora having a date with the woman was kind of an accident, and Glimmer had her dirty hands in it. Being with some, let alone marry someone to help her political career, is nothing Adora would've ever done. It would be wrong. Besides, living that kind of lie, being manipulative and dishonest, is nothing she can be. Glimmer wouldn't hesitate to push Adora into a marriage, but luckily, she has no say in that. It's not that she can't try. [1] So she told Adora that she should go for a talk with Mermista to secure her support. It was a good idea, apparently, because they already knew each other from former occasions, and sounding out the chances for Adora's upcoming campaign for the next Senate elections needed donations and political support, and Mermista had good connections to both. Adora knows that she needs the financial support from as many donors as possible, and even if a good bunch already comes from normal folks, from her supporters, Glimmer always pushed her to snatch another big contribution by a wealthy socialite or business people. "Why stick

with 10 Million when you can spend 20?" she said, while covering her phone with a hand, grinning at Adora. And she wasn't wrong. Since the beginning of century, cost for Senate races totally derailed, with some campaigns spending up to a hundred millions dollars. Not that it helped in every case, but having more money to throw out of the window couldn't hurt in any case.

So, it had been a normal Wednesday evening, and on Glimmer's sneaky recommendation, they met at Loeb's at Central Park Lake to make it not stiff and formal, and talk about Mermista's willingness and abilities to support Adora. 'Have an easy talk with the snarky bitch' to quote Glimmer on that, followed by 'just be nice to her, okay. Put on something pretty. She's okay, mostly, and she has so much money that she doesn't have to care to spend some on you, babe. I mean, your campaign.' Adora got that Glimmer sounded a little off, but thought nothing of it.

A talk to a possible supporter. At least that was what Adora thought it was.
It wasn't.

Adora decided on a gray overknee skirt and alike pants, a white blouse under a dark red jacket to wear. It didn't fit perfectly, but it let her look a tad cooler and more stylish than normal. She fumbled with the dark gray ankle boots, threw a last look into the mirror, and was pleased with a good-looking yet not overdressed woman. "Will do," she mumbled to herself, while putting her ponytail in place again and made a notice to buy new ties, because she lost the little fuckers all the time.
As always, she arrived at the restaurant just in time, and asked the waiter to place them in a more quiety and comfy corner because they had things to discuss. It was 9 p.m. during the workweek, so rush hour was already over, and business started to slow down. Getting a nice table wasn't a problem at all, as the weather wasn't so fine either, and so not even half the tables were in use. Adora took place, ordered a Virgin Sunrise, and took in the room. Being observant was important, she learned that early. The interior wasn't very exclusive, rather comfy and relaxed. A rectangular bar in the middle of the room, surrounded by

wooden tables and chairs, and a front line of seating between the columns on the lakeside terrace. Behind the trees, the glowy skyline of Central Park West lurked above everything. Just a nice place, normal, comfortable.

The heiress to an industrial empire, a fortune of money and the political influence that came with it rushed in ten minutes late, didn't apologize, and sat down opposite of Adora with a low moan. The woman wore a black suit with a white button-up shirt, a golden belt with an intricate turquoise buckle, and a fedora of the same black as the suit. She was an impressive sight, something between intimidating and alluring, given her prurient attitude.

Mermista put the fedora down, unbuttoned her jacket, slid down on the opposite seat, and Adora started the conversation with a kind: "You're looking great, Mermista." She knew how little the woman cared for formalities and liked it straightforward and open.
"Thanks," Mermista replied casually. "You're not too bad either, and your little minion told me I should wear something nice, and so I did."
"Glimmer told you to wear something nice?" Adora repeated slowly, a bit puzzled, maybe because of the similarity. Why on Earth would Glimmer advise Mermista about how to dress for a normal dinner-meeting?
The woman shrugged her shoulders. "Whatever. I'm always looking good, so it wasn't *that* hard."
"It rather looks like you're on your way to hunt down a rival or prey for the night. You have a date later on?", Adora chuckled, ever so oblivious to what this date actually was.
Mermista glanced at her with an odd expression, but before she could speak out possible thoughts, they were interrupted by the waiter. "Good evening. Did the ladies have the opportunity to select something, or do you want a recommendation?"
Adora had no special request, so she went with the dish of the day, while Mermista opted for grilled salmon with selected steamed vegetables, and a bottle of red wine.
They made an amicable conversation till their meals were served. Adora explained the prospective restart of her campaign and what

she wanted to do as a Senator, and she got some overly detailed explanations of how Container Shipping worked today in return. Mermista rubbed her hands in excitement when she elaborated: "Next year, we will have the first ULCS with over 24,000 TEU ready, and then I'll show this idiot from Sea Hawk Ocean Express how business is done. HAH, in your face!" Her eyes glistened with joyful arrogance as she toasted to herself, and Adora giggled.
"ULCS? That means?"
Mermista put on full business mode. "Ultra Large Container Ship. Anything that carries over 20,000 containers. These are fat beasts, the largest movable objects anyone ever built, you know? We'll use them between the East Coast and Europe and the West Coast and Asia, because they can't go through the canal, I mean, both canals, you know? One of them costs over..."
Their conversation had a good flow, as always when professionals talked about things they knew everything about and were eloquent enough to explain it to an audience without much foreknowledge.
While they ate, Adora made clear that she would appreciate Mermista's support for her campaign. The brunette with a hint of blue dye in her hair glanced back while cutting an aubergine, then she etched: "Sure thing, count me in. It's not that I would support your opponent, huh? Creepy guy, actually."
"Sure he is," Adora chuckled. "Old family, massive influence, but the man is *weird*. I don't think he's actually interested in politics. It's rather to make his daddy happy, judging from the few occasions we met. What a bore. Anyway, that shouldn't be our topic. Tell me what you think of…"
And so it went on and on between them. Adora actually enjoyed Mermista's company. The woman was witty, intelligent, had a good taste and filled her suit properly. Not that Adora looked, nope, but she couldn't help to notice that Mermista had opened the first two buttons of her shirt, and that her cleavage as well as the hint of an azure bra was very visible now.
Later, they switched over to the fancy wooden bar with a few more glasses of the smooth, red wine that slipped down their throats unhesitatingly. It was the first time within a year that Adora drank so much, and it made her washy in a welcomed way.

“I told the Chair of the House ‘I prepared for any and all possible scenarios, and I’m so ready for this ball, I mean, session’, and my colleagues looked at me so puzzled. I was just making a joke, but *ugh*, most of these folks are so boring, actually. All serious talk, no fun.”
Mermista laid a hand on Adora’s shoulder, giggled, then added: “Don't let the bores take away your fun.”
“Yeah, I’ll do my best. I just hope being a lawyer isn’t contagious. They’re all so… princessy about their seriousness and stuff, you know?” Adora barked out, then both women chuckled and downed their drinks.

Night had long fallen, when Mermista suggested a walk back to 5th Avenue, where *coincidentally* her penthouse was. Adora still thought nothing of it, they were just two gals havin' a good time, and the two women giggled their way through the park, walking a path between trees and shrubs in a nice summer night.
Mermista had just told her some funny anecdote, making the blonde laugh loudly, then Adora touched Mermista’s shoulder in a matey manner. She also needed to steady herself, because she was a bit tipsy, but upon the touch, Mermista’s behavior smoothly changed from just friendly guiding Adora along the way into something different.
She put herself before Adora, laid her hands on Adora’s hips, and her face was suddenly very close.
“Do you want to continue this conversation at my place? It’s not a palace, but a penthouse… but… yeah, it’s a palace. Maybe, you wanna stay over?” And while saying that, Mermista leaned forward and touched Adora’s cheek gently. It wasn’t too much, but finally even Adora got it.

The blonde flinched back, something between surprised, embarrassed and confused. It obviously required this very, very blatant move on her to make Adora realize that this 'meeting' turned 'girls night out' was something else - at least for one of them.

“What? Wait, you… did you think this was a… date?” Adora looked absolutely puzzled.

Mermista leaned back and huffed. “You thought it wasn’t? Oh stars, you’re even more clueless than I thought you are. Glimmer hinted that, but I didn’t…” She chuckled. “That’s somehow sweet, but dear, we need to talk this out.” She licked her lips, and it seemed that a little blush ghosted her tanned skin.
“Glimmer didn’t say *anything* about this being anything else than a normal meeting”, Adora complained, defending herself with a voice pitched way too high. “I do this every night.” That came out wrong, she realized belatedly and looked away, not sure what to say.

“Ouch,” Mermista pretended and put her hand at the place other people had a heart. “That really hurt me, knowing that I’m not the only one you meet. And every night? You’re quite busy, but, uh, politics, huh?” She grinned lopsided.
“Haha, very funny,” Adora replied dryly. “I didn’t even know you’re into women. Nobody said anything about that?”
Mermista tweaked a lopsided grin: “I haven’t chained myself to such conventions and don’t make a fuss out of it, okay? I just like you. You’re cool. And sexy.”
“You’re sexy too!” it desperately slipped off Adora’s dumb lips before acknowledging that such a statement wasn’t helpful. She stepped forward and took one of Mermista’s hands into her own. She learned early how important touches were when it came to assure people, especially in a situation like that. “I mean… ugh… I’m sorry that Glimmer maneuvered us into such a situation. I promise that I didn’t know, okay?” She awkwardly scratched her neck and searched for more words, then came up with: “It would be cool if this… thing…,” she gestured between the two of them, “could be a thing. But I’m not open for a relationship right now. It's too soon. Too soon."
Mermista had a frown on her face. "But… Glimmer said you haven't been with anyone since… forever, and—"
"I'm sorry," Adora whispered, absolutely unable and unwilling to explain the weight that lay upon her heart, every single day. She was ashamed that she interpreted the whole evening wrong.
Fortunately, Mermista took it lightly. She shrugged her shoulders: “I wasn’t aiming at a relationship, Blondie. Just thinking about a

night, maybe two. Could've been fun, and then we could have figured it out from there."
Adora gulped. This was way too open and straightforward for her usual liking, but she tried to appreciate it. She grabbed her neck with a hand and rubbed it awkwardly.
"That's… it's a compliment, I think? So, thank you?" A weak grin tried to smooth her words.

The brunette waved it off: "It sure is. But, whatever. It was worth a try."
Adora put a strand back behind her ear, asking teasingly: "Oh, really? What makes you think so?"
Mermista let her gaze wander over Adora's body and gestured at her: "Are you serious? Have you looked into the mirror, Adora? Like, ever?"
"What has that to do with anything?"
Mermista shook her head and groaned loudly. "Oh stars, you're so clueless. It would be super cute if it wasn't so infuriating."
"I'm not cute," Adora snorted.
Mermista laughed loudly, but only short, then the charming woman leaned forward and placed a peck on Adora's cheek. "You're super cute. I will vote you."
It didn't change the outcome of the evening, but Adora blushed at the gesture, felt a little better, and didn't protest again. They parted when they reached 5th Avenue, where Mermista strolled over to her apartment and Adora took a taxi home.

Fading Colours (Deezer / Spotify)

The evening with Mermista was Adora's only date in three years, and she didn't even know it was one until it was over. She told Glimmer never to do something like that again. Only that she didn't tell her. It was rather shouting at her best friend - but still very kind for a very embarrassed Adora.

So, when morning comes, and Adora's still in this blissful state between sleeping and waking up, her mind's filling her dreams with pictures. She shifts in her bed, draws her blanket over her head, and drifts, allowing herself to wallow in the reminiscence of

something that might have been and wasn’t allowed to be, besides some very precious minutes. When the sunlight falls friendly through her bedroom window and between a gap of the curtains, hitting her face with warmth, she tries to think that it’s the warmth of Catra’s hand, touching her like she did it back then, at the Waldorf.

When they kissed.

Adora knows she should let go of her. And it’s not like she doesn’t want to, at least half-heartedly. Sometimes, she wants to move on, to be able to move past this feeling of being drawn to a woman she barely knows - knew. The problem is that she just *can’t*, and it’s as simple as that. Her mind isn't on Catra all the time, but in rare spare times it always drifts to the alluring stranger as if she was a soulmate. As if they were destined to be together. When she touches her lips with her fingers, she sometimes thinks she can still taste Catra’s lips on her own.

Then again, it was made clear she would never see Catra again, isn't allowed to, and so she does her usual morning routine, as mundane as it is, even today. Life is just like that, routine, and it doesn’t matter if she’s living in the jungle or in a skyscraper in New York. Life consists of trying and repeating, every single day, and Adora has never been shy of her duties. But there is one thing she does nearly every day, and she doesn’t perceive it as a duty. And despite being told she shouldn't, and can't, search for Catra.

For today, she puts on one of her best suits, one that doesn’t look too formal but also not too casual, it’s a dark white one, with some golden applications, and it makes her look stunning, she knows that. She doesn’t bother with her hair too much, just combs it a few times and puts her poof into place. She should not look too overstyled. And she can let Glimmer have another look upon her later on. Now, something else is important.
Because her usual morning routine, her whole fucking daily routine, even that of today has one special highlight, and that is: taking the bus.

Adora never verbally admitted it to anyone, even not to Glimmer in all the time that she still has hope, deep in her heart. Catra's never been on the bus again, though, but Adora *has to try*. It's her only chance, given that she has nothing else on her plate, and that she isn't allowed to search for the woman too blatantly. This tiny act of daily rebellion is what keeps her alive, keeps her going. There's still that incredibly little piece of hope. So, she has to take this one chance for everything what it's possibly good for.

She takes the usual bus, and Catra's not there, as she hasn't been for the last 1,060 days, minus weekends and holidays. Adora has six stations to go, and her gaze lingers around. Taking in the people on the sidewalks is something she does instinctively now. Adora always scanned everything, but in the last 1,060 days it became rather obsessive. Nothing today either. She sighs and rummages absent-mindedly in her bag, looking for her phone to shoot Glimmer a text. The woman had written an hour ago and deserves an answer, probably, because of *today*.

"You ready, woman? Big day!"

"Yup, I'm so ready for this speech. Will be there soon."

"Great. What are you wearing? And let me guess: someone needs to do your hair?"

"What does everyone always have with my hair?"

"Don't worry, I got this. Makeover time!"

Adora snorts and fears what's coming, then her gaze wanders again over the sidewalk as the bus rides down 6th Avenue and is heading for the fourth stop. Adora has shortly pondered about what to reply, looking outside, when she suddenly sees it: a brunette woman, walking fast, stringy figure, curly hair.
Her heartbeat quickens. It can't be. It can't be.
But the movement of the woman looks so familiar. Her mouth falls agape as the bus drives past the passers-by, and then Adora is finally able to see the woman's face. Everything in her lights up

like a sunrise.
Catra!
It’s her.
It is Catra!
Oh goddess, this is real!

Adora feels her heart race, as she jumps from her seat immediately, and shouts: “Stop! Stop the bus, please! Stop!”

The bus has passed Catra and a crossing, and as Adora looks back she sees Catra walking swiftly around a corner and departing from 6th Avenue into a side street, getting out of sight, making Adora crazy. It's not panic, not yet, because the bus slows down. Luckily, the stop is right ahead, and the bus halts quickly. Adora holds her bag tight, jumps out the second the doors open and runs the 200 meters back to the corner where she lost sight of the brunette woman. It was her, she’s absolutely certain, and when Adora runs into the side street she sees… no Catra.

No familiar figure, but it's not yet lost, Catra was walking quickly, and Adora’s not panting, not yet, as she runs to the next crossing which is only 50 meters or so away. When she reaches the next corner, it is like the whole world comes to a halt, because there, there! the woman is, only a dozen meters away, walking.

“Catra!” Adora calls, and slows down. “Catra!”

And Catra turns.
“Adora?”

Shortly, a wide smile appears on Catra’s face, and it’s such a beautiful sight. But then, her look quickly morphs into something more hesitant than the last time - the second time they met. But it's still the same half-amused, half-concerned gaze. Adora takes a breath and says: “You know, I rode the M55 to work every day for the whole three years, hoping that I bump into you.”

Her words get her a wary look, but she has to explain as much as she can, fast, now, before the people that are overseeing her and

will try to get her on track take notice of their obvious slip up. She doesn't know how this was allowed to happen in the first place, but she'll be damned if she doesn't make use of it, even today.
"Listen, is there a place we could go and talk?" Adora asks breathlessly and with a pleading look.
Catra sighs, and it becomes clear that she's not as happy to see Adora as Adora is to see her. "Ugh… don't you have to get to work or something?"
Adora's phone starts to ring. And Adora starts to look around, trying to get a grip if they are already being watched, presumably being intercepted.
"I just got sick!" she calls loudly, fumbling for her phone to silence it.
"I haven't seen you in three years, you make me sick! That's not an ideal come-on, just so you know," Catra replies with folded arms, and she *tries* to let it sound a bit angry, but she somehow can't hide *a small* smirk.
Adora giggles shortly, but she also looks around to search, being asked instantly: "What are you looking for?"
"Just felt like someone was watching us," Adora tries to apologize, and now she finally got the fucking noisy phone, looks at it, and it's just Glimmer. She takes it and rattles off in an insane speed:
"HeyGlimmer, I'mgoingtohavetoskipbreakfast, andIprobablyhavetopostponethespeech,too. IjustbumpedintoCatra, byebye, loveya."

Pressing the red button, she ends the call, silences and pockets the damned thing. The next second she's accused by said Catra looking at her with a huge frown and folded arms. "You just hung up on your friend."
"Yeah, but we've known each other since we were kids, she'll forgive me. Probably. Or kill me. Whatever." Adora grins widely. "Who cares?"
"What speech?" Catra asks, piercing.
"Doesn't matter," Adora tilts her head and grins even more. She's so excited, and she knows it shows. She doesn't care either, but gets another frown from a suspiciously glancing Catra: "It doesn't

matter?”
“Nope!" she replies, popping the 'p'. "You wanna take a walk?”

“No?” It comes out more as a question than an actual ‘No’, so Adora doesn’t let it count. She won’t, and she can't. “We have a lot to catch up on!”
“I don’t think you should cancel whatever speech you want to hold. And what if I don’t like you at the end of our walk?” Catra asks, hesitant and a bit repellant.
Maybe Adora should’ve been taken aback by the half-rude comment, but she just grins more into Catra’s pretty face, still being so happy to run into her. “Unlikely. But I’ll take my chances.”
Still, Catra doesn't give in so easily. “Seriously, my number hasn’t changed, just call me like you didn’t last time.”

Ooof. That stings. Because these fuckers had the audacity to not even do that? What the fuck? She should’ve guessed or even tried by luck more, Adora thinks for a second, because calling something between ten thousand and a million numbers sounds to be at least *technically possible* in hindsight. But then she throws the feeling of guilt away. They would’ve tricked the line or whatever. Bow was right: these fuckers only act when it was necessary. And as long as Adora didn’t call Catra, there was no need to intercept. She has to make amends for that, even if it’s not her own fault.
“Look, if you take a walk with me, I’ll explain why.” It sounds a bit pleading, and she gets a grim expression in return, but there is a little twitch in the corner of Catra’s mouth. And Adora still has this large grin on her own face that she just can’t stop, despite being looked at with a mixture of disbelief, hurt and mistrust. It’s when she adds a final “Please?” and giving her best puppy dog eyes that presumably makes Catra wave a hand and saying:
“Whatever.”
She takes it as a big win, and so Adora asks delighted: “Where do you wanna go? I just got a free day!" She recounts today’s schedule. "Or at least two hours until Glimmer calls the police. Or the National Guard.”

They start to walk towards *somewhere*, but she doesn't actually care. Catra's voice is lighter than before, not so thick and mistrusting when she says: “It’s been three years. How do you know I don’t have a nice girlfriend?”
Uhm… that would be... shit, Adora silently admits to herself. Actually, she hadn’t considered for that, and realizes just now how dumb this was. She’s such an idiot, of course, she couldn’t have expected Catra to feel the same way as she did! But Catra’s words are actually an open goal: “Do you have a nice girlfriend?”
“Would it matter, if I did?” Catra asks rough, and with a devious grin on her face.
“Yeah!” It’s nearly a shout. Of course, it would matter. What a question is that even?
“So you don’t have any real conviction then?" she gets teased mercilessly in return. Catra seems to enjoy torturing her very much.
“Okay, it wouldn’t matter at all," Adora groans back, half joking.
“Ah, so you don’t mind being a home-wrecker?” Catra continues being an absolute asshole, but the tone isn’t as grim as before.

Adora chuckles, but then they are being interrupted by some fellow yelling over the street they’re walking along.
“Congresswoman! How are you doing? I’m from Red Hook. You’re the best! We love ya!”
She laughs loudly and shouts back: “Thank you! Good to see you, buddy!” The guy gives her two thumbs up, and she waves, then she returns her gaze to Catra who looks at her puzzled. “Happen’s often, never seen him. Okay, if you were married, then it would bother me.”
“Now you’re just saying what you think I want to hear,” Catra accuses her, but it’s lighter. “Just like with the guy who yelled at you.”
Adora looks at her incredulously. “I would never—"
Catra interrupts her by slapping her arm, laughs, then sighs: “I’m single.”
And that’s a massive relief. Adora feels so light, so happy just to know. The woman is single, this day is fucking great, isn’t it? Her grin is back, and her good mood is only slightly bothered when

Catra adds: “Now, let’s hear your bullshit excuse for not calling me.”

Oh! Oh yes, she trained this, actually, before the mirror. Several times! No, she didn’t. Only three times. She can do this. “I... I didn’t have your number.” That wasn’t so hard, was it?
Catra doesn’t buy it. “I gave it to you on the bus. Handed it to you, even.”
“I was mugged. It was taken from me.” Adora can admit at least that. It’s near enough to the truth, so she doesn’t have to lie. She’s a bad liar, still, even after ten years of being into politics, and after twenty years of being Glimmer’s best friend. The woman is capable of many things, but teaching Adora how to lie properly was beyond even her abilities.
“No, come on!”
“My wallet was taken!" Adora insists, nearly whining now. Her composure starts to falter.
“Come! On!” Catra rejects, unconvinced.
“Why else would I fawn all over you on a bus three years ago and then never call you? That doesn't make any sense!" Her voice pitches high, and she gestures wildly around, feeling a bit off.
Catra stares at her. “Because I don’t know! You have a girlfriend, and you felt terrible, probably? People do this all the time. And you’re… You have plenty of choices, don’t you?”
“What?” Adora doesn’t get it. What did she say?
“You’re a politician, aren’t you? Stunning, successful and gorgeous Congresswoman Adora Grayskull. Women must throw themselves into your arms, don’t they?” Now, Catra’s face is concerned, and she’s not really joking anymore. It’s still some kind of teasing, but Adora gets that there is something beneath the surface, something she doesn’t know or understand right now.
“They don’t,” Adora denies promptly, even if that’s not exactly true. In fact, they do - sometimes - but she hasn’t ever made a move on one since… the Waldorf. 1.060 days, and her failed non-date doesn’t count.
“Now I know you’re lying,” Catra scoffs, but it isn’t an outright accusation, it comes out more like disappointment.
“Okay, maybe sometimes someone throws something at me,”

Adora admits, already half giggling, and it gets Catra to chuckle out one precious laugh, then another, and then they both giggle like idiots.
“Listen, I swear to you that I didn’t have your number.”

Catra takes a good amount of her time to ponder about it, while they walk along Perry Street. Adora is a bit fidgety while she waits for an answer.
“All right,” Catra finally replies, but it doesn’t sound believing.
Adora groans. “No! On my parents’ graves, I swear.”
“That’s heavy," Catra barks out, a bit surprised.
“That’s too heavy, I know,” Adora chuckles, “but it’s true.” She can say something like that now, being it nearly two decades ago. “I didn’t have your number. And I didn’t even know your last name. Do you know that if you google just “Catra”, you get 8,460,000 hits?” Adora did that, and it's also true. Eight fucking million search results and none of them helped.
“What?” Catra nearly screams. “You did not, you stalker. And… how’s that so many?” she asks then, apparently stunned.
“Looks like it’s the name of a pretty popular character out of a cartoon? Some snarky catraesque beast. I mean, I can tell you plenty about… but that’s not the point!” Adora must not let herself get confused. “The point is, none of them are you!”

Catra takes a heavy breath, glares at Adora and seems to consider what she just heard, while Adora just stands there and waits, fidgeting with her fingers nervously. Adora feels nervous. Why is she so nervous, like an inexperienced teenager? She’s a grown-up, 31 years old, successful and her return to the political arena is imminent. She already fought battles in the political and business arena, and the last years had been both hard and successful. But here she is, just a girl, standing in front of another girl, waiting for an answer and fearing nothing more than a letdown.

And interception.

Their notebooks can't do much to alarm them when something's *going to go* wrong. The capacity needed to observe everything

out there is so large that it would need the matter of a whole world turned into a calculator. Per piece. They can't do that, and so they don't. Even heaven or however this place should be called is being run by controlling. They have just another word for it. It's more complicated, longer, and probably of German origin.

But what they can do is to immediately notify them when something *has* gone wrong. It's better than having to watch a subject 24/7, which they can't, because of capacity reasons. So, they have been notified, and one of the women with the gray hats walks as fast as possible through the Library's Rose Main Reading Room until she reaches a certain door at the side, open's it, walks through, is in a hallway only *they* are allowed in, and runs for Casta's office.

Bow had some spare time in the recent weeks, and his duty has been easy for the last year: Adora was on track, his other subjects were doing remarkably well, but this was also due to the fact that they were easy cases. Given his contribution to handling Adora Grayskull for more than three decades, which is actually before her birth, this was well deserved. Even he thinks this.

"We have a problem," the woman says.
"Netossa. How unpleasant to see you. What's up?" Casta asks, and looks unnerved. She has a lot of notebooks open on her desk, followed some paths right before, and her bangs are a bit messy. She had hoped for an easy morning, but surely, that won't happen.
"Adora Grayskull is off plan," Netossa says.
"Ugh, that stubborn bitch", she sighs, and throws a look into the plan book Netossa offered her. "How did she find her?"
"Chance. She just spotted her on the street."
"We never should have let her meet her in the first place."
Netossa desperately shrugs her shoulders: "We followed protocol to the letter, Casta. We had to. Now?

Casta looks pissed, and maybe rightfully so. She stands up and takes her hat. "The woman rides the same bus, every day, for three years? Who does that? She makes me crazy." Walking out of

her office, Netossa in tow, they pass through the Reading Room again. Bow is there, writing a protocol, and Casta etches as she passes by: “Three years later, I’m still cleaning up your mess.” Bow looks surprised, but doesn’t say anything. He’s long past Casta’s occasional slip-ups. It’s not like she hasn’t done stuff wrong herself, and so he just ignores it mostly.
Casta and Netossa hurry further into the hallway, go to another door, walk through, and are right at the park, two kilometers further from where Adora and Catra have been walking through, between trees with golden autumn leaves, agleamed by a warm sunshine falling upon them from a cloudless blue sky. This weather is way too perfect, way too romantic, Casta recognizes, it’s like the weather and the whole day was made for them. She feels how there’s something working against her, and she just can’t lay a finger on it now, because the consequences at the very end of that train of thought would be… interesting. Netossa holds a plan book before them both, and there are a bunch of inflection points, blinking.
Casta points at one of them and says: “Let’s cut the power at her dance studio.”

“I’m a dancer,” Catra says.
“Oh!” Adora answers and for a split second she has a picture of Catra in her mind, that is barely appropriate. Not decent. To be honest, it involves the *belt-thingy* from three years before and is downright indecent, so Adora quickly discards the thought and blames it on the fact that she hasn’t had sex in even more than said three years. But Catra isn’t an idiot, and before Adora can do anything, she gets her answer.
“Not like that, you pervert,” she etches. “I’m in a contemporary ballet company.” Her smirk is wide and her teasing voice bares any indulgence.
“I think you have the wrong idea about me,” Adora defends herself, but they look at each other’s eyes, and Catra smirks only more, and then Adora grins, and they both start giggling. Now it’s like before, like the second time they met. The whole banter feels just natural.

“No, I think that was the first thing that crossed your mind, actually,” Catra vexes, still amused and a bit huffy.
Adora opens her arms in a defending gesture: “And I think you should invite me to one of your performances. Just so I can judge it for myself how not-inappropriate it is, huh?!”
“We don’t do solo, pervert.”
“Ugh, that’s not what I meant!” Adora is blushing, hard, upon the thought of a solo dance by the stringy, alluring woman. “But I wouldn’t...“, she cuts her loose mouth off before she embarrasses herself even more.
Catra chuckles loudly, and pats her knee, then adds: “The company is called Two Pines, and there might or might not be a show tomorrow night. If you want to see dressed people dancing, I mean.”
“Is that an invitation?” Adora beams.
“No, it’s information. They probably won't let you in any way. Wait, I'll take a picture, so security knows your ugly face.” And with that, Catra takes a picture of a laughing blonde, and her heart feels so light. Because Adora laughs, bright and wholeheartedly, as their mutual day just got perfect. Catra feels warm and snuggly.

They walk around aimlessly for a while until they reach a nice restaurant at the park beneath some trees. It’s late in the morning, and Adora motions Catra to a place, because having a short break and something for - a late - breakfast would be delightful. The woman doesn’t look so reluctant anymore, she has seemingly eased and maybe believes Adora’s explanation why she didn’t call her. Three years have passed, but now it’s like no time has passed at all.
Adora exchanges a few words with the receptionist, who seems to know her. It’s something she often has to do, because people just recognize the blonde politician easily, and maybe now more than ever. Glimmer’s beneath-the-surface built-up during the last few months has already managed to spin palpable rumors and slowly, people start to pick up on Adora’s *political* career again.
Because everyone loves a good story, about the girl who got knocked down, picked herself up, got knocked down again, picked

herself up again, and now goes for Senate another time. Losing isn't too bad, if you know how to turn into a compelling story, apparently, and to her luck, Glimmer knows exactly how to play on that instrument. The woman is a wicked witch, but luckily, she's Adora's wicked witch.

But for now it isn't important. It's important that they get a table for two at the terrace where it is nice and sunny, that they sit down and talk, that she found Catra again, and now she even knows where Catra works, and she won't let her go again. The just have to continue speaking, and all will be fine.

"Thirty-six hours without contact, she'll never speak to her again," Casta states firmly.
"Her decision tree is diverging from our models," Netossa objects, but is repelled. "Look at her file, it's the last thing in the world she'll put up with. That woman never forgives a disappointment like that. She'll take it as betrayal and will hold onto the grudge. And how could Adora justify another slip-up? She won't be able to."
Netossa contradicts: "No, something's wrong. I'm already seeing inflection points, here, here, and there. They're both off the plan now. Look at this one." She points at one certain mark on the plan that seems to be very near, arriving in the next one or two hours, and it's *huge*. It is way off the main path they need Adora in, and if *this* happens, Casta is out.

Casta is shocked, despite her usual wit: "What's that?"
"A kiss," Netossa simply says.
"A kiss? That's all it takes? They did already!"
"A real kiss", she emphasizes. "It's different. Now they know. If that happens, every possible adjustment strong enough to break them up will cause ripples over your limit. Far beyond, to put it that way. I haven't seen something like that in… decades, I think."
She doesn't really seem to be unhappy with that, Casta shortly thinks, but then, she hasn't heard these words in the last half century either, and they make her sigh. Sometimes, she hates this job.

It has to be done, though.

They have sat down, they're here, and Adora should be happy and grateful, and she is. It's just that she's nervous, because she can't shake off the feeling that an interference is coming.
"Are you okay?" Catra asks with a hint of concern.
"Yeah."
Concentrate, Adora. She's here. Make something out of it. Adora knows that she has to focus on Catra.
And it's actually… easy. It's so easy to fall into chatter with her, they just click. Their conversation flows from topic to topic, until they land by this one: "You have to be born with the right body," Catra explains while gesturing at herself, "like very flexible hips and shoulders and long neck."
"And you weren't", Adora smirks over her glass of apple juice. She's shot daggers at and a cute pout: "No, I was, you idiot! I was lucky. I'm veeeery flexible." Catra moans the last words and bows back on the chair, puffing out her chest and stomach to an amount it's just sinful. Adora blushes furiously and nearly splutters apple juice at the public display of very tight cloth nestling against perky breasts and an absolute flat, firm abdomen. "I see," she coughs, "you've really been graced," then gathers her wit again: "You sure about the… uhm… solo dance?"
It earns her another amused "Pervert", but then Catra continues as if nothing happened: "But after 15 years of that precision and the training, I wanted to try something else, just on my own, open-ended and human, I guess."
That sounds different. "What do you mean?"
"I think that everything you go through in life, should come out in the way that you dance," Catra says earnestly. Adora gets it only half, because she'd always been clumsy in the few times she went to the disco, and she didn't bother to learn to dance during high school or uni, so she's on the rather helpless side of all of this. "I haven't found that to be the case with my dancing", she jokes, and she is so happy about how this makes Catra laugh loudly, and kind, and it lets her look so, so beautiful when she's doing it. Her dark brown curls flow around, frame her face so nice, and her lips

look so plump, her mouth so damned kissable, so perfectly made for Adora.
"It's a shame," Catra says, still laughing, and everything is perfect in this very moment.

Then the interruption arrives.

"Adora!" Coming, or rather hurrying from the park, Glimmer approaches them with large steps, looking at Catra only half surprised, saying, "Hi."
"Hi!" Catra replies, a bit warily.
"Hate to interrupt you. Nice to see you again, Catra," Glimmer states, then looks at the other woman. Adora cuts in with a voice that could fillet: "How did you find me?" Because this reeks of an adjustment, she just knows it. Maybe going paranoid isn't the best idea for a future Senator of the United States, but Glimmer literally had no idea where she was or where they were going. She hadn't told her - deliberately - and Adora isn't an idiot. She can literally feel *these people* fist-bumping somewhere behind her back.
Glimmer wipes it off: "Does it matter? I know people everywhere, and they know you. You've been spotted." And she ignores Adora's stare when continuing: "There's a crowd of people waiting for your announcement speech at the Brooklyn Bridge right now, woman! Who do you think you are?" Glimmer turns to Catra, nearly apologetic: "Sorry, that's not about you, but this woman is an idiot. Unfortunately, she doesn't get it, despite I'm telling her since literal decades. Doesn't listen to anybody."
But Catra gets it immediately, looking back at Adora, stunned: "You're announcing today? You can't skip this for me!"
Adora has to set this right: "I know. I told you I'm not going to let you out of my sight."
Glimmer stands there and is growingly unnerved: "Adora, what the hell?"
But Adora ignores her and pleads Catra: "Do you want to come? You wanna watch?"
Catra's eyes pull wide and struggles with an answer. "No. Yes. I mean, I can't. I have to go and rehearse. Actually, I just heard that they're moving my rehearsal to Pier 17, right next to the

bridge."
This reeks.
Adora can't shake the feeling off that something's going on. She senses that there are forces working in the background that try to tear them apart, and she doesn't want to leave Catra now, not so quick. It's been three years and only today of all days they run into each other? That has to mean something! They need more time!

She looks at Glimmer. "Why don't we just postpone it? We'll do the speech another time."
Glimmer stares at her with fury, and Adora winces a little under it. She knows herself it's a bad idea, but she feels helpless and wants to stay at Catra's side. But Catra is faster: "No! Adora, you can't do that! This is important. You know I said you can't let the country being run by idiots like Hordak! Remember? You have to go!"
"Thank you!" Glimmer shouts and looks grateful, waves at a waiter and calls for the bill immediately. Then she turns back to Adora: "Come on, it's so close. It'll take you ten minutes to get to Pier 17 after the speech."
Adora's unconvinced, still. There's something going on, but she can't tell them because… yeah, Fight Club rule number 1, and the irony is not lost on her, that the rule had been broken all time long during the whole fucking movie.
"Just come over when you're done," Catra assures her, while putting her hand on Adora's. The touch is delicate and warm and unexpected. It reminds Adora of how they touched before, at the restroom, when they did so much more. She wants to do that again.
"All right," she gives in with a sigh, Glimmer breathes out in relief, and they stand up and walk off from the restaurant's terrace.

"Are you sure you don't want a ride? I could throw Glimmer out, and then we would have the back of the limousine for us, you know? Just in case…" Adora is bold when she makes the innuendo, and maybe it's a bit too much, but Catra gets it and laughs so pretty.
"No, I have to go home and change, princess." Hearing Catra

calling her like that makes Adora shudder, while Catra continues. "You're so late. Your friend is about to cry any second."
They turn to each other and are about to part, but Adora doesn't want to leave her just like that. Catra lets out an audible breath, and Adora needs some kind of assurance that this will continue, that they will see each other later this day. Standing in front of the beguiling woman she's dreamed of for the last 1,060 days, she moves closer to her, a bit awkwardly, but though.
And she's met with the same response. It's exactly like in the Waldorf, right before they kissed. She looks into Catra's mismatched eyes, and *falls* into them, shuffles closer, and now their faces are barely the breadth of one hand apart. She feels Catra holding her breath as she raises her hand for guidance, and there's no hesitation when she leans—

"Adora! Sorry, the TV crew is there. We got to go, woman!" Glimmer looks up from her phone, clearly conflicted, but she's also dedicated to getting today done. And in her mind, Adora can kiss Catra just later. They'll be fine!

Adora and Catra recoil from a kiss that almost happened right now. Adora has the distinctive feeling that she's been tricked into letting Catra go. She senses it, and can't do anything, though, because she can't tell anybody. So she grabs Catra's hands, presses a gentle kiss on her cheek, and says: "Look, whatever happens, I'm not going to let anything come between us again." Catra smiles at these words, she feels it's honest, says "Okay," and it makes Adora's heart light. They will see each other again, on this very day. And now that she knows where Catra works, she can find her, come what may.
"See you soon," Adora shouts, then she's on her way with Glimmer up front, to change her life again.

Only, that it doesn't work this way. She hasn't noticed the two people with the gray hats that have observed them for a while, from a bit away, and therefore couldn't capture the relieved sigh that Casta let out when the woman beside her says: "We're good."

Glimmer snorts. It's this kind of snort one makes, when he can't believe how stupid the other one is.
"What?" Adora asks, repellant. They sit next to each other in the back of a limousine, on their way to Pier 1.
Glimmer mimics Adora high-pitched and nasal: "I'm gonna postpone my announcement?" Her voice normalizes. "Are you an idiot? I can't believe it. We've been planning this since weeks, Adora."
Adora doesn't answer, but looks out of the window. She knows herself that it was a snap reaction, driven by fear to lose Catra again. But it felt real, necessary even at that moment, and she won't apologize for that. It still feels real.
"Postpone anything," Glimmer adds and with a mild portion of irritation dripping off of her.
"What?" Adora repeats, because she's not really able to explain what goes on in her mind. And because she actually can't explain. It's forbidden, and she has to carry this on her own. She can't put Glimmer in danger.
Glimmer chuckles lowly: "I just never seen you like that, that's all."
She's right, Adora thinks. But she can't get the picture of Catra out of her mind, smiling at her, when she said that they will see each other soon. She has that picture, clings to it, the whole ride over to the place where she's going to announce. *I will see her soon!*

The cheering crowd is massive, much larger than the first time she announced her candidacy. Given, last time it had been maybe two hundred people, and half of them former co-students that personally had been rallied by Glimmer who threatened them with horrifying punishments if they wouldn't appear. The free beer had also helped. The other half were people from the party, who were interested in the handsome, friendly and still a bit awkward blonde young woman that one day just walked into the local headquarters and announced that she wanted to become a Congresswoman.

It had been mortifying and funny at the same time, but it had been a fitting kick-off for her first election campaign.

Now, she's a well-known person, has connections throughout the whole city, her party supports her well, Glimmer is a terrifying campaign manager, and their friendship has endured everything. They love each other in a platonic and relaxed way, and together, they can do everything, Adora knows.

It seems, they can of course gather a thousand or more people on a nice day, beside the Brooklyn Bridge and Pier 1, where the pier, the plaza before it and the crossing of Old Fulton Street with Furman Street are now absolutely crowded. The police had to cordon off everything because there was no way of getting through otherwise. Adora and Glimmer arrive in a limousine of Glimmer, and when Adora steps out of the car, she is overwhelmed with shouting and applauding people. Two security fellows have to guide her through the crowd of excited people, she hears a group shouting "Grayskull, Grayskull, Grayskull" in the background, and everyone she passed by wants to shake her hands. "How you doin'?" she asks someone, then "Nice to see you," to the next one, a "Good that you're here," and a few "Thank you, appreciate it."
There are more "How are you's" while she slowly shuffles through the crowd until finally she reaches the podium, steps up and calls loudly into the microphone "Thanks a lot! Good to see you, too!" Behind her is the iconic structure of the Brooklyn Bridge over the East River and behind that, the alike skyline of Manhattan. Her campaign chose the place deliberately, to connect Adora's roots in Red Hook in the Brooklyn side with her today's center of her life in *the City*. People cheer and holler back, clapping and shouting, "Adoraa!" and Adora shouts back: "Thank you so much!"

She waves with both hands and just loves it, then Glimmer throws her a thumbs up, and she knows it's time to do her job. She waves the audience down like always when she wants to start a speech, and the crowd falls silent.
"Well, I have to say, it's good to be back in Brooklyn! There's been a lot of speculation as to whether or not I would run for a Senate

seat here in New York. I came here today to put an end to that speculation and I tell you, unequivocally, I will seek the Senate seat for the great state of New York."

Again, the applause is overwhelming. "Adora! Adora! Adora" Glimmer clearly has her hands in this choreography, but it's also genuine, and Adora basks in it. People like Adora, because she's not one of these snobbish ones of the old New York money nobility, nor is she some aloof snipe from wherever that came into town and tell them how to do it.
She's right out of Red Hook, born a few streets from here, and was raised in a quarter that had been described in the 1988 by LIFE with the headline *The Fright Zone - Downfall of a Neighborhood.* She wasn't yet born when Patrick Daly, head of P.S.15 - the very school she went to and that carries his name now - was shot down by a stray bullet from a crossfire between teenage drug dealers. The principal had been searching the neighborhood for a fourth-grader who fled school, crying, after a fight, and the man never returned from that. His story was another cornerstone in Adora's wish to matter, to make things better, when she learned about the effects his legacy had on her school and the community.[2]
Today, Red Hook is a fairly normal quarter of Brooklyn and subject to gentrification as so many other neighborhoods of New York are since the turn of the century, but there's still much flair leftover from Adora's childhood. And from the tragedies thereof.

Adora pauses for a moment and turns her head around to look over at the other side of the East River, where Pier 17 lies. She longs for the end of this event, so that she can teleport or whatever she would have to do to get over there and meet Catra again. But Glimmer's right: this day is important for her. So she turns back and continues:
"I was nine years old when I hung around in our living room on a boring rainy afternoon, watching TV, and accidentally switched on CNN because I was sitting on the remote. There was this odd man speaking about something I didn't understand. He talked about hardwork and perseverance, and about his grandfather, who

joined Patton's army and marched across Europe to fight the baddies.
He spoke about his parents, who shared an improbable love and sought for opportunity. And he spoke about that all men are created equal, and that the true genius of America is the pursuit of happiness. I didn't really understand much of what he said, but I understood that he wanted an America that is better than the one we inherited.
Years later, when I got into High School, this man appeared again on the TV screens, now the President of our great nation. And I knew I wanted to do that too, to make New York a better place, to make Brooklyn a better place! Today, it's not so grim here as it was in my childhood, and many of this is thanks to the remarkable efforts that were made after the death of the man my primary school is named after. But I tell you that this is not enough. I tell you we must, and we can do better!"

The applause is overwhelming.

Twenty minutes later, Adora has finished her speech and feels a bit exhausted. Again, she talked from her heart, despite she has many pieces of her addresses on notes. Now she's chatting with some of her supporters and attendants of the event. Like always, she likes to talk to normal people from the hood. But today and despite the importance of her annunciation, she has other stuff whispering in the back of her mind, and that stuff is mostly brunette and tremendously handsome. And the bad feeling from before, when they parted, never really left her.

"Outlands" (Deezer)

So she's annoyed - or rather pissed - and not really surprised, when she sees a figure with a gray hat watching the scene from behind a window at the Eagle Warehouse & Storage Company. The huge brickstone building glows red in the sunlight, and for a moment, sunbeams pierce into a room, enlightening it. And there she sees something. Them! It's the woman, Casta, she's nearly

sure. And her lackey, presumably, the white haired one. Her bad feeling about leaving Catra behind gets stronger. These folks are here, and they are trying to intercept, to adjust.
Glimmer tugs at her sleeve. “Don’t forget, I added the banker’s group after The Daily Show tomorrow.” Then Glimmer notices that she doesn’t really listen, but still watches that window, and now Adora throws a look back at Pier 17. Where Catra should be. And Adora’s feeling worsens. “Are you listening to me?” Glimmer insists and tugs at her jacket. “Adora?”

Pier 17 is far over, on the other side of the East River, but it’s even visible from here that not much goes on there. Shouldn’t there be a some people moving around, if there’s a rehearsal? Maybe it has already begun, and it’s just inside?
Adora sets her mind. “Okay, I got to get to Pier 17, Glim. Now.”
“Hey, do the interview, and you can do whatever you want.” Glimmer calls with a frown, and is unnerved, but Adora can’t really pay her attention now. “Just handle the interviews for me. I’ll talk to these guys—"
“This has to got to go on the nightly news, Adora. I can’t do that on your behalf. They wanna see you, not me!” Adora knows and can’t do otherwise, though.
“I got to see Catra right now,” is all Adora can say, and all Adora can think of. She knows these folks are messing with her appointment, and she has to get over there NOW!
Glimmer snatches her by the wrist and her voice sounds angry: “Adora! Every time we get close, you do something to mess this up.” Glimmer actually is pissed now, and Adora knows she has the right to be. She’s aware of how unreliable she must be looking, but seeking Catra is also important.
She looks her friend straight in the eyes, grabbing the woman at both arms. “This is different, Glimmer. Trust me.” Then Adora rushes away, leaving a ranting pink-haired bossy fury behind, and is sure that she will pay for this.

Adora jumps on a yellow New York Water Taxi that travels from Pier 1, where she held her speech, to Pier 15 at Manhattan on the other side and while they are on the East River, she convinces the driver to let her out at Pier 17, which they pass anyway.

Sometimes, being a well-known nice blonde has some perks, and she thanks the man gratefully. He gives her a pat and has seemingly enjoyed helping her a little by whatever the woman's up to. Usually, she would have taken the occasion for a short chat with a possible voter, but now she's in a hurry and has no mind for such stuff.
They approach Pier 17 from up front, and Adora thinks it's a shame in which way the iconic structure has been rebuilt after Hurricane Sandy. Before it, the building was a lively tourist spot with many local businesses and cultural venues, often used as a location for movies and such. It was a warm, welcoming place with many facets.
Nobody would use the boring glass and steel building that lacks any individuality standing here now for such things anymore, that much was for sure. The stuff built today looks the same everywhere.

But it's no time for ruminating, as the Water Taxi bumps into the bridge of the pier, and Adora jumps off. She runs up a few steps to the main level, and looks around at the long-stretched structure, but it seems not much in use today. Only a few passers-by scurry around, a couple is taking pictures at the waterfront, a few people sit at one of the bars, but nothing looks like that a rehearsal is in swing. She asks some people at the studio entrance, but no one has heard of anything.
And Adora is sure of two things: that Catra hasn't lied to her, and that this is *their* doing. But she knows Catra's company now, and with that info she picks her phone, types "Two Pines Dance Company New York" into the search and is quickly rewarded with… nothing. Zero search results. She frowns and shortly ponders if Catra has maybe told her a lie, but no, this isn't it. Catra wanted her to know. And zero results? This is ridiculous. This is them! She calls the information via phone.
"City, please?
"Manhattan." Adora says, and she's still a bit breathless from the running, but calms down now.
"What listing?"
"Two Pines. It's a dance company."

There is a short pause while the operator seems to search. "Connecting."

And the operator is gone, the line rustles shortly, then it falls silent. Adora looks puzzled at the display, where the message appears: 'Call failed.'
Whatever causes the fewest ripples, hmm? Bow was absolutely right. Everything smells of an interception, or rather, multiple interceptions. But if this is everything they have, she can handle it, she will punch right through this. She just has to arrive at Catra's studio before the rehearsal is over, to not let this day end on a possible sour note. She senses that this is somehow important for both of them.
Adora runs over to the cabin of a parking attendant below the FDR Drive. The small guard house should have what she needs.
"Excuse me, can I use your phone? I have an emergency."
She must at least look like someone worth a little help, and the man just nods at her, shrugging his shoulders and points at the phone beside him. Adora picks it up, but the line is dead as well. Looking at the device with a frown gets her nowhere, she tries it another time, but nothing. *Fuck them*, there are other options. She ignores the questioning stare from the attendant and rushes outside, over to Beekman Street in the search for another possibility. There's a restaurant and there will be other phones she can use, and she's going to find one that still works.

She doesn't know that Casta has cut down every phone line within three blocks. Adora hurtles around a corner, and directly runs into said Casta and her lackey, the pinched looking woman with the light hair. They block the sidewalk, and were obviously waiting for her. Hah, she knew it, and isn't really surprised.
"There's a whole world of women out there. I thought we established this one was off limits," Casta says without any greeting.
Adora retorts just alike: "It's been a while, I must have forgotten," and starts to walk past the two.
Casta sounds pissed, as they start to follow her. "Doesn't change the fact."
"You put us together three times," Adora hits back.

“That wasn’t us, that was just chance,” Casta informs her.
Adora frowns, because she can’t believe that. Then she decides she doesn’t care and asks: “Why do you wanna keep us apart?”
“Because the plan says so.”
“Then you misread the plan.” Adora is really getting unnerved, because why has this to matter to her?
“There is no misreading the plan when it comes to you and Catra.”
“Then the plan is wrong”, she complains loudly.
Casta huffs and puts herself before Adora, stopping her from walking. The other woman stands at the street side, effectively cornering Adora. “Do you know who wrote it?”
No, no she doesn’t, and these guys didn’t bother to tell her. If all of this is so important to them *and to her*, they just could’ve told her, right? And yes, maybe there’s someone from way up high, who has a plan for her, who has written a superbly crafted path for her life. But whoever this one is, he or she or it hasn’t involved Adora in doing so, and so it’s not hers. She does not have to follow anything, and her answer is firm: “I don’t care.”
That makes Casta scoff. “Well, you should. You should really show a little respect.”
Adora won’t answer on that, but she asks: “If I’m not supposed to be with her, how come I feel like this?”
The answer is cryptic, in the first place: “It doesn’t matter how you feel. What matters is what’s in black and white.”

Adora halts and frowns. The thing is, during the last years in politics and business, she got a real good sense for when people talk bullshit. It’s something you have to learn in order not to be drowned in meaningless conversations or demands. And these words don’t even sound like an answer that’s supposed to make any sense. They rather sound like some blah-blah she would’ve used herself, in situations when she doesn’t want to give an answer, because it would be hurtful, or too revealing.
Or, actually…, when she doesn’t have a clue. And looking into Casta’s eyes, it rather seems that…
“Oh! You don’t know why I’m not supposed to be with her, do you?”
She gets no answer, but a glare from darkening eyes. The woman

seems a bit off track now, but also slightly angry.
“That’s why you can’t tell me. You. Don’t. Know.”

Adora feels an urge to poke the woman’s chest at every single word, but she tries to control herself for once. Casta looks like she can hold her own, and another brawl on the day of Adora’s candidacy announcement is probably a bad idea anyway.
So, that is the point when Adora decides to ignore them. Yeah, they can threaten her, but they can’t kill her, and she’s starting to get a feeling that they even won’t lobotomize her, whatever she does, besides betraying their existence. The amount of effort these beings put into keeping *her* on track - on their precious *plan* - show that they want something from her.
And whatever it is, it’s something she obviously can’t do if she’s out. Adora needs to be alive, and well, and running. So she pushes aside the two folks with the gray hats and stomps off towards a restaurant. Behind her, she hears the other woman saying: “Uh-Oh”, but she ignores her, opens the doors and walks in. They will see what she’s able to do.

“Excuse me, everyone!” Adora calls out loud and raises her hands to get attention. She’s being looked at by around two dozen people who are in the middle of lunch break. “Sorry to disturb your lunch. It’s an emergency. Has anyone here ever seen a performance at the Two Pines Ballet Company?” She looks around at the puzzled folks, and is happy to look like someone not completely crazy, and repeats, “The Two Pines Ballet Company?”
The silent stares are unsettling, but then finally from somewhere at a table, a guy shouts: “Yeah, I have.”
Adora releases a deep sigh. “Okay, where is it?”
The guy rattles off an address at 26th Street, which is near the Hudson Yards, not far from the Hudson River and halfway up from here to Central Park on the other side of Manhattan. It would be an hour to walk there, but she can take a taxi. She thanks the man, then hurries outside on the hunt for a cab.

She runs back to where the FDR overpasses the street, and yells for a taxi. Several of the yellow cars pass by within a minute, but none of them stops. Adora can see their lights going off as they

approach her position at least thrice.
What. The. Fuck?
Above her, on the FDR, the traffic rushes by noisily and behind her, at a street corner, she sees Casta and the other woman lurking around, while she shouts "Taxi! Taxi!" another time, and waves with a hand, both hands now, actually.
"Maybe you should try the subway," Casta says cynically, and Adora immediately knows it's a trap. If she runs for the subway, they will fake an indefinite delay of the trains or just cut off power and trap her. They want to slow her down for long enough until the rehearsal is over and Catra's gone for the day. And then they will keep Adora away from the studio, or for something else to happen. ‘
And Adora thinks, that they can fuck off. She'll walk by foot if necessary. It'll take an hour, but she doesn't care.
"Don't all these taxis you're diverting have plans, too?" she etches. "How long are you going to keep that? Twenty minutes? An hour? Wow, the ripples must just be endless." Adora doesn't really have a clue if that's true and what *ripples* are anyway, but she walks off, back into the side street, chasing for a taxi or if that's not happening, then she'll just fucking walk. At some point, these people have to quit. Casta glares at her angrily, but doesn't say anything. She seems a bit confused.
"I don't care what you put in my way, I'm not giving up."

Adora starts jogging, and leaves Casta and her lackey behind, knowing about the angry stares she gets in her back. In the next side street, she spots another cab having its light on, and shouts behind the driver. "Taxxii! Hey! Heeeey! Wait!"
She runs down Water Street towards Brooklyn Bridge, and the car has already reached the next crossing under the Bridge, when the driver takes notice of the desperately yelling and waving woman behind him. He breaks, to Adora's relief, and the taxi comes to a halt twenty meters before her at the intersection. The driver waves at her to catch up. Adora's glad and slows a bit down in her running. Okay, these guys don't control everything, and that's—

A silver limousine crashes into the cab's passenger side. The impact is *loud*, and pushes the cab into a parking car at the side

of the street, window glass splinters around them, airbags go off. Adora stops in her running and stares at the accident in shock. What? Is that really happening? Is it an...
It takes her a second to shake out of her freeze, then she runs to the taxi driver, jumping over the hood of the parking car, which is now entangled with the cab's trunk. The driver hangs in the seatbelts, bleeding, but is conscious.
"You okay?" Adora asks.
The man groans, and blood is running down his head. He hangs in the belt and looks miserable. "Ugh... what?"
"You got hit, are you okay?"
"I… I think so," he stutters, but doesn't sound very well.
"Just don't move, I'll call an ambulance!"
Adora paces around the hood over to the other car. Its front is stuck into the right side of the yellow cab, and the driver is also in a haze, but he doesn't seem severely injured, only dizzy. The airbag has worked well for him and took most of the blast. "Don't move. Help is on the way," Adora calls, and gets a groan in return. She takes out her mobile, calls 911 and now the fucking thing works perfectly. The line connects immediately.
A calm, professional voice asks: "911, what's the emergency?"
"Hello! I just witnessed a car accident at the corner of Water and Dover Street. We need assistance, and ambulance. Two persons have been injured. Yes. No. Yes."
Luckily, she had trained this stuff and follows the five questions to the textbook, something in the back of her mind notices. Training is everything, Adora tells herself time and again.

Be it luck, prediction, or intent: the alarmed first responders arrive within a few minutes and take care of the injured drivers. Police also has shown up, and Adora is being questioned by an officer. He's actually the second officer who questions her after the female Sergeant, and after a few minutes in, she starts to wonder. Is this really necessary, because the questions are nearly the same as before. It's starting to unnerve her.
They stand a few meters away from the scene, the officer is kind, but he's repetitive, and it takes too much of her precious time.
"Unfortunately, you're the only witness, Congresswoman," the

officer apologizes with a not too worried face, and taps on his notebook with a pen.
Adora stops her urge to facepalm herself, because that is not appropriate in the presence of the law enforcement. Fortunately, no rubberneckers have shown up, because she really doesn't need pictures of herself, involved in an accident. But after all, it was just a minor car crash, and not very spectacular. "Yeah, okay, but we did this three times already."
"I just need a few more details," the officer insists.

This is when Adora starts to have a kind of feeling about this ongoing repetition, and takes a closer look at the man. He's looking like an officer, sure, but now that she has calmed down and takes in his appearance, something about him tells her… "Oh, I see. You're not even a cop, are you? You're one of them."
"Ma'am, calm down, please" the man replies, but now it sounds a little off.
Adora stares at him, but then *she decides*. She's done with the bullshit, says "Okay, and just so you know, someone could've been killed", and walks over to the female officer who's at the ambulance, and asks the woman: "Hey, Sergeant. Sorry, excuse me. I know you need a statement from me, but do I need to stay here, or can I do it over the phone?"
The officer is quick: "No, ma'am, we know how to get in touch with you. It's not that important."
"Okay, thank you. Now, is this man under your command?" Adora points back at the place where she talked with the other officer *seconds* ago, but the man is gone. Unsurprisingly. Adora resists the urge to curse and to make an idiot out of herself, but she can't prevent her hands balling into fists. "Never mind, thank you," she tells the sergeant and walks off the scene, heading for the FDR underpass to watch out for another cab.
She ponders shortly if Casta and her lackey are still around. She doesn't know if that accident was another adjustment, or chance, but if it was an adjustment, they seemed to have upped the game. Causing a real accident, with injuring people, is something different from just cutting the phone lines, or relocating a

rehearsal. People have been hurt, and Adora’s whole doing is aimed at not letting that happen.

Whatever they want from her - she’s less willing than ever to comply. Somehow, she has to get to Catra’s company, and maybe an hour left to do so.

Chapter End Notes

[1]For the last few sentences, I took inspiration from this little piece.↑

[2]Learn something about Patrick Daly here and here.↑

The next chapter is called "There are no rules!" and will be published next Friday, December 3rd. As always, comments are greatly appreciated.

There are no rules

Chapter Summary

> They were meant to be together, because they *were meant* to be together.
>
> And Adora's even cuter in person!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Hey, you wanna make a quick 100 bucks?” Adora practically shouts at the startled taxi driver. “You’re gonna have to break a couple of traffic laws, though.”
She'd been able to wave down another cab and is so excited about it that the man looks at her incredulously. And maybe because of the potential threat to his license. But then he takes the 100 bucks she’s practically throwing at him, and Adora calls: "All right, 26th and 10th. It’s a ballet company called Two Pines. Go!”

The taxi driver does an actual good job in rushing over red lights and doing this way too fast. They have driven up the FDR and turned into 25th East right behind Cooper Village, racing eastwards towards Madison Square Park now. Adora loves and hates Manhattan. The city is wonderful, it’s skyline stunning, the streets so lively and the whole metropolis is just full of beautiful places. She can discover something new every single day. But traffic is… ugh!

They clearly take notice how every single traffic light before them turns to fucking red. *Ripples, hah!* Adora doesn’t mind. The driver is irritated, because the lights don't behave like they usually do and hey, he knows his city. “Go through them. This is going to keep happening, just go through,” Adora assures him from the backseat.
“Ha, you sure? Looks like a perfect way to lose my license,

ma’am!” the driver replies troubled, while not moving his look. His voice is a bit thick, because he has to concentrate and evade a collision.
“Yeah, I promise, these red lights will continue until we’re there. Just ignore them. The others will have red, too.”
It gets her an insistent question: “Who are you even, lady?”
Adora huffs. “Just a woman on a mission to get herself a girlfriend.” Her reply is a bit absent-minded, because she catches sight of two figures with gray hats again, gesturing at her. They have to outrun these fellows who are influencing things around her, she fucking feels it, and her feeling is quickly confirmed when she sees Casta and her lackey jumping out of the door of some business building. She swears she can hear the black-haired woman cursing “Daughter of a bitch!” through the open window, but they are past them so fast. She sees them running towards another building, but then they’re around the next corner.

The driver has laughed at her stupid comment, and takes the whole thing as some kind of challenge now. He also noticed that at every crossing, all traffic lights have turned to red. Unintentionally, the folks with the plan have cleared the way for them. “They should’ve turned all to green. Idiots”, Adora murmurs. There’s no way these folks could have gotten there before them, and why would they jump out of some random building? It looks like they were a bit too late to stop her, but how the fuck did they even overtook her? It must have something to do with their handling of the doors, like when they brought her back from the hall into Glimmer's office, back then. She never forgot how impossible that was.

Adora shakes it off. It doesn’t matter. All that matters is that they reach the Two Pines before another adjustment can interfere with her finding Catra. She has the distinct feeling that she has to find her, today, or something else will happen and tear them apart again. They’ll find a way, she’s sure of it. And she can’t let that happen, no matter what.
She’s sitting in the back seat, and uses the opportunity to redo her ponytail. All the running made it go loose, and the strands hanging in her face now unnerve her. As everything is back in

place, they turn into 25th East at Madison Square Park, and Adora urges the driver to speed up. She's being followed by these folks, and has to reach Catra before they can stop her somehow.

Suddenly Adora is pressed into her belt because the driver breaks harshly, making them slow down and drives with just 20 mph max past a few buildings, shouting "Playground!" at Adora, right before she's pushed into her seat again when he stomps down on the accelerator. *Of course. Nothing could justify that,* Adora thinks. They are being honked at several times, and other drivers curse them for being so reckless, when they rush over 10th Avenue and beneath the trees of High Line, but despite all that, an unbelievable minute later, Adora jumps out of the taxi and approaches the reception door of the Two Pines Contemporary Ballet. The building isn't very tall, two triangular roofs enthrone a brick stone wall maybe eight meters high. Large glass windows, resembling the ones giving light into cathedrals, give it an industrial design. She pulls the door open with a rough grip, and a friendly brunette sitting behind a counter looks at her smiling.
"Hey," she greets Adora, "Late?"
"Uhm, hello, yeah. I'm Adora Grayskull, I'm here to see Catra. Is she here?"
"Yeah, she's in the studio," the woman replies, waving with a hand at a door to the side, not a care in the world.

Adora nods gracefully, lays her hand on the knob, and opens it. And she is caught by the sight of Catra, who—
Behind her, two people burst through the entrance door, and Adora looks back, still holding the door, now rather grabbing it. Adora turns towards the panting woman, and her gaze is lingering over both of them, half expecting to be dragged out of this building by force any moment.

But then Casta's fellow calls: "It's too late. She's already seen her."
"FUCK!" Casta spits out, panting, then she just wipes her forehead, and snarls: "You hit your ripple limit. Congratulations. Celebrate now. They're just going to kick it upstairs."

Adora feels slightly relieved. This doesn’t sound like an upcoming brawl, and they obviously don't want to drag her outside or so. She quickly turns her attention back to the woman she’s here for. The phone of Casta’s lackey is ringing, and the woman says, holding it to her: “It’s Weaver.”
Adora looks back over her shoulder to Casta, who has a facial expression that’s something between angry and scared. “You’ve no idea what you’re up against. This,” and she waves with the phone, “is going to be worse than I.” She looks defeated, though and despite her full-bodied words. Then both leave the entrance, and Adora has already turned around back and watches Catra through the partly open door. The woman is in the middle of her training, excercising with colleagues, and fully concentrated on her doing. Adora heaves a breath, puts her hand on the door, walks into the hall, and is going to get herself a girlfriend.

All in all, Casta had a good run in her duties, until the whole *Adora Grayskull-mess* started to happen. She’s not really angry at Bow, who does a good job to keep Grayskull on track, but he’s also doing this since a while, and maybe he got too attached to his ward over time. Today has been extraordinarily strenuous, and all the jumping-the-places took a good amount of energy from her. She’ll have to have a good night of sleep, after that, but before she can rest, there are still duties to do.

They have failed in preventing Grayskull from seeing Catra again, because her limits are strict, and she can’t do the things that would’ve been necessary. The things Weaver can do, for example. Or the other folks further up the food chain of the bureau. She walks into Eleven Madison and still misses the sight of the Art Deco Sky Bridge over 24th East Street. Her eyes had always been delighted by the element, but now it’s gone, demolished by these stupid morons. Sometimes, she really struggles to keep herself

together, because humanity is taking a lot of her patience away by just being the idiots they are on a daily basis.

Casta walks up one of the large staircases to an upper floor, down a ridiculous broad and high hallway, and sighs. She wants to knock at a certain door, knowing what's coming, when the door already opens and a woman with long black hair, in a dark reddish dress and a maroon mask over half of her face, comes out.
"Casta," the grating voice snarls, with the always on-spot patronizing attitude.
"Weaver," she states, as it isn't obvious. She never liked Weaver, and doesn't really know why the Chairman keeps her, but she - repeatedly - told herself that this isn't her business.
"I'd prefer you call me by my name. But let's take a walk," Weaver says, much too casually, in Casta's opinion. Usually, Weaver - Light Spinner - doesn't handle singular cases like *Adora Grayskull*. She has to oversee the handling of the Americas as a whole, watching and predicting aggregated paths of thousands of people in their oversight, making recommendations of general adjustments and getting legal on them when the ripples are large. Very large. Her recklessness and involvement in managing all the interconnected threads of life earned her the nickname she carries for long.

They walk down the hallway and enter a room. It's large and high, and there is a massive amount of wooden shelves, reaching four meters high and maybe seven meters long, at both sides of a middle line where some low sideboards stand.
They stroll into the room, where two other people are already there, rummaging around.
Weaver monologues: "The intense chemistry between Grayskull and Driluth, the constant appearance of inflection points, and the kicker, you pulling them apart twice only to have chance put them back together… Even if your abilities are not so overwhelming, all that seemed at little much to us. So, I asked Entrapta to do some research this morning." She points at a woman who has rummaged at one of the shelves and has already several folders before her. "Entrapta," Weaver snarls loudly, and her voice makes the woman jump. Her extremely long pigtails turn with her head

and make everything look a bit ominous. She clumsily picks up the folders and rises.

"Have you been here before?" Weaver asks Casta condescendingly, glaring at her with pity, and before she can even answer, Weaver cuts in again: "No, of course you haven't." Then she turns to Entrapta: "Tell us what you have found."
The weird pigtailed woman is obviously overly excited to share her knowledge. Casta has only heard of, but never seen her. If she stays in this… odd library that looks like some archive of her own, it's no wonder.
"Oh, yes. Well, it seems like Adora Grayskull and Catra Driluth were meant to be together, because they *were meant* to be together," Entrapta says it a bit too lively for Casta's taste.
But that is… "Wait, what?" Casta asks.
Weaver points at the shelves containing thousands of archived versions of *the plan*, that the Chairman let to be archived here for studying them in case of need. "In the 90s, when she was born, they were meant to be together, same thing in the 70s, the 80s, the Zeros. It wasn't until 2010 that the plan changed, and Catra was supposed to stay with Scorpia."
Entrapta has put an old plan book on the sideboard before them. It is an archived version, nothing moves, just frozen lines, curves and crossings, no inflection points. She puts her finger at a certain line, where it crosses another one. It takes Casta a bit to digest the information. "That means…"
The archivist continues explaining, not as enthusiastic as before: "The problem here is, there are remnants from all those old plans that keep pushing them together. They still feel like they belong with each other even though they don't, and we're about to tear them apart again. And there's an imbalance in the primary radiant __"
"Entrapta, that's enough!" Weaver shouts. The eyes of the creepy woman are sparkling with fury, but Casta has heard enough. She knows little about the force and meaning the primary radiant has for all of them, but she knows that an imbalance is serious.

And now she understands why her own efforts have been so insufficient. And why Bow had the difficulties he had. If there are

still relics of these old plans manifesting everywhere in Adora's and Catra's life, it's no wonder they ran into each other today. But how? How was it possible that a plan of someone like Grayskull changed so much? That smells very much like an *interception*, and the irony is not lost on Casta. The Chairman doesn't like such radical changes, and very seldom makes them, that much even she knows. But throughout her service, she hasn't heard that anyone else lay hand on the plan itself beside them. She senses that there is something to this fact, but she doesn't know enough.

Casta is still stunned, when she leaves Light Spinner - Weaver - and walks back to her office. Her haze has only dimmed a bit when she passes through the Reading Room, where she finds Bow. This is his usual place, when he's not outside in the field. She always wondered why the man preferred this open space instead of one of the nice and cozy offices, but it's also not like she has a say over where he does his job as long as he does it.

"You spend your whole career hoping, someday, you'll get a red-letter case. Something you can really make a name for yourself with. And finally you get one, it's booby-trapped," she says, with a reluctant and resigned attitude.
Bow looks up from his writing, frowning: "What?"
Casta leans over while she fumbles with her hat, and her voice sounds sad: "I'm saying, it wasn't your fault. They were meant to be together."
"What?" The accentuation is different from before. The first one was rather surprised, pitched a bit too high. This one puts the emphasis on the whole word, like a shot, like a sharp-worded sentence.
"Were. In an earlier version of the plan. Actually, a dozen earlier versions. I always wondered how we had such bad luck that she was on that particular bus on that particular day. "
Bow gets it. He leans back into his seat and his eyes are fixed at some place far beyond. Because he studied Grayskull's plan for a long time. Her entire life, actually, and there's one important question to this - because this detail has obviously been hidden from him. "How could a plan just change like that?"

“I don’t know. It’s above my pay grade. But I have a bad feeling about it, though. However, Weaver’s going to handle it from now on.”
Bow looks horrified. “Weaver? Oh, no. The old hag hasn’t done a field operation like that within a century, has she? She’s no handler, no field officer—"
Casta cuts in, waving him down with her hand dramatically. “She’s not doing it herself, Bow. She’ll send someone from up above.”
Yeah, because - and that’s the only good thing on this forsaken day - Weaver, despite the influence the woman has, doesn’t have the leeway to do what is probably needed in case of Adora Grayskull. Anyway, however important Grayskull is, it’s weird that she obviously has such a personal interest in this.

Unfortunately, her solution is worse.
Casta still shudders at the memory of her conversation with Weaver a quarter of an hour before.

“So, *you* wanna go operational on this?” Casta asked with slotted eyes after Entrapta had left the archive. She doesn’t trust Weaver, never has, but she acknowledges that someone has to handle the mess Grayskull created. Weaver, on the other hand, doesn’t trust anyone, and her methods are seldom of the kind sort. Her reply is as condescending as ever: “No one ever made it to my job by taking stupid risks.”
Casta suppresses a bitter chuckle, but she can fully assess how Weaver stuck to that saying during her whole career. “So, what are we going to do?”, she asks concerned.
Weaver gives her another patronizing run over, before she replies slick: “We? Do nothing. We’re going to kick this case upstairs, to someone with the latitude to clean up this mess without breaking into a sweat. We’re going to bring this to Light Hope.”

Now she can’t suppress the curse: “Fuck! Whoa, hold on a second. I know Grayskull is off track, but it’s not that bad, isn’t it?” The cold stare she gets makes Casta shiver, but she wants to try: “We shouldn’t do this to Grayskull. When Light Hope was out the last time, her nickname was…”
Weaver emptily grins at her. “The Ghost, yes. She’ll crush this little

romance with a flick of her hand and force them back on plan again till the morning."
Weaver says this like it's a given and like she's enjoying it, and Casta fears that the mean bitch is actually right. Keeping Grayskull on track is one thing, but sending out Light Hope is… something else. It's like fixing a broken window by tearing the house down. She frowns, still, and tries to get a read of Weaver's face, but the little part she can see of it due to the weird mask gives nothing away.

Light Hope.
Ugh, that's not good.
She has a bad feeling.

Adora feels incredible. This is literally the best day of her life. She'd never had such an overwhelming feeling from just holding someone by the *hand*. And that's actually all she's doing. It's just that this is Catra's hand, which is laying in her own one, and ever since they met at the Two Pines, no one intercepted them again. Even Glimmer is silent, maybe due to the fact that Adora threatened to force her to go shopping with Adora for a full make-over. They did this once, and it turned out to be a… mediocre idea, to say the least. Ever since, Glimmer just tells her what to wear, and Adora wears it, and it works perfectly fine.

"Glimmer, I'll be yours tomorrow again, but for now, let me have this. It's perfect, and I'm not going to let her go." Glimmer chuckles about the firmness in Adora's voice. "Have this, babe! I can yell at you tomorrow. And I will," she chimes. Adora can imagine Glimmer's petty smirk through the phone line. The woman is going to have a field day, that much is for sure, but it's worth it.
"Counting on it, princess," Adora retaliates, before silencing and pocketing the phone.

Catra looks at her with a frown. "That sounded very familiar, so to say." There is a small edge to Catra's voice, and Adora has the slightest inkling why that is so.

"Are you jealous? Oh, that's so embarrassing for you," Adora chuckles, but she grips Catra's hand firmly and strikes over its back with her thumb. She doesn't even know when they started holding hands, but she knows she won't stop as long as Catra doesn't. "But yes, we are. Glimmer and I have known each other since we were kids. We love each other, but it's ab-so-lute-ly platonic. And businesslike. And because of Glimmer's need for drama. And dresslike, of course! I would be lost without her. I would've shown up in sweatpants and a T-shirt today, but Glimmer keeps me on track," Adora giggles. "She will be the most perfect, overbearing, caring, controlling and exhausting girlfriend and wife to some unknown man she has still not met. I love her, and I'm lucky that I'm not this poor guy. She'll make his life hell, but it will be the best possible hell that is. He won't even be able to tell the difference from heaven."
They both giggle at Adora's vivid description, and then fall back into a flowing conversation, they laugh and chuckle, when they tell each other more stories from the recent three years, while they walk through autumnal New York and day turns into evening turns into night. The brunette woman is funny, Adora thinks again and again, and the longer they talk and walk, the more both of them loosens up. Now Catra laughs out loud at a stupid joke Adora made, and her hand grips Adora's a bit more tight. It sends a feeling of warmth and want through her body and makes her stomach tingle. This is great.

Night has long fallen, and they're near the East River, in a quiet side street, where traffic has died down for hours, probably. They walk along the street, actually in the middle of it, and a short, but not unwelcomed silence falls upon them.
"I want to go to a club!" Catra suddenly states, and Adora isn't really surprised. Given their whole conversation since they left the Two Pines, Catra actually seems like someone eager to party away when she's excited. And they both feel the atmosphere between them sparkling from joy and energy, and maybe this energy needs

a way out of Catra. She’s a dancer, after all.
But on the hand, Adora doesn’t want the evening to end in a club, with both of them sweaty and wasted. They have a superbly good run so far, enjoying a flowing back and forth of joking, sometimes more serious topics, then mutual teasing and plenty of laughing. They didn’t kiss again, though.
Adora spoke a bit about her career and the years since they met, and Catra told about her recent discovery that she actually took a liking to outline the entire choreography of the dances, instead of just dancing. She’s aiming at inventing a whole new form of character dance in a piece she’s developing with her colleagues. Adora gets how lively Catra is when she speaks about that, how much joy and energy she puts into this, and in her opinion, they could talk just more, maybe kiss again, maybe—

But a club means rather no talking, and Adora really had a long day, half of which she can’t tell Catra, and she just wants to be close to the woman, not being afraid to lose her again.
“Oh! Why ruin a really nice day?” Adora says mockingly, with a hint of seriousness behind.
“Come on!” Catra says, because she doesn’t want this evening to end, and she really needs a way to let all this energy inside her out. And maybe - when they dance - she can touch Adora in a more close way, getting nearer to the woman, just like she wants to for the last hours.
Adora bats it away. “No, I don’t dance.”
“And I don’t do solo dance. For now,” Catra ribs, and touches Adora’s lower arm where she had rolled up her sleeve. It feels like Catra's fingers slide over it, and Adora’s throat is suddenly so dry. Why is her throat so dry? The feeling of Catra’s finger on her bare skin is heating her up.
“Oh, come on. Everyone can dance. You just feel the music.”
“Well, I’ve been told that I have trouble feeling. Multiple times, so I tend to believe it.”
Catra shoots her a smirking grin: “Who told you that?”
“A long— a very short list of women, yes!" Adora tries to retract, but it’s too late.
“That’s gross!” Catra nudges Adora’s shoulders, and pats her

playfully, then she points to the end of the street they walk along: "You know what? Let's race to that lamppost!" Catra points at a lamppost twenty meters before them. They've been walking in the middle of the street, because it's so late that the traffic had died down to nothing in this quarter.
"Race you? What are you, five?" Adora giggles.
Catra grins. "You win, I dance for you. I win, you dance for me." Uh-oh, here they are again, these pictures in her head. Of the stringy, accentuated woman, in underwear. In very skimpy underwear.
"On the pole?" Adora asks with wide eyes.
"If you like, yeah." Catra's answer does many things to Adora's imagination, and none of them are decent.
"What are the rules?" Adora asks with a grin, feeling a spark of competitiveness.
"There are no rules." Catra says.

But her next words are less smugly and rather outraged, because Adora started to run at her last word. The only thing Adora hears is Catra shouting: "Oh, you bastard, oh my gosh!" She starts running behind Adora, and her high heels clatter against the pavement. Adora turns around and runs backwards now, laughing: "You challenged me in those shoes?! I can't believe it." She's meters before Catra, giggles and giggles, and it gets Catra waving with her hands in the air in defeat. "Okay, fine, you know I can't. You're right. These are the wrong shoes, and I'm going to twist an ankle."
Adora's stops and is still laughing while she lets Catra catch up: "You said 'no rules'. I avoided them, and OW—"

Catra had reached her, waggishly beats Adora in the gut, and she hadn't been exactly gentle. Adora bows and gasps for air, while Catra cackles loudly, runs beside her and is at the lamppost before Adora even recovers from the low blow.
"You said you had trouble feeling," Catra laughs, jumps up and down like a little child and feels obviously great. "Wow! I won! You dance for me! Wohoo!"
Adora swears to herself she is going to pay Catra back. But with the sight of the vividly laughing woman before her, whose curls fly

around her head so funnily, so beautiful, she can’t do anything besides smile.
“Great! I hate you!” she shouts.
“Awww, princess. I don’t think so. I think you actually like me,” Catra teases back. Adora strolls closer to the still laughing and chuckling woman. When she stands before Catra, she takes her hand, puts it at her own lips and says tenderly “This is not because I like you.” Then she places a hand kiss on Catra’s hand, while she doesn’t take her look away.
The other woman falls silent, and her eyes pull wide, but she says nothing. Only two very sparkly mismatched eyes are glancing at Adora, who has the cockiest grin on her face ever seen under the moonlight.

This is so awesome.

Catra leads - or rather drags - Adora to a club that is located in an old factory hall and of which Adora had no clue it even existed despite the fact that THIS IS HER HOOD. They made it over to Brooklyn, and Adora decides that for once in her life it shall not matter that she has no clue what’s going to happen, because she’s here with Catra, and everything feels just perfect. She can’t let Catra out of her sight, even without the lingering threat of the folks with the plan. And even if none of them showed up since Casta left her behind, she *doesn't want* to let Catra out of her sight.
They dive into the crowd, which is dancing in the large hall. Above them, colorful spotlights twirl according to the music. It's disco upbeat, and the bass goes right through them. They are surrounded by party people, Catra starts dancing immediately, and after a few moments, Adora follows her with less graceful moves. She doesn't care, because all she wants is to stay near Catra.

“Hey Adora!”
“Look, it’s Adora Grayskull. Whoa!"
“You’re even cuter in person!”
“Yo woman! You’re the best!
“I voted for you!”

“Thaaaank you. How’re doing? How are you? Hey, good to see you guys.” Adora takes hands left and right, shakes them, pats on shoulders and gives high-fives to complete strangers. When she started her political career, she didn't like doing these completely senseless stuff, and it felt weird all the time. But over the years, she got used to it. People like and need this type of attention from their elected leaders, and if there's something Adora’s good at, it's to please people. She genuinely cares about her duties as a Congresswoman, and takes her time to listen to citizens. Not all their concerns are really relevant, and she’s seldom in the position to help immediately, because she’s a legislator, and not in the executive. But it shows to everyone that she’s authentic and truly wants to help. It is one of the reasons why she was elected the first time and now, with some years of experience in the field, she puts this trait to a better-leveled use.

So, what does it matter that she doesn’t know who these people are. It’s not important. They are possible voters, they are friendly, despite being mostly drunk, and the mood is actually cool and easy. All the stuff verbally thrown at her is nothing in comparison to the political maneuvers and accusations she has to deal with since her election into the House. It’s actually super-relaxing to be on the receiving end of all this nonsensical chatter and blah-blah total strangers grace her with, in comparison to what she has to endure in an all-day-long-meeting with representatives of all the parties that want something from her.
All these people here in the disco want is a friendly word of encouragement, a nod, a smile, sometimes a picture for their media account or whatever. It’s something she can totally relate to, and as being kind doesn’t cost her anything, she just does it. It’s just another part of her duty to serve the people.

“How are we feeling about this tie?” Catra purrs into Adora’s ear, when they again fell into a mutual dance, and the woman fiddles with said thing, half-slung around her.
“Maybe I should go home and get my tux?” Adora replies, deeply in need to untangle from Catra, because it’s getting her flustered.
“Definitely don’t do that. It’s good.” The woman is very near, when she pulls Adora’s tie over her head.” It makes Adora’s heart race

more, and that is adding to the amount of racing it already does because of the dancing and stuff.
Yes, Adora dances, thanks to the brunette menace to womanhood right before her, that made her forget about her holy oath not to dance anymore at all eight years earlier. Were it eight? Bah, who cares!
"I should have never come back here again without my backup dancers," Adora jokes.

Catra is now dancing around Adora, throwing her hands in the air and waving them according to the beat. It's clear to everyone that they are here together, people are looking at them in awe, another one shouts "Grayskull, you're a rock star!" and there are several hollers and cheers to be heard.
Catra seems a bit jealous about all the attention Adora obviously gets from some other women here, dancing and standing, watching them. Occasionally, one of them comes closer, only to be met with a death stare from narrowed eyes. Adora couldn't care less about these advances, because she has just eyes for Catra. But the obvious jealousy flatters her, and so she doesn't object when Catra finally slings her arms around Adora's neck, dances closer, and brushes her lips over Adora's cheek.

Huh… it's getting hot in here, Adora thinks. And yes, it's hot in here, but it may also be because of the alluring woman with the brown curls and mismatched eyes dancing before her so gracefully, that is the reason for it. Her gaze is fixed on the brunette, barely leaving her at all. And it looks like that doing is mutual.

"Did you grow up over here?" Catra asks, when they finally call it a night, somewhere long after midnight and leave the club. They stroll out of the hall, side by side, and Adora's hand is back in Catra's. She doesn't want to let Catra go, fearing to lose the physical connection so deeply, she just grabbed her hand

immediately when they went through the gate of the hall. It was an instinctive action, and Catra seems to be okay with it, as she quickly wove their fingers together.
Adora nods, and points at a direction eastwards: "Yeah, three blocks over that way. Pioneer Street. My whole childhood."
"Really?" Catra's look is opaque, then asking.
"Yeah, I mean, I hung around a lot at Coffey Park, but it was not so nice as today, back then. They called it—"
"The Fright Zone, I know. What were you like as a kid?"
"Uhm… I've spent about half my time in the principal's office up until the sixth grade," Adora admits, but she's also amused.
"Wow. That sounds… like you, actually."
"Yeah, but that was when my mother and my sister died within a month of each other. I got a bit more responsible later."
"Oh, I'm so sorry," Catra mouths, fearing she has overstepped because of the uncertain territory. She already knows that, but—
"No. It's fine, I mean, it's not fine, but it's been a few years."
Adora shortly ponders how to continue from such an unintentional bummer, but she feels she has to elaborate a bit on that. Despite not really knowing the alluring woman very well, she has a feeling that she can trust her with that: "You know how I always tell that story about how I got inspired to go into politics because my dad took me to the Senate Gallery, and we sat together and that's true." Catra nods, because she has actually heard of that. It's not that Adora Grayskull is a nobody, and that Catra hasn't seen the blonde politician on television several times. Nope, absolutely not.

"Real Kiss" (Deezer / Spotify)

"Uhm, but what I leave out is he did that right after they died. And I was bottoming out. So, he wanted to get me out of here for a little while. And he planned this road trip to DC, and I think it's because JFK was his idol. And we went and sat in the gallery."
Adora gulps and takes a breath, because she needs air, because this is not so easy. Memories flood in, and Catra is just silent. She watches the tall woman before her, who is seemingly struggling, and her eyes don't leave Adora's for a second. As does her hands. Somehow, Adora feels a bit grounded due to Catra not letting her hands go. "I remember watching him watch them. He was so

captured by the debate, I don’t even know anymore what they were talking about, but what I know is that at that point I knew that that’s what I wanted to do. And I wish… I wish they were here to see all this. I wish my mom...” She nervously gestures around her, half-heartedly at herself, and Catra gets it.
Adora tries to continue. “I was—" but falls dry and has water in her eyes because of pictures fading in, glimpses of her family, of her mom cooking dinner in the evening. Her sister, preparing for her duties within the army. She doesn’t think about the loss of her family very often, not in this way, but now she realizes what she just said, what she admitted to a person she barely knows.
Catra’s look is still fixed on her, and it is also still fixed on her when she raises her hand and touches Adora’s cheek very, very slightly.
Adora’s throat is hoarse: “Didn’t expect to tell you any of that. I’m sorry if I ruined this.” She falls silent, gulps one time, feels not so good and presses her mouth shut. She should’ve—

But it seems that she hasn’t ruined anything.

Catra’s hand still lingers on her cheek, strikes it pliantly, and now she curls it around her neck, drawing Adora closer to her. Her eyes are fixed at Adora’s, they are dark and wide open, and her face looks soft and caring. Catra is so beautiful, is all Adora thinks.

It’s in the middle of the night, and they are at the waterfront, the East River is calmly lapping at the bridge right beside them. It’s chill, but it’s not cold, and before her is someone radiating warmth and a feeling of home. Boats still cross the river, releasing some distant noise to wash over the bay, but all Adora can see are two mismatched eyes locked on hers, and all she feels is the hand at her neck.
She doesn’t move, would never resist, doesn’t even dare to breathe when Catra shuffles forward, slings the other arm around her neck, opens her mouth a bit and draws Adora in for a kiss. They’ve kissed before, but this is different. It’s like a first time that counts, and it resonates within Adora on a much deeper level. Adora’s hands hang limply by her side until she remembers she has them, and she finally wraps them around the woman she’s

been looking for for three damned years.
Three years have passed since their first kiss, and now it's a dream coming true. Her eyes are watering, her heart is racing, because *this, this is it*. If she's going to sacrifice something for it, she's up to take that fight. Kissing Catra again is worth it.

Later, when they do more kissing, in Catra's bed, Adora doesn't think of anything else anymore. She hasn't thought of anything beside *Want Want Want* during the last hour. Feeling the soft strokes on her back and how trusting Catra glances into her eyes from beneath makes her happy. Catra is everything she wanted for the last three years. She's so happy, grinning the whole time when they aren't kissing. Somewhere after they laid down, Adora asked, "Is this too fast?", and it earned her another heated kiss and a woman desperately pulling the blouse over Adora's head to get her out of her clothes quicker. If she had any doubts about being too fast, they are wiped away, when Catra fires her underwear into a corner and lays back, snuggling into the sheets under Adora again, completely naked, with open arms.
While they make love with each other, the world is gone, and there's nothing else than the heated and tender woman in her arms. Adora has never felt so happy for a very long time.

Finally, Adora lays her head down on Catra's chest, and feels the soft petting of Catra's hand over her hair down to her shoulders. Adora is sure that she loves this woman. It would be ridiculous to pretend anything else. She always has, since three years, and she knows it's ludicrous. *Tomorrow, I will tell her*, is the last thing she thinks before she falls asleep, embraced and sheltered, not being alone, for the first time since her childhood.

In the next morning, Adora doesn't wake Catra, when she slips out of the bed quietly and goes to fetch some fruits, croissants and two cups of coffee from a little shop at the corner. She wants

to surprise the sleeping woman with breakfast, and hasn't found anything in the fridge or shelve that would be adequate to do it. Catra's apartment is super cozy and sweet, and when she comes back, Catra has seemingly just woken up, because she's still in the bed - the bed where they've been sleeping together last night - but she's on the phone and talks to some woman called Scorpia. Adora hands her one of the coffee's and smiles at the beautiful and still naked woman, then she retreats to the kitchen to let Catra speak with whoever that is. She feels a bit nervous about the call and quietly listens.

"Because I was sleeping. No. No it's not. Why are you calling, Scorpia? Okay, well, I gotta go. No, I gotta go. Bye."
Catra puts down her phone and wraps herself in the sheets, covering her boobs and looking at Adora who now pleasures herself with a croissant and her coffee.
"Everything okay?" Adora asks, because Catra looks so puzzled. She has a strange expression on her face. Maybe Adora shouldn't have left the bed without waking Catra up?
"Yeah. But… that was so weird. I woke up and you weren't here." Catra doesn't sound accusing, but Adora feels a pang. She just should've stayed in bed and snuggle Catra all day long. Waking up beside her was such a deeply satisfying feeling, that it was outright insane to leave the bed. But she had to pee, and the duties of this day will arrive all too soon. Stealing the last day off from them was already borderline, but she won't escape Glimmer's wrath when she doesn't keep her appointments today.
Catra doesn't notice Adora's wincing and rambles along: "And then the phone rang, and it was my ex, which is just so strange."
Adora is only a bit concerned at first. "Sorry, I guess we hadn't gotten to any of that stuff yet, huh?" She smiles at Catra, downing her concerns, then asks: "How have you been?"
"Right. You know, we broke up a while ago, and it's over, and then she calls four times in one morning."

And that's the point when Adora's worries grow. Not because of Catra. They've just spent a night together. But… "She called you four times this morning?" That doesn't sound like a normal doing, just out of a sudden, after being apart for months. Catra just

hums, she doesn't get Adora's suspicious tone.
Adora tries her best to sound casual when she asks: "How long have you guys been broken up?"
"Uhm, three months. It's like she knew I was with someone else." Catra smiles at these words, but that doesn't make it so much better.
Because that reeks. It's reeks so much of an *adjustment* that even Adora can smell it from over there. "Was it serious?"
"We were engaged." Catra admits, a bit reluctantly. That is news to Adora, news she obviously has to digest because there is a knot in her stomach now, and "Oh," is the first and only sound that escapes her mouth. Okay, she has to capture that slip-up.
"So, not really that serious," she tries to sound funny and forces a smile.
"Right," Catra chuckles, because it's reminding both of them of their bantering from the night before. After all, *they just spent the night together, goddammit!*
"Well, what happened?"
Catra exhales audibly and looks a bit unsteady, unsure. "Do you want to know this?"
Adora cocks her head with a small grin. "I want to know, but you don't have to say anything about this to me. It's not really my business. But I admit that I'm curious, you know?"

A sighing Catra looks at her, and after a few silent moments she speaks: "She was a great guy. Is, actually. A brilliant choreographer and a very good dancer, and… uhm… we have the same group of friends. We had known each other a long time, and… I really like her. She's a good friend."
Adora wants to punch Scorpia in the face, even if the woman sounds really nice. How dare she being nice to Catra! Oh, uhm, well, it's obviously good that people are nice to Catra, for sure, but— *Ugh!*
"Well, she sounds great. Why didn't you marry her?" She has put a lot of effort into letting this sound like an okay question, and not like the question of someone who's furious with envy. She just hopes that at some point of this story, Scorpia turns out to be an

absolute asshole she can loathe or let be thrown into the Hudson —

"Because of you."

Catra just stated these three words after staying silent for about fifteen seconds or so, and Adora is speechless. She settles down on the bed beside Catra and looks at her, says nothing, is just there, exists, like it's the first time in years.
Catra purses her lips and continues: "I'm not some hopeless romantic. I've never allowed myself to be that way. But once I felt, even for a moment, what I felt with you…"
Adora is shattered at the admission. She feels exactly the same. For three years, no one stood a chance, never sparked enough interest out of her to make her feel something more than lukewarm friendship.
Catra pulls a corner of her mouth, and the next second she's back to the Catra Adora got to know so well, the snippy, clever, witty woman. "You ruined me," she snarks, but is serious again when she continues. "I didn't want to settle for less."

Adora takes in the weight of these few words. She understands the meaning of them, and when she answers, she's confident and open: "I know the feeling."
Catra's voice doesn't waver, but it's just a whisper when she says: "It scares the shit out of me."
Adora shakes her head lightly, barely visible. "I'm not gonna hurt you."
"You don't need to say that."
"I'm not going to hurt you," she repeats firmly and strikes Catra's arm. She thinks about if it's a good idea to tell Catra what really goes through her mind, because until now everything they said, they did, they admitted to each other just clicked. It clicked, and didn't feel too much at any point. Saying, "*I love you*", is just what she knows how she feels, and she's sure of that, but it's maybe a bit over the top after *one* mutual night. Adora wants to say it, but she holds it back. Maybe it will be okay after the second night.
"This is the first time in 15 years that I don't feel like I'm by myself."

Catra makes an “Oof,” and they both giggle a bit. “That’s a lot of responsibility for me. I don’t know if I’m quite comfortable with that.”
“Well, too late,” Adora chuckles. They look at each other, holding hands, both not wanting to let the mutual silence go, but they’re also unsure what to do now. Make out again?

The pause lets Adora remember that she has actual duties today, and if only not to run the risk of being murdered by an angry campaign manager. “You know, I could stay with you in bed the whole day, really.” She touches Catra’s cheek again, and the woman leans into it with closed eyes. It's quite a challenge not to pull the covers off her and press her back onto the bed. “It’s only that if I wanna have a few more days of my life, then I’m supposed to go to an interview right now. Glimmer will murder me if I don’t.” She grins playfully, shrugs her shoulders and takes Catra by the hand. “But, what if I told you that I’m not ready to let you out of my sight quite yet?”
Catra knows that she doesn’t want to let go of Adora either. Adora is here, she is by her side, after so long, and she doesn’t want to part from her so quick. She briefly thinks about what appointments she has for today, but she actually can postpone everything. So she nods firmly. “Sounds good.”
Her words make Adora beam like a spotlight. “You wanna go?”
“Yeah.” A simple and honest answer.
“All right.”

When both women step out of Catra’s apartment house and mirthfully walk to the subway station, they don’t take notice of the tall and slender figure with the hat, that stands in the shadow of a tree beside the street, watching them with a concerned, calculating face. They write a remark into a plan book, and when Adora and Catra turn around a corner, they seem to vanish into thin air. No one notices the strange event.

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is called "I tried to reason with you" and will be published next Friday, December 10th.
As always, comments are greatly appreciated.

I tried to reason with you

Chapter Summary

"My name is Light Hope," she says.
"How ironic. You really have it with the odd names, huh? Must be pesky. And what happened to free will?" Adora accuses her, and they immediately understand each other.
"We actually tried free will before."

Brace for impact.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"So, are you just so handsome, or is it that Washington is so populated by… I don't wanna say, hideous abnormalities—"
"This is getting a little weird, Trevor," Adora knocks it away, and the audience laughs. Trevor Noah raises his hands in mock defeat: "Okay, okay. I should have said it in a way even a politician can understand."
Adora touches her chest over her heart with her right hand and makes a grimace. "Ouch, the betrayal." But then she smiles devilish: "Maybe before you do that, you should get your nice ass out of that comfy chair and do some real work out there, to get to know what you're talking about. Congress' always there, huh?", Adora mocks him back, and the audience actually gets it. There are many 'Oooohs' and some 'Whoooos' to be heard.

Catra has a field day in front of the TV. She's cackling with joy in a waiting room of the studio, from where she's watching this awesome back and forth chit-chat since it began. She didn't want to be seated in the studio and is perfectly fine having this room for herself. Watching Adora pouncing back Trevor's clever sayings is just like a tennis match between them, that goes on for twenty minutes now. She's not able to declare a winner, and that's fine. Catra has her feet up on the couch, leans over casually, and

laughs loudly to herself at every well-intended joke of them both while she nips on her drink.

And Adora hasn't finished. "Because some of my fiiine colleagues in the House would love to have a word with you!"
Trevor makes puppy eyes. "Ow, that sounds terrifying, Congresswoman. As if I was partisan, huh?"
Adora laughs. "Come on. I've been so nice to you. And hey, you know what?"
"Oh noooo, now comes the tax increases! Everybody, get outtaaa heeeere!" Trevor shouts, gesturing at the audience, shoving with arms and hands, and again there is much giggling and chuckling in the studio.
She waves it away and winks at the people: "That comes later, Trevor. You know, after the election. Not before, that would be stupid of me! You do the taxing *when* you got elected, people aren't dumb."
"Ohhh, so *that's* the reason why your folks always lose. You should give them this advice, you know, for 2028. Or do you wanna keep it secret, keep it safe, because it's your precious and you wanna use it as your magic weapon when you run for—"
"Shshsh, you promised! You promised not to spill it, Trevor," Adora laughingly shouts and pats him on the shoulder, her ponytail whirling around, the audience again giggling.
He smirks and cocks his head. "A female president doesn't sound so bad? I mean, it's 2025 and even the USA is finally getting there, huh. Even the Germans got it done."
Adora has the broadest grin on her face when she replies: "What should I say, Trevor? Can't outrun your fate." Her voice pitches and draws it out at the end. She giggles at the usage of the line, because it's out of the speech from yesterday, and she loves the phrase Glimmer put in.

Everyone who's laughing now knows they are just joking. Adora is still just a candidate for the Senate, and she's young, very young, regarding all the other aspirants to this certain office in the next few races. But Catra has leaned forward, and she watches Adora's face insistently during these sentences. Something in Adora's expression tells Catra that she's not just kidding. There's a hidden

truth in it. She sees it in the corner of her eyes, and knows that she will have to ask Adora later what's up to this. She can't be serious about running for the Presidency, that would be too much, even for her. Adora's cocky and confident, competitive to an almost unbearable amount, but she's not that stupid, huh?

Trevor goes over it: "Okay, keep that in mind. So, what did you wanna say before?"
Adora makes puppy eyes at him. "I love the in-between with Anna.[3] Can I do this when I'm elected?" She looks at him with the begging blinking of a golden retriever, with her large gray-blue eyes, the long blonde hair, formed into the usual stupidly cute ponytail and the even more stupidly cute signature hair poof. The dark white suit with the golden stripes she wears so often in the public suits her like armor and only adds to that impression.
Trevor sighs and ruffles his hair. "Oh my god, allowing that was such a mistake. Ever since that happened, everybody comes around and asks me this. These are MY in-betweens," he complains loudly, nearly whining, "and now it's like all the people like it more than the rest of the show."
Adora chuckles: "Yeah, well, can't blame them, huh? Then next time, I just bring Anna with me, and we make it together?"
Trevor laughs hard and short at the backhand before he answers: "Okay, Anna's already taken, but I can promise you the following: you bring a handsome girl with you, and then we do the in-between together."
Adora claps her hands and squeals with joy, barking out a loud laugh. Of course, he would rely on her single life, which is no secret to the public. Only that such a handsome girl is just waiting for her outside, in this very studio, and he doesn't know it. Haha! This is so great.
"Deal!" She holds out her hand and Trevor strikes.

"Adora Grayskull, everybody," he shouts, and this is her sign to leave.

Adora stands up, makes finger guns at Trevor, waves at the audience and waits until the cheers die down a little. Walking out of the studio, she takes out her phone and scrolls through the

incoming messages. This was a fucking awesome publicity stunt, and Glimmer will surely spill over with joy right now. Such an appearance will let her polls shoot up, and that's all Glimmer wants to see.
Okay, that's unfair. Glimmer wants to see her in this special white building, but it will be a long way until then and right now, she's just making up for her mistake from four years ago. This time, she won't let anything like that happen again.
There are already notifications barging in from her Twitter-account, but she doesn't dare and start to answer them personally. Her social media fellows will handle them, and inform her about if she should make a reply to one or two personally. Replying to maybe three thousand replies to her team's tweet about Adora and Anna "getting together just for the show" seems to be a bit too time-consuming, even by Adora's standards of how to use a lazy Sunday morning.
Someone from the studio staff receives her in the hallway and says, "This way, Congresswoman," guides her through a door, and Adora follows him absent-mindedly. She's still on her device, now checking for messages from Glim and such, and therefore it's not until the man closes the door *behind* her that she realizes her mistake. She looks up from her fucking phone and stares dumbfounded into an empty hall. Turning back and rattling at the door which just closed doesn't help a bit.

It wasn't just a door, but one of *these doors*. And of course it's locked. *Ugh!*

So here she is again, in the large, empty hall where she'd been with the woman, Casta, and all the other beings and their henchmen from the first time, when they threatened her. Seems they got her. Only that now she's alone. Nobody's here. At least, they left the lights on, otherwise she would be standing in the dark.

Super.

By the stars, she hates these fuckers. After a minute, it's unnerving her. After ten minutes, it's just annoying. She worries

about Catra, who will surely expect her back, and now she’s trapped in this fucking bunker. Adora clenches her jaw and grits her teeth. She wants to punch something.
“Hello?” Her call is echoing back from the walls and makes it all the clearer how alone she is in here. “This is boooring!”
Her phone doesn’t work, not even SMS go out, but who would’ve wondered. It doesn’t take magic or heavenly intervention to make a phone not working in a fucking bunker. Ha, they’re in America, they just have to dump her outside a large city.

She hammers at the door, but to no avail. She bumps into a rolling gate that should lead outside, but it’s very robust and doesn’t move an inch, it just rattles quietly. Nothing else is to be heard. A staircase into the basement ends before another locked door, and this doesn’t even seem like an exit. She doesn't try too hard, because who knows what’s to be found there. After a few more tries at another door and walking around restlessly for a few minutes, she finally decides to just sit down and wait.
One of the people with the gray hats will show up, Bow or Casta or whoever has no clue this time. She’s pretty sure that these guys don’t want to let her die from starvation in here. About eighty percent sure. Give or take.

“Hellooo?” No answers, no people in gray hats, no one talking to her.

And so she waits.
Time goes by slowly and all it does is to unnerve her even more. Adora was never the patient type, and useless waiting makes her frantic. She hates being forced to do something she doesn’t want to do. But after half an hour, she sits down and flips through her phone, reading old stuff.

“Frustrating, isn’t it?”

The woman finally emerging from the staircase to the basement is… intimidating. Adora doesn’t know how much time has passed.

The figure doesn’t do anything threatening, she doesn't even look rough or so, she’s just walking or rather… gliding over the floor. As if she doesn’t really touch it. There is some kind of weird glow emerging from her, it’s almost as if she’s a hallucination, or rather, a hologram. Adora knows that this technology is still years away, if it’s *ever* going to be real, but maybe there has been progress she isn’t aware of, and so she looks around for technical installments that look like projectors or similar.
But there are no strange lights coming from nowhere, no technical installments or so, and her gut already tells her that this… emanation... is no projection made by man.

That she’s not human was clear from first sight, the proportions just don’t fit. Too long.

Beside herself and the… woman, the hall seems still empty. She has an elongated pale face, a slender figure and wears some kind of peculiar purplish-blue suit that has a long skirt attached on the backside. It’s a resemblance of some upper-class dress-code without actually resembling it.

"My name is Light Hope,” she says.

“How ironic. You really have it with the odd names, huh? Must be pesky. And what happened to free will?” Adora accuses her, and they immediately understand each other. Unfortunately, Light Hope’s answer goes into a completely different direction than Adora expected. It sounds like she's explaining something to a child, but Adora's body hair start to straighten.
“We actually tried free will before. After taking you from hunting and gathering to the height of the Roman Empire, we stepped back to see how you would do on your own.” She glides around slowly. “Your kind gave us the Dark Ages for five centuries, until finally we decided we should come back in. The Chairman thought that maybe we just needed to do a better job with teaching you how to ride a bike before taking the training wheels off again.”

The woman seems disappointed, actually, she doesn’t really try to hide her exasperation.

“So, we gave you the renaissance, the enlightenment, the scientific revolution. For 600 years, we taught you to control your impulses with… reason.” She emphasizes the word slightly, in all the patronizing. “Then, in 1900, we stepped back again. And within only 70 years, you brought us two World Wars, Fascism, the Holocaust, and capped it off by bringing the entire planet to the brink of destruction with a strategy you literally called MAD, Mutually Assured Destruction. Fifty thousand nuclear warheads, enough to wipe out life on this world entirely, multiple times.”

She heaves a slow breath and her eyes pierce Adora. “At that point, the decision was taken to step back in again before you did something that even *we* couldn’t *fix*.” How she underlines ‘we’ and ‘fix’ makes Adora frown. And shiver. “You can thank us for the fall of the Berlin Wall later,” Light Hope continues, as she’s walked towards Adora again during her words, and now the glowing emanation is standing right before her.

“You don’t have free will, Adora. You have the appearance of free will.”

Despite she’s frightened by these horrifying revelations, Adora doesn’t budge nor backs down. She also doesn’t really buy it. Even after all she experienced, this is just too much. This… being… whatever it is can’t be serious. “You expect me to believe that? I make decisions every day.”
Light Hope scoffs amused. “Sure. Free will over which toothpaste you use, or which beverage to order for lunch, but humanity just isn’t mature enough to control the important things.”
Adora scoffs, because that’s outright annoying: “So, you handle the important things? Well, the last time I checked, the world’s a pretty screwed-up place.”
Light Hope cuts in immediately, and her answer is giving Adora just more shivers. Every hair on her skin stands on end as the woman says: “It is still here.”
She pauses shortly, because she makes every one of her words count. “If we left things in your hands, it wouldn’t be.”

Then it seems that she’s pondering or rather reminiscing in memories. “Did you know the Wright Brothers wanted to open a bike shop. Edison’s real dream was to be a sculptor. Steven Jobs almost went into the insurance business.” She shortly stops and makes a wicked grin, bringing her hand up and closing the gap between her thumb and index finger to a narrow margin. “Oh, and your friend Glimmer came *this* close to bankrupting ASI, and your political prospects with it. Instead, she made some good investments and backed a revolutionary solar technology you brought to her door. Technology that’s gonna change the world.”
Adora’s mouth falls slightly agape. That sounds incredible, because: “But the panels didn’t work the way they should. They never met the criteria.”
“But they’re going to,” Light Hope says, very calm and confident, now standing before Adora all high and mighty.
“I don’t believe you.“
“In six months from now, you will. And so will the voters. In five years, half of the world's fossil fuel industry will be extinct due to the rise of cheap solar power. In ten years… let's say, your names will be tied to it. And everything that comes with it."

That is… that is something to process later, like all the other stuff just told, Adora decides. Because it’s too large, the implications are too far-reaching. If this was a movie, the heroine would make some good joke now, or she would draw a funny trick out of her hat to reply to that. She would be cool and confident, not shaken to the core.
Unfortunately, this is no movie, and she’s no heroine. Adora’s actually shaken, trembling inside. Light Hope can’t be serious about that. Because if she is, it would mean… billions. Unbelievable wealth. Amounts of money that would make Elon Musk and Jeff Bezos blush in embarrassment and dwarf them to beggars.
She just can’t be serious.
Can she?

But it's still not the core of what’s going on in her mind. Light Hope still dances around the real issue. So Adora asks about what’s important: “Tell me why I can’t be with Catra. Because the

last guy didn’t know.” Casta didn’t, and she has the distinct feeling that Light Hope does.
The glowy manifestation smiles knowingly, then speaks with an assuring voice.
“After your little gaffe with the bar brawl that ruined your victory, meeting Catra at the Waldorf three years ago wasn't chance. That was us. We knew she would inspire you to give that speech. That speech that brought you back from the edge of oblivion, and overnight made you the front-runner in this coming election.”
Adora is frozen. What? This sounds like—
“You’re saying *you* want me to win the election?”

The tonality, the content of the woman’s next words cut through Adora’s reality. Light Hope’s voice is a sharp knife that tears apart the veil of uncertainty in her own longing, and brings to light what she had always known that she wanted, but didn’t dare to say. Not yet.
It doesn’t sound like a suggestion, it’s like Light Hope is talking about things that have already been decided, maybe happened, and her emphasis is strong:

“This one. And four more after it. And I’m not only talking about elections for the Senate, or the Presidency, Adora.”

There is a short pause, probably aimed to let Adora catch up, but it is not enough, not enough, because every single hair on Adora’s body straightens while shivers run down her spine. And the woman already continues. “You can matter, Adora, really matter. What your father wanted when he took you to the Senate gallery when you were ten. What your sister wanted when she made you promise the day before she went into combat, that you wouldn’t be like her. Why do you think you have that yearning to be in front of people, the terrible emptiness, when you’re not?”

“D-Don’t do that,” Adora stutters. No one’s allowed to use her memories of her family like that.

Light Hope is just unconcerned as she continues her missive: “The world is at a crossroads. Tipping points are going to be reached

soon, endless ripple effects occur, and they magnify. The next few years will see great conflicts, and these will shake the foundations of every nation. Humankind will need leadership, Adora, leadership that you can provide. Not only for this paltry country. And your time has come."

The woman's voice is so soft and gentle. She puts a hand on Adora's shoulder. The first half of her sentence is confirming what Adora always wanted to hear. It's only that the following part is all the more cruel.
"Adora, you can change the world for the better, but that doesn't happen when you stay with her."
Adora shuffles back with two paces and is louder than before when she calls: "Why do you care about whom I love? What has that to do with anything?" The question is burning in her, ever since Bow's revelation, and she needs to know. Light Hope knows.
"It's not about her. It's about you. Or what being with her does to you."
"What it does to me? I'm better when I'm with her, even you said it, the speech—"
"In small doses, Catra was the cure. But in large doses, she rubs off on you."
No, this isn't… it can't be. "Stop."

"Adora, the leader of the free world can't be a loose cannon."

"Stop TALKING!" Adora yells. Desperate. It's too much. Too far-reaching. Leader of the free world? What shall that even mean? As if the Presidency wouldn't be enough? It's something she barely allows herself to think about, not even really talking about that with Glim.

Light Hope shuffles around her, walks away and hovers through the hall, seemingly focusing on something else. "Why do you refuse to accept what should be completely obvious by now? You've seen what we can do, you can't doubt we are who we say we are."
Adora collects her mind a bit, stepping away from the edge of madness she seems to walk on since Light Hope entered the

scene. “Look, it’s not about who you are, it’s about who I am.”
“Can’t outrun your fate, Adora.” Light Hope chimes.
That is low. Even the tonality is exactly like her own. “Did you actually use my own words against me?”
“Who do you think *wrote* that speech? Your friend Glimmer? She’s smart, but not that smart. So few of you are. When it comes to your fate, you better leave this to us.”
“I just disagree with you about what my fate is. Don’t get I a say in what happens to me? Don’t I get a choice? I know what I feel for her, and it’s not gonna change. All I have are the choices that I make, and I choose her. Come what may.”

Light Hope’s blinks a few times, looks into the space of the hall beside Adora, and is considering something, Adora sees it. Then the glowing emanation purses her mouth a little: “It’s six twenty. If you leave now, you can make Catra’s show.” She just looks at the roll gate, which starts to open, and Adora is presumably free to go. Frowning, she starts walking towards the gate, leaving Light Hope behind, then it’s hurrying, and finally she just runs, before the spooky figure changes her mind and maybe closes the gate again. Or whatever.

She doesn’t look back. She can’t. Her fear is not so much in being trapped again. These people or whatever they are can't really capture, hurt or kill her, that much is clear by now. They want her to be alive and running.
Hah! Running, what a fucking joke.
Yeah, running.
For the Senate.
For the Presidency.
And then, for something more that she doesn’t even comprehend by now. *Leader of the free world?* Huh, hadn’t that been the President of the fucking USA? Wouldn’t that be enough, even for herself? She’s always been ambitious, she knows that. Getting into Congress was an important step, yeah, but her candidacy four years earlier and her candidacy now already made it clear that being a Representative just isn’t enough. Even being a

Senator might not be the end of the ladder. She's young, and ambitious, but she knows for herself that she lacks the experience she needs to go for more.
But four more elections - she would be in her mid to late forties then. Isn't that a bit far-reaching? But on the other end, given Light Hope's words, they seem to plan ahead far longer.
And maybe times are changing, and maybe Adora can matter. And that is what she's really fearing. She wants to matter, she always has. To make a difference. To *lead*, to be able to fix things. And if leading means not being with Catra, then what? So be it? Is this a choice she can make. She shall make? And is Light Hope knowing it for sure, that Adora is the right one?
These beings seem to know. They seem to have their hands in so many events of her life, that she can't be sure, what of it was her own doing, and what wasn't. But on the other hand, recent events seem to approve that they don't know, don't foresee everything, huh? They make mistakes. All these revelations by Casta back then, and by Light Hope now, seem to be somewhat distressed attempts to keep her on their precious plan. She should be furious about that, but somehow and for an unknown reason, she isn't. Well, duh, she is. She's angry. But not as angry as she thinks she should be. And that's confusing.

Her overthinking doesn't get her anywhere. There isn't much she knows right now, but one thing is for sure: she has to get a taxi. Now!

"Elise" (Deezer / Spotify)

Seeing Catra dancing is something else.

Adora's never been the type of girl to admire the fine arts. She's rather a hands-on guy, out on the streets of New York, of Brooklyn, talking to people, sitting in meetings with people and

trying to convince them of her opinions. She’s destined to be out on this battlefield, not squandering her time gushing over some overly exaggerated interpretation of five white lines drawn on a blue background. Sitting quietly and just watching others doing nonsensical stuff for two hours is something she doesn't tolerate very well. Usually, she gets giddy within ten minutes.

The auditorium of the Two Pines is well filled with people who do, actually, tolerate and even more, they admire it. Due to Adora being so late, the show started a while ago. It’s dark in the back where she stands, behind the rows of seats, but it’s okay. She can watch Catra from here, without knowing or distracting her. She just watches. Minutes go by and Adora just watches. She doesn’t even mind standing, because Catra is… beauty.

Not beautiful.

She’s sheer, personified *beauty*, the manifestation of it. Her movements are perfect. The seemingly effortless flow, the coordinated choreography of how she’s been carried, twirled and guided around by her fellow dancers are wonderful to watch. Though Catra is concentrated and hasn’t noticed Adora - she possibly can’t, because of the stage lights - her face is glowing from love and dedication. She bows her spine backwards, flows onto the floor, her colleague lifts her up, others carry her further and spin her around. It’s a continuous, fluent movement of all of them, working together as one.
And somewhere, with a whisper in the back of her mind, Adora suddenly understands how and why people admire this form of art. It’s breathtaking to just watch her, making her mind light, full, and satisfied. The music underlines everything to the point. That Catra loves doing this for a living is nothing but perfectly clear.

“She’s a beautiful dancer,” Light Hope says, suddenly emerging behind her from wherever. Adora hasn’t seen her coming in, but maybe the woman just mustn’t. She has dulled her appearance to a normal, yet still patronizing looking woman in a gray business suit, without the glow, and so she just fits into this place.
“I thought that I made myself clear,” Adora retorts snappy, giving

her a short runover. She's really done with Light Hope for the evening. Or forever. She won't hear any more of her bullshit. Not now, maybe never.

It's only that this won't stop the woman. "There's one more piece to this that I haven't mentioned. I guess I just didn't have the *heart*."
There's a short pause before the next sentence, and it makes Adora half-turn and listen, still looking at Catra.
"If you stay with her, it not only kills your dreams, it kills hers."

Adora needs a second to catch up, then asks: "What?"

"Catra is about to become one of the most famous dancers in the country, and eventually one of the world's greatest choreographers. If she stays with you, she ends up teaching dance to six-year-olds."

Adora shortly wonders why that would be so bad. On the stage, the choreography is still going on. Everyone is revolving around Catra, moving, holding her upwards, bowing and gliding so beautifully that it makes Adora's heart flutter. It's a testament of dedication, aptitude and talent. The music nails it perfectly. And Catra is completely immersed, she now twirling around, her arms outstretched, spinning like a top.
Adora understands now how and why Catra loves this, and her heart tells her that she does it with her whole being. Catra wants to become famous for her doing, she feels it just like she knows about her own desires. She deserves this as much as Adora deserves her own fate.
And that's why Light Hope's voice, so incredibly soft, makes Adora clench her jaw and the despair inside her grow ever greater.

She's a bit surprised when Light Hopes says what seem to be her final words to Adora: "When you look back at all this Adora, just remember, I tried to reason with you."

She doesn't need to be firm. It shatters Adora nonetheless. Light Hope turns to the exit, wanting to leave. But then there's one last

thing she does. It’s not even a wink, she doesn’t even twist her mouth, nothing is visible. But she looks back at the stage - at Catra - and Adora knows, she just fucking knows - it is Light Hope’s doing that makes Catra trip.

They are sitting in a taxi on their way to a hospital, and Catra is quietly nestling against Adora. She places soft kisses on Catra’s head and whispers: “It’s going to be okay, you’ll see. All will be well. I’m here.”
Catra hasn’t said a word the whole time since they entered the cab, but the desperation that is pouring out of her is very tangible. They talked about such stuff, yesterday, when Catra explained how even just a partly broken ankle could mean the end of her career, of her dreams, of everything she worked for during the last decade. It happened to a colleague of hers, only a year before. It’s a fear which is always there, sitting somewhere in a corner of everyone’s mind and no one is really talking about.
Adora has a dim understanding of what must be going on in Catra. She presses the woman’s hand in affirmation, but it’s just an useless gesture, given what’s at stake.
When the cab stops in front of the emergency, Adora quickly pays the driver, then carries Catra into the building bridal style. The brunette still doesn’t talk, and it is luck - or maybe it isn’t and again something that was *adjusted* - that Adora’s recognized by the woman at the counter. With a friendly wave of her hand and a nod, they are lined up front, Catra is quickly put on a stretcher, and then she’s gone for being x-rayed and stuff.

After Catra is gone, Adora’s sitting in the typical hospital waiting lounge and thinks about how these places are allowed to be so uncomfortable, unwelcoming and obviously trying to make people even more sad. The wall color is a terrible puke green, the ceiling the usual mixture of gray tech and cheap white plastic panels. A few artificial plants stand around, but the desperate try to give

this place some friendly color is making it rather worse than better, because the plastic just shows. *Ugh!* Adora thinks. How can people be possibly okay with that environment? She slumps further into one of the seats that are older than she is, and props her head into her hands, elbows on her knees. She tries not to worry too much while she waits for the results.

And so she just waits. She has never been good at this. But for Catra, she can. Adora doesn't know how much time has passed, how long she sat in this chair, when she's suddenly spoken to.

"I always hear people saying 'You can't blame yourself for what happens to other people', but in this case, really, you can."

Her blood has already been boiling, and now Adora wants to scream at Light Hope, who's standing before, looking down on her, and scolding her with this condescending voice. But screaming isn't enough, not by far, as Adora is so angry.
And it's not only that.
It wasn't Adora who made Catra trip.
This was her, Light Hope.

Her fist connects with Light Hope's face within the glimpse of an eye, and surprisingly it makes a very audible *thumb*. Light Hope is visibly pained, her face and body pushed aside, and she crunches a bit. Her dress wavers from the movement. Around them, other people waiting are startled, and two men jump up with surprised faces, concerned about the sudden outburst of violence from Adora, maybe trying to cut into the upcoming brawl.
But it had just been this one punch. Adora stands now, and pants heavily.

Light Hope collects herself, straightens up again, just touches her jaw where Adora hit her *hard*, and grimaces. The weird emanation seems to have felt this, on whatever level she's able to. Adora feels between embarrassed because of her loss of control - this damned lack thereof that had always been her demise - and the righteous fury, because she wants to beat Light Hope up for—

“This is what you do, Adora, so typical. This is what you did getting into a bar fight before the last election, and how the compromising pictures were made, that ruined it. We give you opportunities that other people would kill for, Adora, and you squander them because of an urge, an impulse. It doesn’t take a genius to see Catra isn’t exactly helping you with this.”
She nods at the direction where Catra’s room is. “It’s just a sprain. This time. She’ll recover quickly. But if you stay with her, you’ll take away the only thing that ever mattered to Catra. Hurt her now for once, to spare her this fate. Or hurt her for the rest of her life.”

Light Hope nods at her. “It’s up to you.” And then she just… fades away. The other people in the hallway don’t even notice that the woman who was there right before their eyes, who got punched in the face, is doing something impossible, is gone by now, without actually leaving the room. No one pays attention to this weird happening. It’s another cornerstone that makes Adora question her mind, but the proof is there.

Because her hand still hurts from the blow.

“Both Worlds” (Deezer / Spotify)

A little later, Adora is called into a room where a few people lay on stretchers. Catra welcomes her with a warm smile, and they fall into each other's arms. Or rather, Adora takes Catra, who still lies on a bed, into her arms, and they hug softly.

“It’s just a sprain?” Adora asks with a thick voice, because she already knows that and has difficulties to look surprised. Despite being a politician for so long, she isn’t a very good actress when it comes to personal stuff. She can just not tell things, but she can’t lie very well.
Catra looks glad, even in all the misery of being in a hospital bed that is placed in a room with half a dozen other beds, mostly empty though, due to the late hour. But her face is so much

lighter than before.
"Yeah. The doctor said it's going to be better in a month or less."
"That's totally unexpected." Adora assures her.
"I'm so relieved," Catra says, and the alleviation in her voice makes everything a bit harder, but also a bit more clear. Adora still has the horror in mind, from before, how Catra's eyes looked.

It makes it obvious what she has to do.
She knows. And she has to do it fast.

"Great. Great," Adora manages, thick. "I'm so glad for you, Catra. You're such a great dancer, and… uh… you'll heal up, and just get better and better." She falls dry, doesn't really know how to continue, how to continue from this. What is she going to say now? Probably nothing more. So she just hugs Catra another time, and lingers a little too long by doing so. Catra embraces her, oblivious about what's going to happen, but Adora just needs this, needs the closeness. She wills down the tears which are forming in the corner of her eyes, feels Catra's hands striking her back, and it's all Adora wants, to have this woman at her side, to be touched be her one more time.
Just one more time.
She presses her eyes shut, shortly.
When they finally part, she mutters: "I'm going to make a couple of calls, okay? I'll be back in a minute." Her voice is wavering a bit, and she doesn't… she can't look Catra into her eyes as she straightens herself.

Catra tenses a bit, it's palpable to Adora, but when they let go of their hands, the woman replies with a simple "Okay," that sounds somewhat unconvinced.
"I'm so happy for you," Adora says reassuringly, but it's more like a whisper, and then she turns from the bed, starts walking out of the infirmary, slower than her usual pace. Her shoulders are tense, and she senses how Catra's looking behind her, how her gaze lingers on her. Adora wants to turn around, immediately. *Turn around, now, get back to the woman you love*, because maybe, maybe Catra already senses that…

... Adora won’t come back. That Adora *won’t stay.*

Adora Grayskull has no tears in her eyes as she walks out of the emergency rooms, out of the hospital, passes the place before it, then into the streets of nightly New York that she barely recognizes, as she slowly drags herself back home for an hour or more. She walks and walks and some time later she reaches her home. Once there she takes the elevator, unlocks her door, closes her door, undresses herself down to her underwear, leaves her clothes on the floor, shuts off her phone, crawls into her bed, pushes a pillow over her head, and it is there that she finally lets herself start to cry. She cries into her bedsheets, and doesn’t stop for a long time.

She’ll hurt Catra, now, despite promising that she wouldn’t, and doesn’t know what she should do otherwise. The pain and guilt are consuming her, and emptiness is all that is left behind. Adora could outrun her fate, maybe. Pick up a fight against the people with the *plan* for her own fucking life. Who would care? Certainly not Adora. Putting herself to duty is what she does. Fighting them for Catra is a duty she’ll gladly do.

But she couldn’t ever, never take Catra’s fate from her. Nothing could be worth that.

That, Adora’s not worth of.

So she curls up and cries into her bed, into the pillow, trying to let Catra go, knowing that it can’t be done. She’s broken and she cries.

Back in the hospital, Catra sits, and waits. Her leg is bandaged, and she can’t walk very well, so after being finally released for going home, she just sits in the hallway and waits for Adora to get her. Adora promised to come back, but time goes by, and she

doesn’t come back, and it slowly dawns on Catra, she still hasn’t Adora’s number or any other contact of her.
After waiting for an hour, Catra asks the person at the reception if she saw the woman somewhere and is told that Adora Grayskull left the emergency an hour ago.

The woman has gone. Suddenly, everything seems to be so dark, heavy, unforgiving. The hallway, the whole place turns into an unfriendly place, and it is then, when Catra finally decides, that Adora won’t come back.
Her eyes water and she wipes away the tears. This isn’t the place. It’s not the right time. With a grim expression on her face, she calls a friend to help her get home. It takes her another half an hour to close her own door behind her. She lays down in her bed, where still a faint hint of Adora’s scent lingers in the sheets, and it is there, and with the memory of the last night, that she decides that his infatuation is over.

Adora Grayskull will never see her again.

Tears dwell in her eyes as she curls up, and sobs. She doesn’t understand what happened, and why it happened. Everything seemed to be so good, Adora came to her show, she brought her to the hospital, but obviously, sleeping with Catra was the goal she really aimed for, and… the... rest was just for the show. A bit of kindness, after she got what she wanted, and then she just… left. *How could I be so stupid? Falling for some sweet words by a bitch politician?*
Now she knows that Adora can’t be trusted. She was all shine, no truth, Catra tells herself repeatedly, while crying into the sheets. Adora's scent is still there. She grips her pillow and pushes it into her face, then starts to tear it apart in desperation and anger. She hasn't been so infuriated since... No, she isn't enraged. It isn't rage what fills her. This is grief, and so she weeps even more.
But after all, why did she even wonder? Adora got what she wanted, and now she just left her behind. She should have known better than to trust, to fall for her so easily.

How on Earth could she be so wrong about Adora?

“It’s done. Light Hope finished it,” Casta says, not looking at her colleague, while she lets her gaze linger over New York, then fixing the Empire State Building. Many lights are still on there, but they’ve seen this sight often enough and have no eye for it anymore.
“I know,” Bow silently replies, his voice cold and absent.
“You can’t let it get to you, like it did with her family. This is the job,” she tries to assure him, but he doesn’t really buy it.
Instead, he asks her: “You ever wonder… if it’s right? I mean, if it’s always right?
Casta ponders a bit before she answers: “Not like I used to. Look, Chairman has the plan. We only see a part of it. It’s not our place to question it. We just have to carry it out. It has always been so, and it was always for the better. The greater good demands sacrifices from everyone.”
If she sounded more convincing, it could have done something to soothe Bow, but it doesn’t. Casta seems to have her own thoughts about all of this, and he… he actually likes Adora, and it hurts him to see her hurt. Even if they need Adora where the plan is going to put her, she doesn’t deserve this kind of pain.
They stand there for some minutes, just looking over the glistening city, and he pities Adora. But he can't imagine how he can help her.

Chapter End Notes

I know everything seems to be pretty bad right now, but have some hope! You won't be let down.

The next chapter is called "Always turn it clockwise" and will be published next Friday, December 17th.
As always, comments are greatly appreciated.

[3] It's hilarious: Anna Kendrick's takeover of Between the scenes.↑

Always turn it clockwise

Chapter Summary

Adora's campaign is soaring.
Catra makes a final decision.
Bow is not happy with any of that.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Storms (Deezer / Spotify)

Eleven months have passed.

Again, autumn has fallen over all of New York State. Golden foliage sails quietly from the trees to the ground, where it forms beautiful patterns, and children pile up the leaves into heaps and throw themselves into them. They laugh and giggle, and it's childish, but that's just what they are. Adora watches the kids while her campaign bus maneuvers around to fit into the designated parking spot of the farm they just arrived at. She hears them scream of joy. *I would like to do that too*, she admits to herself with a small smile on her face, her head still leaning onto the window. *Just being a child again, with no worries, not a care in the world.*

Adora has never spoken nor seen Catra again since she walked away, and if there has been any attempt by her to reach Adora, she's not aware of it. She's sure that Light Hope and her lackeys make sure it stays that way, that every possible try by Catra will be intercepted, prevented, *adjusted* in the first place.
Given how Adora left Catra behind, in the hospital, alone, after their first mutual night, right after being injured, she doubts that Catra would try at all.

It is more likely that Catra hates her and never wants to see her again.

And Adora understands that, intended that even. She has hurt Catra intentionally, and Adora lives with it. It was aimed at making it easier for Catra to *not* like her anymore, to leave Adora behind. As far as she is concerned, Adora simply didn't matter in that equation, and Catra has hopefully been able to move on. Her career will soar, and that's what counts, what Catra always deserved.
The hole in Adora's heart has not closed, nor has the wound begun to hurt less. She fears that it never will, and so she simply distracts herself with what she does best. Fortunately, there's much to do, and her campaign takes all her time.

Because beside the grief, everything else just goes well. Glimmer Brightmoon has set up a terrifying juggernaut of an election campaign, and her war machine is flat rolling the State of New York like *London* through the remnants of Europe in 'Mortal Engines'. Glimmer hammers the message into people's mind, that Adora Grayskull is the woman of the hour, and Adora puts her whole, boundless energy, dedication and time into making her friend's and their team's efforts count. There is no stopping them. They meet possible voters everywhere, anytime: Town hall meetings, local fairs, press conferences, golf clubs, movie openings, evening receptions, sport events, union meetings, hearings, shops, concerts, walks and sometimes even birthday parties.
It's worse than the last election, and Adora does it all.
She will exhaust herself to the last drop, because when she lays down for sleep at night, exhaustion is the only thing that lets her sleep. She'd always been a good sleeper, but since she left Catra, her bed, alone, is not a welcomed place to be anymore. So she is out from six in the morning till ten in the evening, trying to fill her day with anything but leisure time that will inevitably turn into thinking about the woman she left behind.

It is nearly enough. Would've been enough, earlier.

All is going so well and odds seem to be in their favor, but sometimes, Glimmer notices the underlying mental absence of her friend. When they are on the road, driving back home from a long

campaign day, Adora often just wistfully looks outside, seemingly dreaming to herself, and barely reacts to Glimmer's words then. Which is not like it was before.
The last election, there was so much chatter and giggling during their trips, they talked and rattled, and made fun of everything. Now, it's a quieter Adora, and she's sometimes moony, faraway. Then, Glimmer lays a hand on her friend's thigh, which Adora grabs absent-mindedly to hold and seek for a bit of comfort, while she's still looking out of the window, and they say nothing.

Beside Adora's explanation why Catra was gone again, only on one occasion during the last eleven months, Adora said something about her. They were on tour around Syracuse near Lake Ontario, and at the end of the day Glimmer found Adora in the hotel bar, sipping a drink and talking to some strangers, like so often. When the people finally left, Adora looked at Glimmer with a quirked grin and took another sip.
"Don't you have enough for today," Glimmer asked while sitting down on the barstool beside, and didn't mean the drink.
Adora stirred her Mojito with the straw, but didn't look up. "What? We just got another two votes. I'm fiiine."
"Of course you are, babe," Glimmer drawled while she laid a hand on Adora's shoulder and stroked it softly. "You look tired. How about if I put you to bed now, and you can continue to ensnare voters tomorrow?"
Adora huffed, but didn't reply. It made Glimmer snatch her drink and empty it in one gulp. "Rude much! That was mine," Adora grouched, but her gaze didn't hold any glare.
That she wasn't loud and annoyed was just another sign. "What's on your mind, Adora? Shall we… cancel tomorrow? I know when you're not doing good. We can just go back and sit down with the staff for planning, you know? Having a day or two off won't hurt us. You need some sleep."
"As I said, I'm fiiine," Adora brushed it off, and it wasn't more believable than before.
"You are not!"
Adora rolled her eyes and groaned: "Yeah, maybe I'm not, but

sitting around at home doesn't make anything better. I'm just restless then."

Glimmer grabbed Adora by the wrist and started pulling her outside. Back in the elevator, the machine made a low whirring sound, and Adora lent against the cabin, her arms wrapped around herself, when she finally whispered, "I miss her, Glim."
The terror of New York's upper class needed a second to get out of her surprise, then she took Adora in her arms and embraced her for the rest of the ride. "I know. I'm sorry," she said. "I wish I could do something. Help."
Both women left the elevator arm in arm and were quiet until they reached their rooms that lay next to each other. Adora fumbled with her key card, still silent and obviously hesitating a bit. She looked a little lost, not radiating anything of her usual confidence, until Glimmer asked, "Sleepover?"
Adora squeezed her mouth into a flat line. How could she be so weak, after all the time? She was so pathetic. But then she nodded gratefully. Neither girl said anything, when Adora curled into her friend until the morning. Glimmer just held her, nothing else, but they didn't speak much about it. An earnest "Thank you, Glim," had to do it.
Adora had never been great with her own feelings.

But today is super, it's a lovely autumn day, the trees are still full of colorful leaves, beaming in the golden sunlight, and the campaign has invaded a nice and helpless farm from a party member near Saranac Lake in Upstate New York, where Adora's talking to a bunch of locals like they did for the last days. Despite most of her voters being from the Big Apple, people from here also want to be heard and seen, and she needs their votes as well. Being around folks from a friendly stronghold of the party is also excellent for the pictures, Glimmer insisted.
So, Adora's in the middle of her charming little speech - not too long for this occasion, fifteen to twenty minutes must be enough because nobody here wants to hear a politician rambling for an hour - in front of some barn, and she looks as handsome as always. She'll do some talking to the people after her address. Her blonde hair is bound into the signature ponytail and the poof, all

of it shining in the sun, and together with her good figure it makes her look like the beautiful girl next door who made it in the big city.
Which is somewhat true, in Adora's case.

Around 50 people have gathered to listen to her. "I was talking to some friends of ours over in Monroe County this morning, and, you know, I said something to them that I think a lot of you may have heard me say before, but it bears repeating. We need to make sure that living conditions stay good in the countryside, so that people still want to live here. The passing of farms like yours from generation to generation must be possible without having to fear financial drought. I know about these concerns, and my aim is to... "

Glimmer watches her in a relaxed mood and doesn't really listen to her friend as she sits in Adora's campaign bus - their campaign bus. She has the news on, while keeping only half an eye on Adora. The blonde doesn't really need support for gatherings like this, because she's done that a thousand times and can do that off the cuff.
Conveniently, the news cover the current election right now, and Glimmer's not up to watch anything else until election night anyway. The news anchor of NBC just started: "Adora Grayskull, who has spent the last three days campaigning in the Tri-Lakes area, received some welcome news yesterday, when the latest New York Times poll gave her a 16-point lead over her opponent, less than a month before election day." Glimmer grins wide and large at that. "Since her announcement eleven months ago, Grayskull has had a significant lead, and it only widened in the last weeks. The party is unanimously behind her. Her rival, incumbent Lucius Hordak, wasn't available for a statement, but a spokesperson of his campaign said, quote 'Grayskull also led by far before the last election, and you remember how it turned out. We're sure that the woman will do something similar this time and just crush herself. We won't have to deal with such insolent behavior any more soon enough, I would say."

“Fuck you, Lyn,” Glimmer mutters and shoots her frenemy a mocking message with something about “16 points” and “Eat that” in it, while she watches Adora shaking hands and smiling at people after the end of her speech. She has gotten so good at it that it fascinates Glimmer. In their childhood, she never thought that the torn, often just friendly, pleasing and sometimes clumsy girl would turn into such an appealing and confident politician. She rather envisioned Adora to become a sports star, maybe a war correspondent, or just serving in the military, leading her corps into battle. Adora, holding up the flag for her comrades to follow, is something she can imagine very well.

To her surprise, Adora turned out to be a born leader.

It foreshadowed when she rallied her schoolmates in the sixth class, when the board of the school decided to cut down free lunch for children from poor families. The protest she organized over such narrow-minded and stingy pettiness made her famous early in Red Hook, because they crippled traffic at four blocks around the school when 200 of the 300 pupils demonstrated and protested under her flag for three days. Half of them did it for fun, sure, but Adora got them nonetheless. She took the blame and the following detentions willingly, but the public pressure on the school board by so many parents was large enough for them to cancel their plans. The little event showed Adora that Adora could make a difference, if she put herself into it, and it was her first step on the ladder of her political career, without her even knowing it at the time.
Glimmer still thinks how funny it is, that such a trivial thing like free lunch for a handful of kids was one of the sparks that triggered Adora into politics, and would make her a Senator of the United States of America soon. She gladly put herself behind Adora’s ambitions, because she actually admired the stormy and passionate attitude of her best friend.
As she aimlessly flips through the newspaper, she sees a headline, and nearly chokes on her coffee. “Fuck. Fuckfuckfuck!” These were reserved words for the mood she got in right now.

Under a large oak, Adora still talks to some attendees of the little event, shaking hands as so often. “Thanks, thanks a lot. Thank you for your support. I need it. Thank you.” These are normal people from this rural area, mostly farmers, folks working in tourism and mom-and-pop stores and such. All these people want is some attention by the allegedly mighty soon-to-be-Senator. It’s not often that they get to see their representative, so it’s not only a campaign event, but also a possibility to hear and see each other in person.
Some of them ask for an autograph, which Adora hands out gladly. “Who should I make it out to?” She signs a few of them while people disperse, and she isn’t afraid of all the public attention. That, she can handle easily today. It’s rather the nights, the loneliness, she fears.
But here, she can make a woman happy by taking a picture with her. “Yeah, sure, come here,” Adora says and lays an arm around an elderly while her husband takes a photo. “Thanks a lot,” the woman says, smiling, and Adora’s happy. “My pleasure, Ma’am. Thank you for coming.”
Another couple wants the same, and on she goes for some more minutes with all the chit-chat and people-pleasing. “We’ll vote for you, Ma’am”, a random stranger in an overall says, while tipping his hat. “Thank you!” Adora replies gratified.
All the praise and approval is so nice that it nearly covers the hole in her heart, of which she doesn’t think during her days. "Thank you for being here, Sir. Yes, I will. Be well. Thanks! Bye!"

When finally everyone has enough of her, the tall blonde lets her teammates handle the rest and walks over to a bench under a tree, where Glimmer sits, with a newspaper in her hands. Glimmer smiles at her, but it’s a worried, lopsided one, Adora can tell. They know each other well enough.
“Hey,” she says, “what’s up with you?” waiting for Glim to speak.

Twenty seconds later, she wishes she hadn’t asked.

The facial expression of her friend morphs into a concerned one. “I want to show you this, because you will find out eventually. And I want to be here for you when you do.” She hands the

newspaper over to Adora, and taps at an article. Everything slows down when Adora gets what's on it. It's a half-pager in the arts section of the New York Times, where a large picture of Catra shows her in the middle of a performance. Adora's look moves over the headline and reads "Dance Takes a Quantum Leap". The article talks about the soaring of Catra's career as she's about to present her second own choreography of a whole play, and the national and international attention of the ballet scene that is slowly turning to her.
This is good, Adora thinks for a moment, and a little spark of pride manifests in her, because this is telling her that her sacrifice wasn't for nothing. It's not much, but it is at least the reason why she did, what she did.
But then, down on the right end side of the article is a small photo of Catra with another woman at her side. As Adora reads the subtitle, the late summer air seemingly gets colder, and the so far beautiful day vanishes behind dark clouds.
She mutters to herself: "The show's co-choreographer, Scorpia Davis, and lead dancer Catra Driluth are partners on- and offstage and plan to marry next week in New York." Her throat is tight.
"She's getting married, to that girl she was engaged to," Glimmer says unnecessarily, if only to speak it out loud for her friend. Adora knows what and why Glimmer does by voicing it. But, actually, hearing it just makes it worse. Adora just stares at the picture, the large one, with solely Catra on it, and starts to shiver slightly. Fighting back the urge to cry or groan or at least to do *anything* to unleash the pain that makes her heart clench is hard.

"How are you?" Glimmer asks in a seemingly light tone, but Adora senses the worry behind it. She told Glim everything about how she left Catra behind, and why she did it: to protect her own career, to protect Catra's career, so that both of them don't mess with their concentration because they are so love-befuddled. Of course, she kept quiet about everything to do with the *people under the gray hats*. Sometimes, she doesn't even think about them, as if a cloth of gauze has been spread over this knowledge, in order to dim it purposefully. It's still there, in the very back of her mind, it's just that she doesn't pay much attention to it, and

the more time passes, the more the memory dims.
"Yeah, I think I'm going to…," Adora replies slowly, putting the newspaper back in Glimmer's hand.
"Take a day off. Hell, take a couple. We're 16 points up," Glimmer says firmly, and Adora can't remember her saying something similar in the last ten months beside the one evening in Syracuse. It's always 'Just this one more appointment, Adoraaaa!' and 'We need to get up at 5 am sharp' and 'Saturdays are for meeting families with their kids at a local funfair, and not for squandering around. Sundays too, by the way!' It's uncanny how she sometimes sounds like Light Hope, even if it's light years away from the spooky emanation. Adora barely thinks of her anymore, though she has the consequences of her doing still in her mind all time.
After all, Light Hope wasn't wrong about one thing: Adora wants this, too. With half her heart.

"Yeah, even I can't blow a lead that big, huh?" Adora presses out, trying to stop possible tears. "I… uhmm… I'm gonna take a short walk, okay? Just to… uhm… take a breath." All her confidence lost, she looks at Glimmer pleadingly, trying to say that she needs a few minutes on her own without saying it. The pink-haired terror nods, lays a hand on Adora's and replies: "I'll cancel tonight's dinner. It's okay. Go, I'll be waiting for you here."
It takes Adora an hour of walking through the fields around the farm before she's able to come back, calm enough to bear the ride back to New York in the campaign bus, with all the people. Her heart is heavy, and the picture of Catra, arm in arm with her soon-to-be-wife is burned in her mind, despite she only saw it once.

She can't think of anything else.

Bow hasn't been happy for a long time.
Despite what he and his colleagues are, they feel something. Being Adora's ward and case officer has had its perks. It's prestigious, and challenging, and he knows and feels that the kind, tall blonde woman was always worth his time, unlike so many others he had officiated. In the last year, though, he hadn't found any joy doing his job. He does it, because he's dutiful, and because Adora's path needs a few little adjustments here and there. He was surprised how good Adora did on her own, since they separated hers and Catra's path.
There've been virtually no deviations, no inflection points, no disturbances.

Adora marches or rather storms forward on her path to victory, soon to become a Senator of the United States, and then further on her course to take the future in her own hands, and Bow is glad he can assist her from behind the curtain.
But he also senses the emptiness in Adora's heart and for the first time in decades, he lacks any zeal. And that makes him angry. Because he's usually proud of what he does, and likes it.
When the exact same newspaper is in his hands that Glimmer handed to Adora this very day, and it's the same message they read, it is the last straw that makes him leave a message. Putting his hat on his place, he walks out of the Reading Room with a grim face. This day won't end calmly.

Adora reaches for the bar of Brooklyn Ice House, for the first time since weeks.
She took Glimmer by her word, and got herself three free days, without appointments. Okay, with little appointments. She was at a daycare today, because she wanted to go there just to lift her mood a bit, and she also spoke a few sentences in honor of Police Officer Moira Ann Smith at the playground at Madison Square Park named after her the day before.[4] The playground is right before

her apartment building, she walks by it every other day, and it would've been rude to cancel. Besides that, Adora has no dates. She called Glimmer a few times, just to talk and keep herself updated, but as she said, 16 points wouldn't vanish as long as she did nothing stupid.
And Adora didn't. She felt just empty, the hole in her chest was as big as it had been eleven months before. Nothing's changed regarding that, and she simply had no energy for stupid stuff.

In the late afternoon, her steps lead her back to Red Hook, rather unintentionally, while she'd been aimlessly wandered through the city after the daycare visit. When she recognizes the so familiar signs of her favorite bar, she decides to sit down for a beer - only one this afternoon, because she promised - as the bartender approaches her friendly: "Congresswoman. Good to see you again. Your friend just left you this. He said you would be stopping by." The woman hands over a folded note and Adora suppresses a surprised exclamation, stomps down the puzzled question in her throat, takes the little yellow piece of paper, unfolds it and reads.

A minute later, she's running over to Pier 12. It's just a few hundred meters, and the sky has darkened remarkably in the last quarter of an hour. While she runs, it starts raining, and Adora thinks about if Bow has planned this so well. She reaches the Pier and runs along the warehouse. To her left side is Buttermilk Channel and over there, Governor's island. She makes out the illuminated contures of the Statue of Liberty on her own island behind, hovering above the dark bay.
Nobody is at the pier at this late daytime, normal work is done for today, but Adora sees a figure under an umbrella standing at the end of it, and slows her steps down. The rain intensifies, and Bow looks at one of the gates of the warehouse behind them. It clicks open with a silent noise, and they wordlessly retreat into the large space to not be soaked from the gushing that starts just now.

It's rather dark inside, and of course turning on the lights is a stupid idea. So they don't, and stand in the dark. Only the emergency lights and the rest of daylight from the outside

illuminates the scenery, while it pelts the roof.
"Do you control the weather now?" Adora lightly accuses Bow instead of a greeting. She remembers him saying that water influences their abilities, and maybe this has something to do with that.
Bow rolls his eyes at Adora's blunt antics. "I can use a weather app as well as the next guy." He waves with his mobile. "Rain radar isn't that magic anymore, huh? Even if you're still pretty bad with the forecast."
Adora huffs shortly, but decides to let it slide. "Why do you wanna see me?"

It's a bit of a surprise when he jumps right in: "Light Hope was lying to you when she said you couldn't be with Catra because she brings out your reckless side."

What?

Adora's eyes pull wide, and she gestures around angrily. "Then why? Why do they care so much? Why can't I be with her?"
Bow sighs, and takes off his gray hat. Without it, his face looks torn, but he's not struggling to say the next words: "Because she's enough, Adora. If you have her, you won't need to fill that void inside of you with applause and votes and of dreams of one day making it into the White House. And that's important, sure, but it's not the only thing that matters."
"The White House… doesn't matter?," Adora parrots, unable to comprehend. She's totally bewildered. Implications and premonitions tremble down on her, and she needs a few breaths to come up with a response, with another question, because this is significant to know: "Why are you so different from them?"
Now it's Bow's time to need a while before replying: "Your dad was a very smart man. He could've been a lot more. Wanted to be. Your sister, too. But the plan didn't call for it. We… can never make such large deviations."

This is it. Adora is nearly speechless at his admission, but she pushes herself through, now that she finally gets some real answers. "What about my mother?" She requires this clarity.

“That wasn’t me. That wasn’t us at all.”
“It was just chance?” Adora asks coolly, but with a lump in her throat.
He shortly cocks his head, indicating a nod, but again, it takes some time for Bow to say something. “Chance is still an important factor to everything that happens. I’m sorry.”

Adora tries to stamp down the urge to scream loudly and to punch him in the face. She has long since accepted and come to terms with the loss of her family. And it wasn’t like that she hadn’t some suspicion about all that since Light Hope's revelations. Adora knows herself that she’s a bit dense sometimes, but she isn’t stupid. Of course, she already silently assumed that *they* had their hands in it. This confirmation is just some odd kind of closure, actually, and there’ll be a time to process it properly.
But this time isn’t now.
It’s a malicious and cruel joke, but Light Hope was right about another too: she has to learn to control her impulses with reason and self-control. So Adora breathes in, and out, in, and out, multiple times, fighting down her rage and the anger that fuels her now.
When she’s finally able to unclench her fists, she tells herself - repeatedly - that it’s water under the bridge. And she wonders why she’s so lenient.

Maybe it’s because of the hole in her heart that she can’t muster the energy to be really angry anymore. Glimmer already said something like that, when they were sitting in the bus on their way back from Syracuse. She’d pestered Adora with some nonsensical stuff, and Adora didn’t even had the will to say anything. “Losing your stamina, baby?” Glimmer asked, politely and clearly noting her mental absence, and Adora just didn’t care. She just sighed and continued looking outside, where nothing but a forest ran by.

Here, in this hall, with all these revelations at hand, she decides that she can be angry at Bow, or Casta, or Light Hope, or the Chairman another time. The plan isn’t Bow’s in the first place, and

the past is the past. She'd shed enough tears, and more will obviously follow.

But not now.

Now's not the time, she tells herself and shakes the feeling off, shrugging her shoulders. "You know, Light Hope's not lying. They're already talking about me being a presidential candidate in a few years. I don't deny that this sounds tempting. First female president and so. All this power in my hands. The most powerful woman on the planet. I'm phoning in my speeches, and I'm 16 points up. Give me some time, and when I'm 35…" She falls dry again and Bow just nods.
"The public loves you, and will continue to do so," he adds and pulls a corner of his mouth in a weak smile. "As long as you don't get into a bar fight or punch a child, your rise will go on."
Adora ignores the weak joke and clenches her jaw. "Before I met Catra, that's all I cared about. I really wanted that. And I don't even notice it now." Her voice falls quiet, tones down to a desperate whisper: "Everything tastes like ash and dust."
There is a hint of wetness in her eyes. She hears the rain pattering on the roof of the warehouse. It sounds calming, as well as knowing that these beings are disturbed by such a triviality.
Adora heaves a deep breath: "I can't stop thinking about her."
"I know," is all Bow says.

Adora needs a bit until she comes up with the question: "Do you know where she's getting married?"
He answers without really thinking about the implications: "In front of a judge, tomorrow morning."
Adora's throat tightens again, shortly closes her eyes to gather herself, but she has… she has to ask this: "Is she happy?"
Now he gets it. "Uh, Light Hope won't let you anywhere near her. Not tonight, not tomorrow, not ever. "

"Bow, is she happy?" Adora insists, more firm now. She knows where this is aiming at. Adora is absolutely clear about her choices.

Bow just sighs, and the worried look on his face tells Adora all she needs for an answer. *Come what may*, she'd said to Light Hope. It is time to make good on that promise. It is a decision, and it is *her* decision.
"I got to try and get her back," she says, and it sounds like carved in stone.
"Will you help me?" She stares at Bow. "Will you just help me get to her?
With a voice pitched a bit too high, Bow tries to counter: "They'll sense you coming a mile away, Adora. Light Hope has a dozen or more case officers tracking you and Catra all the time. You. Just. Can't."
But Adora has long thought about that, and with Bow's revelations, everything falls into place. "What do you want with your oh-so-desired leader, if I'm just an empty shell, huh? So, tell me, what if I could move as fast as you? Teach me about the *doors*, Bow!"

Bow looks at the ground, and he's surprised that he actually thinks about it. Never in the history of humankind have they allowed someone not of their kind to use *the doors*. It's not that they are a special secret. Sometimes people catch them using a door and wonder how it is possible that suddenly two or three people vanish into a little storage room and never come out of it again. Or that someone comes out of a closet without getting into it in the first place. When they look, nobody's in there and nothing is special. And then it's that they just forget about such stuff quickly. Their memory doesn't keep it, and so there's nothing to think or talk about. This is the way how they keep their existence a secret.

But showing Adora how this works, and giving her his hat - which is necessary - is something completely different. It will reveal so much of their possibilities. On the other hand: he knows that he wants Adora to be able to walk into a future where she's not a burnt-out shell, a heartless hull, and not able to form a real bond to people anymore. He has the strong sense, that this is more important than he actually knows, than even the chairman might have considered. He knows Adora for her whole life, and he wants

to keep Adora *alive*, for real, and not only her shell. She has to stay *Adora* for being able to do what they want her to do.

"The rain will stop in the next hour, and that's the only thing keeping them from seeing us right now."
Adora wants to open her mouth but is shushed by him, and he laughs at her: "Rain radar, Adora. No magic." It makes Adora bark out a single laugh, and it is the happiest expression she made the entire day.
"If we're gonna do this, we'll need some time to do it and a place surrounded by water to do it in. They can't know that we're together for more than a few minutes."

While Bow explained, they've walked towards the other end of the warehouse and approach an unimpressive door, just like a dozen others they passed. It's still raining as Bow comes to a hold, lays his hand on the knob, and explains: "Always turn the doorknob clockwise."
Of course, Adora asks just out of curiosity: "What happens if I turn it otherwise?"
"You DON'T wanna do that. That's only for us. Really, Adora, don't do it." Adora notes the seriousness in his words, and she just files the information away. "Now, put your hand on my shoulder, and don't let go until we cross the threshold."
Adora does as told, asking him teasingly: "Are these ever locked?"
"Not when you're wearing one of our hats," he replies, and Adora literally hears the smirk.

Bow turns the doorknob with a strange grinding sound, as if gears were meshing inside. It's clearly different from normality. They walk through the door and are in a building that looks like a museum. It's empty, void of people, and of course it is, because it's the evening and no museum has open for so long. They walk through the large, white painted hallways with round, modern columns, and Adora starts to recognize it. She sees a whale skeleton hanging from the ceiling and knows. "Is this…?"
"Yeah, the Museum of Modern Art. We like it. Many nice doors, empty at night. Keep moving Adora."
Bow is walking quickly towards another door, which seems to be a

fire exit. Adora puts her hand on Bow's shoulder again, and they walk over the next threshold.

Adora nearly falls, when she trips over the edge of a carpet. They are in a beautiful living room, no, rather a small reading room, because bookshelves reach up until the ceiling, four meters high, and two beautiful upholstered armchairs stand opposite of each other, with a small wooden table between them. This looks like a private apartment of some wealthy people from the last century, not a public space, and the question leaves her mouth quickly:
"Whose is this?"
"Can't tell you, Adora. But they use it only during holidays, so it's safe today. Come on, no dallying!"

Another door, another threshold passed. They are in a dark, long, industrial looking hallway, the floor, walls and ceiling are made of concrete, and water is dripping down from long pipes mounted waist high and run along the corridor. It's cold and damp, and everything looks a hundred years old. It is, actually.
"Close the door," Bow instructs, and Adora follows, then he explains: "This is the city's main pumping station for downtown Manhattan. From here, two million people receive their water day to day. Enough of it to shield us for some time. And we're just ten blocks from the courthouse."
Now Adora's happy that she dressed in a comfy dark suit for today, because the chill air gives her shivers. Bow doesn't seem to mind. They walk through the long concrete corridor and reach a stairwell.
"Wait here." Bow steps on a metal staircase that leads two stories up to another door, and he turns the knob with the usual grating sound. It closes behind him, leaving Adora alone in the hall. She's not fearful - if Bow wanted to betray her, he could've had it easier - but the surrounding isn't very comforting. She taps with her foot on the ground, on beat with the drops of water from the ceiling. And waits, trying to keep her thoughts away from a Catra being married to someone. Now, that she decided to take action upon this, she feels a nervous energy filling and driving her.

Minutes later, Bow returns with a large briefcase in hand. He leads Adora through another corridor while explaining: "Lower Manhattan is layer upon layer of substrate. That's what we call the doors that have been added over time. Makes it a lot more complex to navigate downtown than it is uptown, and a lot slower. Honestly, it's a messy maze."
They reach some kind of maintenance room or workshop, because a wooden table stands between the concrete columns. The walls are equipped with some tools and cabinets. Bow switches on a light that flickers to life and lays a set of plans on the table. They show a weird view of Manhattan, but not with its usual streets. It rather looks like a plan of power lines and sewers, only that there is much blinking and such. He points at a place southwest of their own position. "Your destination, 60 Centre Street, Courtroom 300."
Adora knows the address. It's the New York County Courthouse, set of the county's supreme court and the county jurors. And for getting married. She's been there often enough, for talks, speeches, blah-blah. Bow rambles on: "They won't let you near this building tomorrow morning until the marriage happened. There are hundreds of different ways to get to the courthouse using the doors. I want you to learn how to stay in the substrate, so Light Hope won't be able to get a fix on you. Because if she does, she'll use whatever it takes to lock you until Catra is married. Our predictions show, that she won't break her promise to Scorpia so easily, then. And she still holds a grudge."

"Okay," Adora says, not knowing what's coming when Bow said that he wanted to teach her how to use the doors.

Catra approaches the reception of her so-familiar dancing studio. On this evening, her mind is nothing but confused, a place where twirling thoughts spin around and make her restless. Well, more restless than usual. She desperately needs to have some

dampening relaxation before tomorrow, and draining her body of his energy is the surest way to do that.
"Hi, is the floor open?" she asks the receptionist, with her sports wear in a bag slung over her shoulder.
"Uhm, sure," the woman answers, and adds a concerned "You okay, sweetie?"
Catra often trains at unusual times, but this is tardy even by her standards, so the question is legitimate. It's late evening, and the studio is just still open because there's a little business party going on in one of the smaller stages. Otherwise, it would be closed as of now, because there's no performance today. And everyone here knows about what happens tomorrow.
"Yeah. I just… I just feel like being on the floor," Catra replies hesitant, trying to avoid showing anyone her insecurity. No, she isn't insecure, it's just excitement. That's it. About the wedding, yes. In 24 hours, even less, it'll be done. She'll be married to Scorpia, to friendly, gentle and always kind Scorpia, and that is what she wants. Catra gets an unconvinced nod, strides for the stage and plunges into a relentless training.

Focus! It's all about focus, and concentration.
The absolute will to perfectly dedicate her body to the narrative of the choreography. She stresses and bows her torso to the struck of the piano keys that hall through the room with a soft tonality. It is far from aggressive, but the tinkling supports her on each single movement. Two Pines is a contemporary ballet which means they use the full pallet of classic, modern, western and non-western sources and cultures to combine everything into something new and unknown to the audience, and sometimes even to the dancers. It's sometimes edgy, and in their best times it's surprising and chaotic, and this is what Catra loves. She trains for an hour, pushing her body to his limits, she sweats and is exhausted, her back aches, her arms are numb. When she twirls around a last time, panting, she knows she's done for the evening.
And still.
And still, when she finally falls to the floor, panting and gasping for air, her hair messy and her clothes drenched, it doesn't feel like she is exhausted enough to find sleep tonight.

When she's on her way home, walking through the nightly air of the large city, she shivers a little. It can’t be from the cold, because she’s still heated from her extensive work-out and her jacket is thick. Catra hopes that during her way home, she’ll get tired enough. And even if not, it won’t change anything. She’ll push through this night, and luckily, after tomorrow, everything will be done. She’ll be married, and can move on after these months of uncertainty.
Her future will be what she ever wanted: steady, secure, reliable, with a friend on her side who will never leave her. She doesn’t need anything else. She clearly doesn’t need images of the treacherous blonde soon-to-be-Senator in her mind. The woman can go fuck herself. Or anyone.
But not Catra.

Six hours later, Adora knows.
Her head is twirling with all the paths, waypoints, doors, connections and junctions they discussed. It’s a freaking labyrinth out there, where two doors next to each other connect two places five kilometers apart, and another two doors literally just let you travel from the 83th to the 59th floor of 432 Park Avenue, a skyscraper where you don’t wanna live in. Maybe even the gray hats didn’t want to deal with the legendary elevator issues there, Adora muses. One door leads into the Ghostbusters HQ, right beside the ghost vault, it's just ridiculously dangerous. So, now she knows much more, but knowing isn’t doing, and that’s what will be important soon.
“Just south of the diner, it’s a red door. I come out on Broadway, right by Leonard Street. “That’s good, keep going,” Bow encourages her.
“From Leonard, half a block down, then—"
“Okay, suppose, Light Hope’s there, intercepting you at the corner?”
“So, I go east to Lafayette—"

"No, it's Crosby Street there."
"Ugh! I know which street it is, I know where to run!" she groans.
He shakes his head. "Adora! Concentrate! You have to jump from door to door, and you have to know where you are every single time! You don't have the luxury to meander around, because Light Hope knows the area and the doors like the back of her hand. She'll be acting fast, her forces are far superior to you, and you don't have time to search for the right door! Understood?"

Bow shows her another map of downtown Manhattan and points at a place, where several doors and ways are marked.
"Eight doors? I'm zigzagging all over the place. That will take me too long!" Adora objects.
"But every time you go through a door, the plan books will lose track of you shortly, so it's safer. Look, I need you to understand that this has never been done before. So, the minute you go through that first door without me, every plan book in New York will scream alarm and all hell will break loose. Light Hope will call every available agent into service, claiming it's an imminent threat to the primary r— to the plan - which it actually is - and you can fairly assume that everyone with a hat on is a threat to you. Don't care if it's a Yankee cap, a bowler, or even a yarmulke. Just assume that everyone in a hat is working with Light Hope!"

Adora gulps, but thinks of countermeasures also. This is what she and Glimmer do all evening long: how to counter her opponents with clever ideas. It often ends with funny nonsense, but it also often helps them to be prepared. "So, you guys can't get through the doors without your hats on, right?"
"Right," Bow freely admits. "It's one of the ways the Chairman limits our power. Water is another way. Hats can be taken, water can be sent."
Adora doesn't even try to think about 'water being sent' and asks: "And you said before, what if Light Hope's in front of me on Crosby Street?"
"Yes?"
"Why don't I just knock the hat off her head and then run by her before she has time to pick it up? Maybe take it?" She cracks her

knuckles together in a very Adora-ble way and grins grimly.
Bow actually laughs: “Oh, that’s good! Improvisation! We have trouble with that.”
Adora looks at the plan and draws a line. “That fastest way is actually if I go right for the blue door.”
“Yeah, but then you’re exposed the entire way there. That’s a lot more dangerous than leapfrogging through doors.”
“Buuuut, if I make it, I’ll take them completely by surprise.”
“If you make it.”
They shortly stop in their little quarrel, until Bow picks it up: “Come on, we have a lot more to get through.”
“Whatever it takes,” Adora says, firmly, determined. She sees a smile forming on Bow’s face, and he chuckles lightly.
“What?”
“Your father used to say that.”

Ooof… that is… that is a bummer. Adora tries to not let this get too near and too deep, because she needs the concentration, to be focused now. Bow just sort of thought loudly, it seems, so she can ask something different: “I guess you’re not supposed to identify with your... subjects. You’re not supposed to feel guilt, right?”
He tilts his head slightly, to one side, then to the other, a few times. “We’re not built to lead with our emotions like you are, but that doesn’t mean we don’t have them.” He doesn’t really sound like he feels guilty or is very moved by the situation, but Adora got some skills in reading people during the last few years, and she can tell when someone’s saying something from his heart or not. And she believes him. This… being obviously says the truth, and he clearly cares about her. “Some more than others, huh?”
Bow doesn’t reply, but an understanding and somewhat comfortable silence falls upon them, as they continue to study the plans he brought.
He can’t tell Adora everything, and he won’t.

And then, before Adora really gets it, morning has come.

Chapter End Notes

The penultimate chapter is called "Turn it counter-clockwise" and will be published next Friday, December 24th.
As always, your comments are greatly appreciated.

[4] Learn something about Moira Ann Smith here.↑

Turn it counter-clockwise

Chapter Summary

Adora runs for everything that counts.
Catra is determined to take a hand.
Bow is called to the chairman's office.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"We need to get going. The wedding's in ten minutes!" Adora can't deny her excitement, hops from one leg to the other, and can barely contain herself. She's *super fidgety*, Glimmer would say. Despite being awake the whole night, she's oozing energy and dedication. Adora wants to jump and run, now, she wants to get to Catra, to see her, explain everything to the woman, tell her that she loves her, that she's sorry about what she did, that Catra can't...
Bow lays a hand on her shoulder and calms her: "You're lucky, it started raining again. We have time, Adora. Being early is just as bad as being late. We can't have you waiting there for her. You have to arrive exactly at the right time." An assuring smile underlines his words, then they walk through another dark and wet hallway of the widely ramified building until they reach a iron staircase.
And he's right: their plan depends on Adora arriving *on spot*. She won't have very long, before the members of the Adjustment Bureau will get a hold on her, no matter what. But when - and if - she can explain to Catra what she wants to explain, if Catra hears her out, she'll take everything else from there on. Improvising. It has always been her strength, despite the fact that she doesn't really like it. Making a plan up front is her nature, but today, she has to rely on her other strengths.

Only slowly does the night give way to dawn. Gray, heavy rain clouds still hang over the city, letting only little light through,

covering everything with a clammy wetness. Adora studied the paths with Bow until half an hour ago, then he went outside to grab two cups of coffee and handed Adora both of them. "The rain will shield you, but don't forget: when you use the first door, the hunt begins." He finishes the moment they reach the ground of a little staircase that leads to a door, the exit, from where she will leap in a minute. Adora feels the caffeine mingling with her own adrenaline, pushing the tiredness from staying up the whole night out of her system. Her heart is racing faster and faster. It might be the excitement. Or the caffeine. Or the prospect of a future unknown and terrifying. Maybe all of it.

Time has come.

"This is it," Bow just says with a terminal expression, as he turns to her.
"Okay." Adora is already breathing, deeply, like before starting a run. Because - funnily - this will be exactly one. She mentally goes through the path of the first five doors, tries to remember all the details they discussed for hours, and feels utterly unprepared to run through her home turf. *This is my city*, she assures herself. *This is my city, I got this! Puh!*
"I'm going for the blue door," Adora blurts out, and Bow just smiles. "Of course you do." It pulls a grim grin out of her, and she wants to give him a hug, but doesn't dare to, still unsure about what he actually *is*.

The Game Has Changed (Deezer / Spotify)

Bow takes his hat off, reverently traces the edge with one finger, then hands it over to Adora with a concerned face, adding: "Here is your way through it. Don't lose it." His voice doesn't waver, but she senses how important this is, how much overcoming this is costing him. She remembers his words about that this has never happened before.
"Thank you, Bow." Adora puts all emphasis she can muster on these three words.
"Good luck."

She heaves a deep breath, puts the hat on her head, then her hand grabs the doorknob, turning it, and says, “Okay.”

Adora runs.

She jumps out onto a doleful backyard street, it’s raining cats and dogs, there are puddles on the road everywhere, and Adora keeps a hand on Bow’s hat - her hat - to keep it safe on her head.
The rain has turned the streets into a nightmare, but on the lucky side, the traffic has died down to a minimum - for Manhattan. Avenue D is still busy, with people coming and going mainly into the direction of the iconic Consolidated Edison power plant on the East River at 15th Street behind her. The vast stretching building is barely visible in all the fog, but as she turns into 12th East street, it noticeably dies down to just a few cars here and there. Adora runs across the next two intersections without really caring about the traffic. She runs for 500 meters, then 800, and rain patters down on her.
There is it, the blue door, in an unobtrusive brick stone building.

The first doorknob she turns clockwise feels alien, the creaking sounds unusual, and when she passes the threshold alone for the first time, it *tugs* at her shortly, somewhere deep inside her being. It’s like this isn’t made for her, and she uses it despite.
But this is not the time to hesitate, no time to wonder, when she straight runs into the entrance hall of the New York State Department of Motor Vehicles where several people who just minded their business, stare at her now with very startled looks. She obviously came out of nowhere - through a glass door - ignores all of them, searches for the *door* among the three at the other side of the hallway, recognizes the right one and runs for it. Doorknob clockwise, grinding noise, passing threshold, poof!

Faster! She has to be faster!

Run, Adora, run.

“Grayskull’s got a hat! She went into the substrate, Ma’am, she just went into the substrate!” Suddenly, the always so quiet, carried rooms at the certain floor of the Met Life North Building come to life, when five doors pop open and men and women with gray hats start shouting the news into the hallway, where Light Hope stands at a high table. She already noticed that Adora is in Downtown Manhattan - where she so suddenly emerged in all the rain and shouldn’t be at all today - but now she freezes in her thought.
“WHAT?” Light Hope seldom gets loud, but today seems to have surprises in stock for anyone.
Netossa shows her plan book, points at the broken lines, and Light Hope can’t comprehend it in the first place. A hat? How? Well, doesn’t matter now.
Quickly, she dishes out orders to all of them: “Follow her, cut her off. Call the proctor at the wedding. Seize her.”
The next thing happens is that Light Spinner bursts out of her office, snarling, raging, and the woman is shouting: “Adora Grayskull got the hat of Beauregard Scribner. She’s running for the Court Building, right through the substrate. Light Hope, we have to stop her immediately! We can’t let her near this nuisance anymore!”

Light Hope is indignant, but collected. “Of course, Weaver. I’m ordering every field officer of New York to do exactly that. I don’t need advice on that behalf.”
The raging woman isn’t pleased: “You remember how the last time we got revealed and were barely able to contain it at the cost of almost everything? Again, it’s your incompetent subordinates who let this happen in the first place!” Weaver growls.
“Temper your tone.”
“I told you we should’ve gotten rid of Driluth as soon as she served her purpose. But you didn’t want to listen.”
“I’m not causing this kind of ripples just because of your inability to use adequate measures to problems. And your obsession with Grayskull, Weaver. Calm down, or you’ll be taking a holiday,” Light

Hope retorts with a voice that *cuts*.
Weaver's flaring aura instantly subdues, and she doesn't reply to the threat. It's not that Light Hope can do this without approval of the Chairman, but the damned facilitator has a better standing up there.
"Better," Light Hope snides. "Now, if you'll excuse me, I have to make sure that a wedding takes place and that Grayskull has no part in it."

Weaver stares after Light Hope while the emanation vanishes into thin air. She has to use the substrate as well as everyone else, but as long as there's *a door* nearby, she can just *filter through* it. Weaver always envied Light Hope for that ability. One day, it'll belong to her, she grimly thinks.
Around her, more agents burst out of their offices and run for several doors, upping the womanhunt that has obviously just begun. But Weaver knows Adora, and she's absolutely aware of how clever the woman is when it comes to handling pressuring situations for two decades. Grayskull may not be the brightest candle on the cake out there, but she clearly knows how to get what she wants, her dedication is strong, and she has a good grip on herself in any fight.
Light Hope is weak, and hasn't the guts to do what is clearly necessary, Weaver thinks. Even the Chairman is. All these figures are so blatantly incompetent when it comes to handling the things efficiently, that it's just outrageous. And so she turns around, goes for her plan book, and her hat.
She'll make sure that Adora stays on track, whatever it takes. And if that means she has to seek out an old enemy to acquire the means necessary, so be it. She'll teach these idiots how to handle this mess efficiently.

Said Adora pants and keens when she jumps out of the door of the public restroom at Columbus Park. This has been the fifth

jump, and the little public green space is right beside Worth Street, with the Courthouse on the other side of it. Only 500 meters, but Adora can't just run there. She sees one, no two men with hats scurrying towards her from the park, cornering her from the south and west - where the Courthouse is - and so she turns on her feet and runs over Bayard Street into a restaurant. Only that the door is a *door* and when she passes the threshold, she jumps out of the main entrance of the US Court of International Trade. Large marble columns tower above her, and on the other side of Federal plaza… there is the Courthouse. A hundred meters. She's a bit dizzy, because the sudden location changes are disturbing for her orientation, causing her inner compass to be totally confused. So she nearly stumbles on the lanes of Federal Plaza, only to jump back at the last second with a yelp, when a car nearly touches her. On the other side of the large place, she sees the Courthouse, but there are several people with hats on the stairs, hurrying up and down. Too many of them to be sure that there isn't one of *them*. She can't enter this way.

She needs another door.

Concentrate, Adora! There's a door that leads into the main entrance hall of the Court, but then she had to… Two of the folks start moving towards her, with measured steps. Adora decides to jump back into the door she right came through. It's a dangerous move, because they were there already, but possibly have used other doors meanwhile. There can't be dozens of them around, can there? Maybe they're coming, but she takes the risk, because the door she needs is back at Columbus Park.
Back there, her chasers have vanished, wherever. Must've something to do with their disorientation because of her quickjumping.
Whatever, doesn't matter. Adora makes a beeline for a side entrance to the Criminal Court, located at the west side of the park, which is now clear to go. Again, the doorknob, again, the creaking.

She jumps, or rather falls right out of the entrance door of the main hall of the Courthouse.

The majestic dome above her reverberates the sound as Adora crashes full force into some poor fellow who was just on his way out. Adora yelps, they clatter down to the ground, ring binders are flying around.
"Ouch," the man groans, and Adora needs a second to gather herself, stands up and raises her hands. "Sorry, sorry!" she shouts, also because a police officer who secures the entrance started moving towards the little crash. Such accidents can quickly get problematic attention these days, and Adora can't have any second of delay right now. "Just an accident!", she assures the officer, and has three minutes left to reach the entrance of the courtroom where the wedding takes place. Three minutes! Luckily, the man is alright, and the officer helps him up. "Sorry! It's an emergency, I have to go."

She leaps forward and through the metal detector that secures the building. Nothing beeps, and she's through in seconds. "You're Adora Grayskull?" the officer behind the machine asks with a concerned face. Adora yelps: "Yes, sorry. I have to run. Uuhhm… the room for today's weddings?"
"Courtroom 300, fourth floor," the man replies in a friendly manner, still frowning upon the panting woman. To her luck, he doesn't make a move to stop her.
Fourth floor? Well… stairs.
Adora runs for them, jumps up the round staircase, taking two treads at every step. Why the hell do the floors have to be so high here? She pushes the buttons at the elevator doors as she runs by them on every floor, to delay pursuers. Childhood trick.

Finally arriving at the fourth floor, panting, she has one minute left and makes a beeline for the door of courtroom 300, which is just a dozen meters before her. But a woman standing in the hallway throws her a knowing look and calls: "She's not even in there."
Adora slides to a halt. "Wha—"
"She's in the bathroom", the brunette says, and points at another door. She has a weak smile on her face, and nods into the direction. Adora throws a grateful look, turns on the spot and hurries into the restroom, pushing the door open with a loud *bang*.

There she is.

Before the mirror.

So beautiful.

Not looking happy. Rather shocked. Worried?

But just seeing Catra again is so wonderful. “Catra! You’re not marrying that girl!” Adora pants heavily, but she has to push this out, fast: “I’m so sorry, and I don’t know what you must think of me, but you can’t marry her. You CAN’T! You don’t love her!” Adora’s still gasping, and she really needs a few breaths to compose herself.

Before her, a terrified looking Catra stares back at her, and looks so amazing. She raises her hand to hold Adora back, but Adora hasn’t seen her in eleven fucking months, and still the woman looks exactly as stunning as before. She’s so drawn to her, nearly can’t hold back and approaches her with one, two steps, but suddenly, Catra’s surprise turns to anger and her hand raises to block her.

The woman’s curls are down, falling softly onto her shoulders, and she wears a long black dress, and… and it’s exactly that what tumbles out of Adora’s dumb mouth: “Black? Who the fuck wears black for a wedding?”
Catra’s startled, clearly, and only a creaking “Wha—" leaves her mouth. Her facial expression wavers between shock and anger, nearly derailed from Adora’s stupid words, and drops her hand. Adora mentally slaps herself. “Uuhh, sorry, not the point, right. I’ve been terrible, I know, but—"

“I’m getting married,” Catra says in a haze, and repeats it. “I’m getting married.” Again, she raises her hands in a somewhat defensive gesture.



(Drawing by wingedcorgi_art)

“No, you can’t!” Adora moves forward and tries to touch Catra on the bare skin of her arm. Catra flinches, but only for a moment. Then she pushes Adora back with both hands and shouts, nearly hisses: “Don’t touch me! What are you doing? Don’t you DARE, and touch me!”
The anger and hurt in Catra's voice makes Adora wince. She backs

away. “Sorry, I—"
It’s not really a scream, but it feels like one when Catra calls, and clear anger flares to life: “Do you know that no one has ever hurt me as much as you did?”
“I KNOW,” Adora cries out.
She’s so sorry about what she did, sorry about letting herself being scared by Light Hope, for leaving Catra, for not fighting harder. It’s coming deep from her heart, because of course she knows. She’s known it for eleven long months, and there hasn’t been an hour without regret and sorrow since the moment she turned away from Catra. She’d been delusional that she could make it without her, despite all of her other success. “I’m sorry that I left you the way that I did!”

Catra is angry. “You left me in a fucking hospital! I waited for you! You promised to come back and you didn’t! What’s been so important that you didn’t come back? What were you even thinking you were doing?” Catra yells. Adora’s never heard her yelling like that.
She manages a weak and desperate, “I know it seems terrible, but there was a reason, and—"
“You don’t know anything about me and what makes me happy!” Catra’s voice is loud as she cuts in, and she sounds desperate, tears seem to mix with it. The woman is on the verge of crying, making Adora’s distress grow quickly. She has to get through to her, because she doesn’t know how much time they have. “I’m sorry that I hurt you, please, let me—"

Turns out, time’s running out quickly.

Behind Adora, a man with a hat enters the bathroom - the women’s bathroom - and Adora turns on the spot and immediately punches him in the face, knocking him unconscious. She learned to channel her anger into more productive results since the last election, but now, here, violence is needed. Violence is, actually, *a solution,* even if only short-lived. The man crumbles down to the ground, and a notebook slips out of his hands. Adora grunts, and behind her Catra yells out, surprised at the sudden display of savagery. “What are you doing?”

“Don’t worry about him, he’s with them! Just listen to me,” Adora pleads, but Catra’s shocked upon the violent outburst, and steps back from Adora.
“Are you crazy, why did you do that, you idiot?”
Adora tries to calm herself down, tries to stop the panting, but she’s still breathing so hard, from the running, and now the punch.
“Forget about him.” She shuffles forward and takes one of Catra’s hands. The woman looks frightened.
“Look at me! I know that you love me,” Adora says, calming herself, trying to assure Catra of what counts.

She has seen that the man lost something, looks down and recognizes a plan book. She steps back and picks it up. “Okay, this says, that you love me, and that I love you, and that we’re not supposed to be together. Because of this book, this plan.” She opens it and shows Catra the content, which is nothing but a tangle of paths and blinking points and lines, constantly updating and redrawing. Catra stares at it, but obviously, this doesn’t explain anything to no one. “What is this?”
Adora ignores it. “I know that I’m supposed to be with you because of the way I feel. I love you, and I don’t care what happens. I want to spend the rest of my life with you, even if it’s only a little while.”

Catra can’t even begin to comprehend what the mad woman in front of her is saying.

They run upstairs the Courthouse, because of Adora’s little trick, when one of her men calls: “She just revealed us.
Light Hope throws a look into the plan book, which is practically screaming with inflection points. Grayskull is completely off the given path, and now she’s an imminent threat to the paths of other important subjects they steer also. They have avoided the

mingling of such paths for centuries, because too often some kind of weird interference disturbed them then and forced both subjects off track. Either the subjects were incredibly attracted to each other, or the result was a deathly feud. The *Wars of the Roses* started this way. Simple and easy coexistence just didn't seem to be possible. If Grayskull's actions revealed their existence to more subjects, and if only on this continent, the resulting ripple effects would reach levels of magnitude that could possibly destroy the persistence of the primary radiant at all.

And that makes many things different in Light Hope's eyes. Until now, Adora Grayskull was an asset, for so many of them, and for such a long time.
And despite they invested so many years, she just proved, that she can't be trusted and turned herself into a liability.
Light Hope feels a small spike of sorrow, with an edge of annoyance in it. *All the time, wasted.* Her voice is cool nonetheless when she tells her assistants: "Call the intervention team. Tell them it's a square-one reset now." Her lackey runs to give the orders, and somewhere in the depth of her organization, people in black suits and with strange tools start to assemble and reach for their vehicles.

Three blocks away, someone tells Bow the news: "Light Hope has deployed the intervention team. She's requesting emergency reset authorization from the Chairman." And at this time, Bow realizes, it's time to call in a favor.

Adora blocks the door to the restroom with a broom. She has to show Catra something, and can't have another interruption now.
"Why are they chasing you?" Catra asks, and her voice has gotten calmer. There is an edge of *want* to it now, but it's feeling very thin and cracked.
Adora picks up the hat from the sink and determination is in her

voice: “I’ve revealed them to you, they’re gonna reset me.”
“What are you talking about?” The woman before her obviously doesn’t understand anything, and how could Adora reproach her for that. “I never lied to you. I love you, Catra. I’m going to show you something. You deserve to know.”
“What’s going on, Adora? I don’t… no! Don’t touch me!” She hisses the last words again and tries to unwind her hand, but Adora drags her with a firm grip, and doesn’t let go of Catra’s hand as she turns the doorknob of the maintenance cabinet with the grinding sound of gears. She opens it, drags both of them through…

...and they stand at the edge of the field of the Yankee Stadium.

Catra can’t believe it and her mouth falls agape. The stadium is 15 kilometers away, far in the north of the city, and this is just not possible! The door closes behind them, Adora let go of her hand and runs around, but Catra doesn’t really notice it, because she’s on the field. She’s on the fucking field of the Yankee Stadium and her head is twirling. Above her, the iconic stands for the audience rise high.
“Okay, we got to keep moving, there’s another door here.” Adora has returned, grabs her hand again, and Catra is just too overwhelmed to really resist the pull. So she lets Adora drag her back to the wall, where she opens a door and hauls both of them through, then up some stairs, only to find themselves on 6th Avenue at the corner of West 54th. The glassy skyscrapers of Manhattan are lurking over them, casting shadows.

But the rain has gotten weaker, as well as their cover.
Adora drags her further, along 6th Avenue and Catra’s clearly not suited to run in her long dress, but now she gathers it up and takes the hem in one of her hands. This gives her a moment to collect herself. “What’s happening to me, Adora?” It comes out cooler than Adora would’ve believed she’d been able to, but there’s just no time.
“All you need to know, we’re being chased! I need you to trust me.”
“How—" Catra shakes her head in denial, and there is clearly fear

in her eyes. All of this must be a bad dream, a nightmare.
"I need you to trust me, Catra." The firmness in Adora's voice is nearly overwhelming and a strong reminder of why Adora is so successful as a politician.

Catra doesn't say anything, though. She can't. She can't say it and don't mean it. But she has a sense that Adora doesn't want to harm her - besides crashing her wedding, which is somehow ironic, given the way and reason they met in the first place - and so she can allow this crazy madness to continue for a bit. Just to find out what Adora really means with all of this. Catra can't process how they've been able to jump from the Courthouse into the Yankee Stadium and onto 6th Avenue, and she strongly guesses, she's just drunk on Scorpia's sofa and this is nothing but a wild and lively dream.
She doesn't have to do anything, though. She can just let it happen. So, for once in her life, Catra just nods and raises no argument, Adora grabs her hand again, drags her over the street and yells "Doordoordoor!!!".
They reach another door in a construction fence, push through and…

They are on Liberty Island.

The gray waters of Upper New York Bay lay before her, but Catra turns around, and behind or rather above her, Liberty *Enlightens the World* like she does for 140 years. From down here, right beneath the monumental statue, her view is absolutely intimidating. How they got here in the first place only adds to the feeling. Rain is dripping down from Liberty's stola and blurs the view. They came out through a door at her pedestal, and Catra's starting to doubt her mind. She grabs her hair and shouts at Adora, a mixture of anger and desperation dripping off her: "What the hell is going on, Adora?"
The blonde was already searching for another door, but now she comes back to Catra and calls "Sorry, sorry, sorry, I'm just so sorry. I shouldn't have left you." When she grabs Catra at both arms and holds her, she doesn't flinch like before.
"How did we just do that?"

Adora squeezes both of Catra's hands: "Okay, these doors belong to the people who are chasing us. Well, me, mostly." She wonders herself why she's able to sound so calm.
"Who are they?"
"I don't know what to call them, but they want to take you away from me. All the time."
Nothing of this makes any sense to Catra: "Why? Why do they care about us?"
Adora tries to tell this in a way Catra might understand, but she knows she's failing miserably. All the planned speeches she turned over and over in her head have long flown out of the window.
"These are the people who hurt your ankle, back then, when you had to go to the hospital. They threatened me, that everything you've worked for your entire life doesn't happen if you stay with me. That's why I left you in the hospital."
"What? I don't understand. I don't understand. That doesn't make any sense." Catra's voice silences as she frowns upon Adora's blurted explanation. "I don't understand any of this."
Unfortunately, Adora's trouble mind also lacks the words to explain it properly, not here, not now. But there's something on her lips, something that must be said. "This can't be wrong, Catra," and raises a hand to caress Catra's cheek. She searches for her eyes, they find, lock, and Adora repeats while still petting Catra's face. "This can't be wrong."

Catra's voice is unconvinced and full of disbelief. Who can blame her. All of this is still unbelievable. "Why do they think it's wrong? Isn't that something that could be… fixed?"
Adora shakes her head. "No, the book… the plan book I showed you. It says, we can't be together, because we won't reach our destiny if we do. They all act on it, and make sure we stay on plan. Their plan." Adora points at Catra's feet. "They hurt your ankle and threatened me it would be worse the next time. And I didn't… I couldn't…", Adora needs to breathe. "I could not let that happen."
And it's here, right there, when she decides to improvise. Because they deserve a chance to be together. They have to take their fate in their own hands. Adora will.

"They have their plan. And they won't let me go or us be together. But… what… what if we can find out who writes it? There must be a way."

She knows that they run out of time. The rain has nearly stopped, and soon their pursuers will know where they are. So, this is it. Adora moves towards a door at Liberty's pedestal, lays her hand on the doorknob, and turns back to look at Catra. Her curls are wet, hanging down in a mess, and still, the woman looks beautiful, even if she's trembling a bit. The rain certainly hasn't helped, but Adora know's it's not because of that.
She puts all the confidence she has into her next words: "Okay, I can go through this door alone. You'll never see me, or the people chasing us, again. I'm sure they just erase your memories of the last minutes, and put you back on track. With Scorpia, with your life, your career. It will go well, I'm sure."
Adora closes her eyes shortly and gulps down the lump in her throat when she thinks about someone else touching Catra. She hates the thought of it, and can't remember feeling so much envy before. *Go on.* "Or you could come with me, and I don't know what's on the other side, but I know you would be next to me, and that's all I've wanted since the minute I met you."

She takes a deep breath.

Catra lets out a desperate gasp. She's torn. This is all madness. Everything Adora said doesn't sound like it makes any sense, and it presumably never will. But then, they just went through *these doors*, and she can't deny that they're standing next to Liberty herself, even if minutes ago she was kilometers away and ready to vow herself to Scorpia. To an easy and successful life. With a perfect career, as it seems. Stable. Steady. Secure. At least that's what Adora said, and she believes her, for a reason she doesn't really understand. And when she thinks about that, she...

Oh stars, I believe her, Catra realizes. *I fucking believe the mad woman. And I love her just because. Or despite. Oh, no! I love her still!*

And she regards Adora, who still stands before her, holding out her hand and waiting for Catra to take or to deny it. Vulnerable. She believes Adora, but Catra still hesitates. What should she do? Dive into this world of madness and insecurity? Take the risk? Does she want this, to be with Adora so much? And possibly be hurt again? Scorpia will never hurt her, that much is for sure. Everything will be going well.

But isn't it ironic, considering where she just stands? With actual fucking Liberty right beside? The liberty to chose her own fate? And as she imagines a world where Adora is not there, not by her side, won't be there ever again, she realizes that… she can't. No, she can't. Letting her hurt and anger cloud her judgement is nothing new to Catra, but now she gasps and trembles, her heart clenches at the thought, beats faster, her breath speeds up, and her hand raises by itself, taking Adora's. She's sure. This is her choice.
"I'm coming with you."

And Adora smiles. She smiles so broadly that her jaw hurts, and hasn't felt this good in a long time. She puts her hand on the doorknob and leads Catra's hand to the other one, then instructs her: "Take the other door knob. Turn it to the left. Turn it counter-clockwise."

The grinding sound has become familiar in the course of this day, but now, it sounds slightly different, a little bit heavier. Bow told Adora not to do this, not to turn them left, he explicitly forbade it, and Adora has a clue, why he did it. They turn the knobs, holding hands, the door clicks open, they walk through…

...and they stumble into the Rose Main Reading Room of New York's Public Library. At the rows of seats to the left and right people are sitting, maybe a third of the seats are filled, just like

usual, reading, taking notes.
But then it becomes clear that these are no normal people. Everyone has a gray hat, some still on their heads, others laying on the desks, beside their plan books. They all have plan books, each one of them, open before them. And these folks are *surprised*. Some raise their heads with stunned expressions, a few stand up but don't dare to do anything as a shockwave runs through the room while the attention of everyone turns towards the women that just stumbled into the resemblance of a room that humankind knows nothing about. Adora realizes that this not the real Reading Room and maybe, this isn't New York anymore.

But Adora has Catra's hand in hers, and they have to move on, search for the one person or whoever it is in charge, the Chairman.
To get answers.
They deserve answers.

One of the men before her stands up and yells "You're not allowed __"
Adora springs forward, punches him at his shoulders with her free hand, back to his place, while she still doesn't let go of Catra's hand.
Another one yells "Hold them up", trying to block their way, and Adora throws him on the table, dragging Catra behind her with a firm grip. She won't let go. It's clear that these folks obviously haven't expected them here. Adora pull Catra closer while they rush forward, aiming for a large door at the end of three steps. She whispers: "We need to find the Chairman's office."

Behind them, more of the strange people populating the large hall rise from their places, and Adora pushes another fellow out of their way. Most of the folks are just frozen in their places, but some have pulled out devices and talk into them. Adora and Catra are running for the exit that seemingly leads to another hallway where more important rooms might lay. It's a rather narrow chance, but it's what they have been dealt. Adora throws the door open with her free hand, and it makes just a normal sound. They enter a corridor with several doors left and right. On one side,

there seems to be a larger hall, so Adora goes for this way, always with Catra in tow. The woman seems to be stunned, maybe still overwhelmed by all the revelations she had no time to process properly. She follows Adora willingly, but for how much longer?

They haven't seen that behind them, Light Hope pushes open the same door to the Reading Room Adora and Catra stumbled through a mere minute ago, with numerous of her henchmen in tow, and is following them with a grim and determined expression. The intervention team is minutes away, and when Light Hope gets a hold on the women, they will clean up this mess once and for all.

Adora and Catra climb up a spiral staircase that leads into the sky, it seems. The round of stairs leads upwards in many turns, and they fly over the steps. It takes them minutes, they both pant, but luckily, they are in good shape. Adora and Catra reach the top floor of the tower-like staircase, from where another large hallways lead to more rooms. Beneath them, Adora can hear loud steps of people following them, and she knows they're running out of time.
She opens the door to another room that seems to be an archive. Shelves and shelves with books, old plan books stand there, until under the ceiling. It's all beautifully crafted wood and chiseled glass, and they would admire it, if they weren't chased.

Bow throws a look into his plan book and freezes. The lines of Adora and Catra have just vanished into nothing, they are gone from the plan. In the first place, he can't really comprehend it, because something like this has never happened. But moments later, they reappear, and right before the present line, dozens of inflection points are blinking wildly. The plan book would scream if it only could.
"Oh no." He stops walking through the hallway, not far away from

where he now knows both of them have appeared. Here, and despite he strictly forbade Adora to use his hat that way. *That's only for us*, he'd said. Now, they'll know for sure it's his hat. He turns around and wants to get to them. Maybe it's not all lost, maybe he can save them from being…
His thoughts are cut short as he's approached by someone. The man holds out an envelope, and says: "Beauregard Scribner. They want you in the Chairman's office. Immediately."
Bow sighs, and maybe calling in a favor had worked fast enough. The other option is, that this is how his service ends. He takes the envelope, nods, and goes where he has to go.

This isn't good, and it's going to get worse.

Adora never let go of Catra's hand. After passing through several archive rooms that all look the same, they run up another broad, concrete staircase that leads them to another door. She pushes it open, and they stumble out on the viewing platform of Top of the Rock, 45 Rockefeller Plaza, Manhattan.
The sight over New York is marvelous, but the gasping women have no eye for it. They are chased, only two doors lead down from here, one before them, the other is the one they just came through. Adora jumps forward and reaches for the other door, hoping it is *one of them*, providing them a way out, or to the person she's looking for. At this point, she has little hope left that everything will turn out well.

And it isn't.

When they run through, they just come out at the door on the other side of the platform, in the exact same place, at the terrace of the Rock, 250 meters above the ground. Central Park to the north, the District to the south.
Behind them, at the end of the stairs, the way is already blocked

by uniformed henchmen, everyone equipped with baton and taser, their faces hidden behind helmets, walking up the stairs. On the other side, the other door, the same.
It dawns on Adora, that there is might be no way out of this. She stops and gasps, then Catra squeezes her hand upon the realization and drags her in, closer.

They are surrounded. They are trapped.
No escape.
Adora knows what will come, what Casta and Light Hope said they would do if she reveals them.
Lobotomy. Erasing her personality. Everything gone.
Her life.
Her love to Catra, gone.

Uniformed figures spill out of both doors and surround them. Cornered by a dozen underlings of Light Hope, without a way out, Adora turns to Catra. Her face shows nothing but terror and fear. In an attempt to calm her, Adora cups her cheeks with both her hands. She would do it again, when she takes Catra in her arms, embracing the woman she loves since four years ago and whom she met for four days and one night only.
Here, at the end of her road, it's all she can do. Maybe they'll spare Catra if she cooperates now. As Adora looks into Catra's eyes and is met with the same expression, she's okay with everything.

Everything is clear. Everything is good.
"I love you."
"I love you."

They say it at the same time, and it makes all worth it. They close their eyes, and kiss each other, trivial as this is. Catra's lips haven't changed a bit since three years ago. They maybe got a bit more mature, so to say, but they brush over Adora's with the same gentle attitude and willingness than before. Adora lets out a small, desperate gasp and kisses Catra more. Her hands cup Catra's face. More. One last time. More. Just once more. She loves her. It's okay. More, only once more.

“Wha—"

Adora opens her eyes again at Catra’s exclamation, not realizing she’s closed them in the first place. She just wants to exist there, in her arms. And suddenly she sees that the henchmen are gone, and there is only Light Hope standing next to them, looking over New York, with a disappointed, angry look.
Suddenly, the sun breaks through the cloudy, overcast sky, and covers half of Manhattan in a gently, warm sunlight that seems to taunt their dire situation. Nature is a hard bitch.
Light Hope tears her gaze away and stares at the women, finally sighing. “Did you really think you could reach the Chairman?” The glowy emanation doesn’t look so different from before. But her voice carries a sad note. “And change your fate if you did? Or write your own. It doesn’t work like that, and I told you why.”
She pulls a corner of her mouth in a resemblance that might be compassion or something similar. Whatever seems to appear on her face, her voice is firm, and assures Adora of what she has to do.

Adora grabs Catra’s hand one last time and puts the woman behind herself, despite the uselessness of the protective gesture. “Light Hope, I’ll go with you willingly, but you have to let Catra go first.”
Light Hope frowns shortly, then composes again, maybe readying to order her henchmen, and Adora has a strong premonition of what’s coming.

Only, that it doesn’t.

What comes instead is Bow, appearing from the staircase beside them, with a piece of thick paper in his hand. He walks over to Light Hope and hands it over to her, his face nothing but a neutral mask. “I’ve got a message for you.”
The woman looks at the piece and her appearance changes into something unreadable, a bit more dull than before, then she suddenly looks kind of broken, actually. Adora and Catra still cling together, their hands firmly intertwined, when Light Hope says with a hollow voice to no one in particular: “I understand.”

She takes another look at Adora and Catra that the women can't interpret. Around them, the sun shines brighter, breaking through the clouds more and more. Then, Light Hope vanishes into thin air and is gone.

"The Ripples must be endless" (Deezer)

Suddenly, everything feels so light. It is maybe a coincidence that the clouds are thinning out and give more way to a golden illuminated sight of New York. Skyscrapers reflect the sun's rays into all directions.
"Even Light Hope has a boss," Bow says, and the smile on his face is unmissable. It's rather a smirk.
The tension lifts, somehow. Adora can't believe it. "Bow?" She needs a few seconds to collect herself, still gripping Catra's poor hand so hard. "You're the Chairman?"
Bow laughs loud, it's more a huff, but then he grins wide and says: "No. Of course not. Buuut, I think you've met him, though. Or her. Them." He corrects himself immediately, and Adora wonders what that should mean, but Bow already continues: "I mean, everybody has. The Chairman comes in a different form to everyone, so people rarely realize when it happens, you know? I'm sure you've crossed ways, actually."
Catra cuts in: "What does that mean? Is this some sort of weird test for us?"
Bow looks at her friendly for a moment, then taps his head: "Nice to meet you, Catra." He turns towards the railing, laying his hands on it, and looks over New York, regarding the view and obviously thinking about his answer. "Look, in a way, it's all a test, for everybody, even the members of the Adjustment Bureau. The Chairman is playing a very long game, and we see only a tiny part of it. It's not often that they interfere in the way they did right now. And like this, I never experienced it for myself or have heard of.

Then he turns back to the women. "Adora, you risked everything for Catra. And Catra, when you came through that door at the Statue of Liberty, you risked everything, too. I assume, your dedication inspired the Chairman."

Adora wonders where this is actually going, and points at the paper in Bow's hand. "Is that about us?
"Yes."
"What does it say?"
He pulls a corner of his mouth. "It says that this situation between the two of you is a serious deviation of the plan. And we can't have that." Bow sound's earnest and amused at the same time. Neither Adora nor Catra can read his intention, but luckily, they don't have to. He turns the thick paper around and shows them.

"So, the Chairman rewrote it."

The two paths, indicating the fate of Adora and Catra, have been separate before, the lines far away from each other with no tangency or contact. Now, where the thick and blinking vertical line indicates the present, they are side by side. And they continue like that. Before them is nothing but a blank, white paper, aside their two lines, leading into the future.

Undetermined. Unknown. Free.
With their paths next to each other.

Bow takes the paper back. "See, most people live life on the path we set for them. Too afraid to explore any other. But once in a while, people come along who knock down all the obstacles we put at the sides of their paths, to keep them on track. People who realize free will is a gift you'll never know how to use until you fight for it. I think that's the Chairman's real plan, and maybe, one day, they won't write the plan anymore."
It takes Adora a moment before she can make up the obvious question: "Okay, now what?" She is still stunned, but she has Catra's hand in hers, and that's all she needs to know. She feels Catras squeezing her hand, as the other woman comes to the same realization, and it makes the knot in her gut loosen.

Bow grins a lot. He takes a step forward and grabs his hat from Adora's head, still smiling. "Now, you can take the stairs. See you around." Putting the bowler back on his own head, he taps the edge with a finger, nods, then walks towards the staircase, and is

gone, leaving the women behind.
Above them, the hitherto overcast sky had changed into a mostly clear, serene blue, giving way for the sun to bathe everything in a golden light. Glittering, the wet skyscrapers of New York throw the sun's rays in all directions and sparkle intensely. It's like if a rainbow wave washes through the city. Never have the colors of the world been so intense, so impressive. Adora thinks she's the luckiest person on Earth, having Catra's hand in her own, and still being herself.

Luckily, *taking the stairs* only meant taking them two floors below, where the elevators end. So their descent from the Top of the Rock is less strenuous than feared. Adora and Catra scurry along 5th Avenue of morning New York, rather aimlessly for now. Adora looks at Catra, Catra looks back at Adora, and both women know they think the same. "My place or yours?" Adora asks, and Catra smirks. "Yours is closer, huh?"
"So eager? How embarrassing for you." Adora replies with a smug grin plastering her face. It's outright annoying how someone can heave such a big ego, but for Adora, this is the second-best day of her life. Right after the last time they met and when they ended in Catra's apartment. So… time for payback, right?

Catra draws out her phone and voices coolly: "I mean, I can always slide in at the Two Pines for a rehearsal, you know? Actually, I'd like to call an Uber, yep! Suit yourself."
Adora yelps and snatches Catra's mobile with a quick grip. "Don't you dare! I won't let you out of my sight for the next day. Days! Actually."
"Who's horny now?"
"I'm not horny! That's—"
"The absolute truth," Catra grins and kisses Adora wildly. Her hands travel up and down Adora's back, she can feel she shivers running through the other woman, and she's delighted how well

Adora reacts to her touching. They both know that there is a lot to process, but they have time. Now, this is important.

They walk among the streets of New York, and make their way towards Adora's apartment at Madison Square Park. As they stand before the tall building, Catra leans her head back and mutters: "Show off."
"What? That's not what hmpfff—" Adora's response is interjected by another kiss. Both women are giggling and are totally distracted with more mutual kissing and touching of indecent body parts, when they finally stumble through Adora's door, with Catra pushing the blonde backwards through it, eager to get in and to bed.

It's unfortunate, that Adora's door isn't just a door anymore. But *a door.* They fall.

Adora's head buzzes. Still in a haze, she touches the side of her skull. "Ow!", it slips off her tongue, and she has a ferrous taste in her mouth. Beside her is Catra, seemingly unconscious. Her figure lays on her front, her head covered by an arm and hand.
"Catra!" She crawls over and puts Catra's head in her own lap, gently touching it. She releases a deep sigh of relief when the woman opens her eyes after a few seconds. "Uugh." She seems to be in the same state as Adora, shakes her head and looks back at her. "What happened? What kind of place is this?" Catra asks, looking around.
Adora quickly realizes that they are in the damned concrete hall again, where she met Casta first, and then Light Hope. "Not again," she sighs, and it gets her a questioning look from Catra. "What do you mean with that?"
"I've been here before. It's the place where I'd been told that I can't be with you. Multiple times, actually."
Catra scoffs. "Yeah, well, I guess that didn't work out, huh? Maybe

they should've talked with me instead. I would've told them to fuck off the first time", she mocks, and Adora has the nerve to actually look wounded. "Hey, I did too."
"Yeah, maybe, but you're pretty lousy at convincing people, aren't you? I mean, look where you are now." She gets serious when she looks around. "Any way out of here?"

Adora shrugs her shoulders, and they stand up, slowly. "Not that I would know. The first time they threw me through a door they opened, and the second one the roll gate opened. It was before we met at your dancing spot."
"And these folks told you to stay away from me? Here? Multiple times?" Catra scurries around a few paces, watching and mapping the space.
Adora looks down at the floor, as if that was her fault. And maybe she should've tried harder, back then, when Light Hope dissected them. Suddenly, Catra is before her and lowers herself to the ground. Her voice is soft, and slow: "Hey. You came back, right in time, okay. You stayed." She takes Adora into an embrace, and the blonde woman just melts into the touch. "You're terrible at listening, aren't you?" Catra chuckles. "These… beings, whatever they are, threatened you multiple times, and you still tried to stick with me?"
Adora giggles out a few teary laughs. "Yeah, you know… I'm…. stubborn." Her head lies on Catra's shoulder, and for the first time in so long, she just lets herself being caressed by the hand that softly strikes her head and cheek. It's strange how even in this odd situation all she can think of is that this is the most wonderful place in the world to be. To stay. With her.

Everything feels like a dream, but it is not.

That becomes clear, when suddenly a weirdly frightening figure appears from somewhere in the hall and places herself in front of them. It's a woman, the woman with the odd mask covering most of her face, and it's obvious that sheer anger drips off of her.
Adora has seen her only once, from the corner of her eyes, on the first time she got here. She was the one scolding Casta.
She has a horrible feeling, and instinctively jumps and puts herself

before Catra. It earns her a low growl by her beloved, but she's already sensing something, and she will protect Catra no matter what.
"Adora," the woman snarls, putting a weird emphasis on the "o" of her name. "My dear, would you please take a step aside?"
Adora is a bit confused about the surprisingly intimate approach. "What? No. Who are you even?"
"I'm the one taking care that you don't waste your fate, Adora. A fate long determined before you were even there."
"I thought, we'd been able to plan for ourselves now? Bow just said—"
"Unfortunately, the kind-hearted idiot was able to charm the Chairman with his serenade about you two. I'm not so gullible," the woman scoffs.

Adora is angry.
After all these revelations from the last, what, 24 hours or so, she's really done with being interfered, intercepted, *adjusted*. She just wants to go home and cuddle her future-wife-to-be or whatever it is that Catra wants to make out of this when they're finally alone and can talk about it. As long as Catra is with her, she'll be fine with it.
Adora stills holds Catra firmly behind herself, and even if the woman bristles against her back, she doesn't let her go. Adora just can't, and Catra has to live with that.
"What do you want?" she growls.

"I want you to step aside, Adora, so I can make sure that you can reach your destiny. It is your fate, and for the better of all of us."
Adora has enough. "Ah, is this for the better of Catra and me also? Does some plan that I had no say in writing say anything that I should know?"
It's dumb of Catra to step aside and raise her fist at the woman, but this fucked-up bitch annoys her beyond anything. "You wanna tell me something? Don't hold back. I'm not spooked by you."
The fiend grins behind the mask and snarls: "Oh, but you should."
She flicks her hand and something bright leaves it, aiming at Catra.

It’s a snap decision, and Adora doesn’t think, she just throws herself before Catra and is hit by whatever that is. She’s pushed back into Catra’s arms, and her head hits the woman’s chest, sending them down to the ground. For a second, she catches Catra’s appalled look, hears the masked woman calling “Adora, no!”, but then her lights are already going out. Another “Adora!” is shouted by whoever, then it’s suddenly becoming very, very silent.

White light fills this place, and maybe the entire world too. It’s so bright, it seems that the sun itself has decided to rise in here. Quickly, Adora tries to grab Catra, but she isn’t there anymore, there’s just nothing around her. She turns around, but she’s all alone in here. The air seems to whir and rustle of electricity, but there’s nothing to be seen. Only white ground, endless white room, a white ceiling or sky or whatever this is.
After a few moments, a voice is to be heard. Familiar, but also alien, mellow and firm at the same time. There’s something like a fairy figure hovering in the distance, up above, but it’s not really perceivable. “Go, Light Spinner. This situation has been adjusted. Your service is no longer needed.”
The voice of the woman called Light Spinner is also dimmed. It’s the same as the voice of the bitch that attacked Catra. And… killed her? Is she dead?
“But you can’t!,” Adora hears, ”this nuisance will bring nothing but distraction and disarray upon Adora. The path has to be—"
“Has been rewritten. I took care. They will go this way together.”
Light Spinner screams, it’s nearly a yowl. “NO! I always knew you were too weak to do what’s necessary. You won’t stop me when I get rid of—"
“Do not challenge me. You miscalculated, Weaver. Prime has no power here.” The voice of the fairy figure is very firm and very quiet.
It’s heard.

But it’s not recognized.
Light Spinner shouts, “You wouldn't dare to do that. You can’t intervene—"

Adora isn’t really able to look at what’s happening there, her eyes would be blinded forever for it’s still so shining bright.
But she can try to see something, if she shields her eyes against the place from where the light comes, and so she looks to the side, squinted, where her gaze falls upon something that seems to be mirrors or windows. And it is there where she can make out a female figure, wafting before the masked one. It’s an only sketchy image, mirroring in something what could glass but isn’t. Anyway, it must be enough to grab it.
The figure seems to do something, maybe waving a hand curtly, and a spherical blow strikes through the air, pushes Adora down to the ground, and silence falls upon the scenery as her lights go out again.

Again, like it’s fucking Groundhog Day, she’s back in the hall and Catra is at her side, grunts, stumbles, and falls onto Adora, and Adora lets out a short “Ouch!” Catra is slim and significantly lighter than Adora, but that doesn't mean she doesn't weigh anything. Her chest hurts from the blow, but at least the bright sunshine is gone, and they’re able to gather themselves.

As the women look around, they realize that Light Spinner is gone. And a shiny figure holds out her hand to Catra, then to Adora and helps both of them up.
“Thank you,” Adora says, and looks puzzled. The luminous being seems to be a woman in a long fairylike dress, a rose vest contouring her body and long bright hair flowing down her back. She says nothing, but now it slowly dawns on Adora.
“Are you… the Chairman?”
The figure bows her head slightly, then she says: “Some use that

name. My full name is R. Angella Venabili, but please, call me Angella. I am not so keen of the other sayings." Has she winked? Adora's a bit dumbfounded, and for the first time in her life, Catra also seems at a loss of speech. Finally, she manages a suppressed: "Why are we still here again, in this… hall?"
"Hmm. Let's say, it's a place where we can shortly speak to each other. Its location has no meaning regarding your… sense of the world."

Catra has composed herself and mainly wants to know one thing: "Where's this mean bitch? Light Spinner? Was that her name?"
The figure nods lightly. "Yes. I have called her back. She won't interfere again. We will take care of her."
"Whatever that means, I guess, huh?" Catra lets out with a growl and earns a slightly tilted head in return.
Angella's voice doesn't waver. "I understand your frustration, Catra. But you are not here to get many answers. It was just my only way to intervene on your behalf without breaking too much."
Adora frowns. She's glad not to be dead, sure, but all this sneaky and secretive demeanor is just outright annoying. "Why can't you just… intervene. I mean, directly on Earth? To make it less… obvious? Isn't that the way you prefer to handle us?"
The wafting figure tilts her head slightly. "I can, but the cost is too high. I can recall my own kind, but in your realm, using my powers is equivalent to some ants you pave over. The forces of my kind are not designed for *surgical intervention on this microscopic level*, to put it that way. I create and undo on a much… larger scale. I might not act on myself on Earth and therefore, I need—"
"Paws. You need paws. And they are," Adora interrupts her, disillusioned, sighing, "as well as we are to them."
Angella nods, and there is no audible regret. "Yes, mostly."

It's a bold confirmation, and it seems that even angels or whatever they are, are just footmen to higher powers. It's like Bow said. And on that thought, another one, an even far more reaching one, strikes her mind. Maybe Adora stretches her luck in the sight of… whatever Angella is, but she has to ask this. "Is there… someone else above you? Or are you - please forgive the

expression - the top of the food chain?”
Angella tilts her head, pulls a corner of her mouth, then she laughs wholeheartedly. It doesn’t last long, but it’s liberating to hear god or goddess or whatever she is just laughing like a human. “No one has asked me that for thousands of years,” she still giggles. She actually giggles, and it makes Adora question her mind. Again.

“You are remarkable, Adora, and I’m glad I met you. You will achieve great things, and you won't even need us helping you. Thank you. Maybe we can leave Earth with you.”
Adora doesn’t know what to make with this compliment, and she isn’t sure it is one. And she frowns at the kind reply, because:
“You didn’t answer my question.”
“I didn’t,” Angella simply says.
“And you won’t,” Adora sighs, and the emanation before her does nothing.
“Okay, keep your secrets. And now? What shall I do now?”
“Now, you're gonna go back and get to work. Like you wanted.”
She doesn’t believe a word, because… it can't be so easy, that's just ridiculous. “Just like that, huh?”

“Just like that. Take care of each other.”

Angella flicks her hand, and is gone, and then Adora and Catra blink upon the sudden change of scenery, because they are back at the place where everything started: in the men’s room of the Waldorf Astoria, 301 Park Avenue, Manhattan, right beside the Grand Ballroom.
Catra looks at Adora, incredulously. “She… she didn’t do *that*, did she?” Adora is up to open her mouth to say something - anything - when it clicks in one booth behind them, then a man in a dark suit walks out and frowns at the sight of two women standing in the middle of the large room, holding each other by the hands, both looking a bit ruffled. He walks towards the sink, washes his hands and dries them with measured movements, while Adora and Catra are still frozen into place, doing nothing besides clinging to the other one’s hands and watching quietly. If their mouths have fallen agape, they don’t notice it. As the man walks by to

leave the room, he throws them a small grin, mutters something that sounds very suspicious like “This is a hotel, get a room”, and is gone.

When the door finally closes behind him, Catra lets out a deep breath, takes Adora in her arms, and hugs her so firmly, that the held woman can barely breathe. It’s probably breaking her rib cage, but it’s the best feeling Adora has since an eternity. They murmur assurances into each other's ears. “Thank you. Thank you. Thank you,” Adora repeats herself over and over again. She puts her nose into Catra’s hair and inhales her scent.
She has missed this so much. They had one mutual night, and ever since, she missed this. Catra buries her head onto Adora’s collarbone and her eyes are shut. She doesn’t say anything, she just drinks in the presence of the woman before her, trying to realize that she is actually here, and that this is no dream.

“Your place or mine?”, Adora asks after some time, her head still nuzzling in Catra’s neck.
Catra smirks at her. “You know, the guy was right, actually. This is a hotel, you know?”
Adora’s eyes go wide, but only for a second. Then she repeats the smirk. “Let’s do it.”

Chapter End Notes

Please give *wingedcorgy* a visit on her account. Since I always admired her little Catradora-comics because of their excellent humor, I was happy when I was able to commission her with a drawing.

So, only one chapter left. It's name is "Westward The Course Of Empire Takes Its Way", and will be published on New Years Eve, Friday, December 31st.
Have a very pathetic ending there, and an overly lengthy afterword as well ;-). As always, your comments are greatly appreciated.

Westward The Course Of Empire Takes Its Way

Chapter Summary

The chairwoman has some trust.
Mermista can cross something off her bucket list.
Adora's going to shatter some things.
Catra is still Catra.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The hall is wide and empty. Large transparent walls let in plenty of light, and make it bright. Outside, one can see the moon in a star-studded, but otherwise dark sky. And earth. It's not that this is a real place. It is more a resemblance of a place that was, or could be. They don't need it to meet or discuss things, but even *they* admire the sight, and appreciate being able to use a physical form, in order to be more close to their subjects.
It's always a struggle, an act of balancing and weighing the needs of many against the needs of everyone. To bring humanity here, many sacrifices had been necessary. So they use this place for gatherings, but also for contemplation when needed, and it seems that this is more often the case in recent times.
Bow hasn't become acquainted with it, but he's getting there. He's still Adora's warden, but his duties have notably eased up during the last year. Sometimes, he makes a very small adjustment - it's rather *nudging* the Senator than anything else. This woman strongly needs a better calendar, that's for sure, because Catra will get grumpy if her birthday is overlooked. Nobody wants that kind of disturbance, and Bow likes putting an occasional hint into Adora's office or another place to remind the woman of that. Her tendency to overwork herself hasn't really eased. Luckily, Catra is a strong reminder to her what also counts in her life.

However, and whatever this place is, right now there are only two figures standing there, looking down. And an important decision is imminent. The other figure has her hands folded behind her back, and Bow scratches his chin as he asks: "Do you really think it is a good idea? It's not that I totally disagree, but it would be nice to understand, you know?"
The tall and slender figure tilts her head slightly, and smiles: "I don't *know*, Bow, but I have a feeling. At some point, we're going to have to trust them again. At least, some of them, don't we?"
"Hmm." He doesn't sound so convinced. Maybe his opinion is biased, because he has been doing his job for so long that he can't imagine a world where they don't *adjust* all the time. "And what if she's going to mess it up? We know the woman can throw a tantrum, don't we? Both of them, actually. And abandoning the plan like this is something I never experienced. I approve of it, somehow, but I still feel pretty uncomfortable."
"Is this because you're afraid of becoming useless, Bow?"
He looks down on the ground. This point has actually crossed his mind, yes, but he wouldn't dare to speak it out loud.
"Do not fret, my friend," she continues, laying a hand on his shoulder. "Your service will always be needed. There's still so much to do. Is this all you fear?"

"Not really. I mean, letting them do their own thing?"
The answer is calm, and sincere: "I trust that she'll grow, but yes, we'll have to live with that possibility." The figure kneads her hands and forms a rhombus, with her thumbs pointing upwards and the other fingers downwards. "I just want to note, it came to my mind, that letting her be with Catra might actually work in our way as much as it will work in hers."
He furrows his eyebrows: "How do you mean that? Do we not simply throw away all plans for Adora's future and what would come with it so far? Half a century of work, just to throw it away?"
He's surprised as gets some light laughter in return.
"Why do you think that I let you tell Adora all about Light Hope's lying to her? Don't you think I could've prevented that?" There's no reproach in their words, it's a mere statement.

Bow looks caught, though, and has the decency to stutter: "Uh… Uh… I didn't… I'm sorry."
Again, a kind laugh, and a pat on the shoulder. This has never happened before. Bow doesn't know if anyone has been touched by—.
"Don't be. I actually had a feeling that this would turn out to be a way the radiant would approve."

Bow looks surprised. "But, isn't she going to be distracted by Catra the whole time? Isn't she going to lose the urge that we need? That was what we worked against. I know what I did, and I still stand by my decision. Adora would've been of no use if she's just a lifeless shell. But stopping all our adjustments around her… well, uhm, I'm still fearing the consequences."
"Oh, she is distracted, for sure." She makes a gesture and Adora's plan manifests in front of them, then she points at a time a few years into the future. "See. Her efficiency is affected. Here. Catra will take much of her attention she would've put otherwise away. And, I mean, look at them and their… uhm, *repeated usage*… of the Resolute Desk." They both look at each other and roll their eyes mutually. "Be assured, I'm aware of the fact, fed it to the primary radiant, and had it calculated."
"The rad—"
Angella snickers. "You can just keep saying 'Heart' to it, okay? It fits you more, Bow. You're the rather emotional type here, not me."

Did the Chairwoman actually wink at him? No, that has never happened, he's sure. She would *never,* so he just asks: "Then, why?"
The Chairwoman shoots him an amused look and lets him stew for a moment before answering him: "Adora's still competitive and confident. And she loves Catra with all her being, that is for sure. Do you not think she will do everything in her power to keep Catra safe?"
He nods slowly and the Chairwoman continues: "And this was my mistake. To not calculate that. Given her personality, she'll exert her power to do that, but with a focus that meets her means. She'll just extend this care to all the people around them. To a

lesser degree, but nonetheless. And, in further extension, to simply everyone. She is just like that, and there was nothing we had to do about it. It is actually ridiculous that I did not see it earlier. Except for her occasional clumsiness and slip-ups, she is maybe the least destructive human we ever warded, you know?"

She points down at Earth. "Given the knowledge she has, she'll spend the rest of her life making sure that Catra is safe and that her world makes it. And more than anything else, this world needs optimism and willpower, decisiveness, Bow, to make it through the coming decades. And Adora, with all her unbridled energy, has plenty of that. She's a - how do they phrase it down there… a bullseye, yes. So, what more could we ask for?"
Her voice is very firm while she says that, and he tilts his head. "I haven't looked at it that way."
"I know. I also did not. But the equations are sure. If you look at the Heart now, it is much more stable and… balanced, beautiful even. It is the first time in centuries. Good job."

She winks, Bow has absolutely seen it, but she continues with a rather contemplating voice and again, folded hands before her lap. "Maybe, even we learned something during these recent events. I cannot wait to see what she comes up with next. These are going to be interesting times, won't you say so?"

Bow nods slowly. He doesn't think that 'interesting times' are something humankind actually needs or really wants. This planet needs a breather, to downshift, to think about his options and a meaningful path towards the future. They have possibilities, so many, but they don't think far enough, always struggling with their meaningless need to outbid each other. And 'interesting times' is just another wording for 'chaos and turmoil'.
But, after all, she's the Chairwoman and should know what she's speaking about. It's not that she hasn't done this for the last few thousands of years. If she trusts Adora, they can do as well.

Seven years later

The evening before the big day. Adora - okay, Glimmer - invited a lot of their supporters to a little gathering in their new home. Plenty of people flocked in during the last hour, already mingling and chattering with each other, picking goodies from the buffet, while relaxed laughter wafts through the East Room. A live band of two plays music in the background, but it's not too loud, because this evening is just for having a nice time with each other, not for getting drunk and crashed. It would be a little unbecoming. But everyone deserves a break, after giving everything for the last two years. This is a part of their reward, being received here, in this house, in this room, by Adora and Glimmer, and for one evening all of them can be friends instead of just being allies.

Adora stands beside the door to the entrance hall and smiles at the incoming pair, already inwardly giggling. Her white-golden jacket of the suit is cut at the sleeves and leaves her forearms uncovered, her shoes have no heels, and yet they kill her, but her hair poof is still where it always has been, and her eyes are sparkling of joy. She's having so much fun while also being absolutely cocky about this whole event. *Haha.* On the other side of the large door stands Juliet, the freshly appointed head of her detail, and the woman eyes everyone carefully and warily.
"Hey, I'm here too, don't make a big thing out of it," Mermista Salineas hums, but it shows that it's hard for her to not be impressed by the surrounding. Mermista is a snarky bitch and cool, but not that cool.
"Ah, the infamous Sea Hawk, I suppose?", Adora says. She hasn't met him in person till today, but she's of course *heard* of him, because Mermista complains about her boyfriend / husband to be / competitor all the time. The middle-aged man twirls his mustache in delight and declares with a booming voice: "Yes, Ma'am, I'm proud to be at your service! And I see that my reputation precedes me! That is of course not unexpected."
"Ugh", Mermista groans, facepalms, and Adora chuckles lowly,

taking her hand in both of hers and shaking it warmly. “So, he’s your plus one? I take it you made amends since a month ago? Last time I heard, it looked like you were bitter rivals? Mermista —"
“He’s just my ride!” Mermista cuts in quick, and waves it off, repeating “Just. My. Ride”, while Sea Hawk lays an arm around her shoulder and raises the other hand with a straight index finger. “But my dearest! Why don’t you let your friend indulge in the compelling story of how we met? I must say, it was quite an adven—"
“DON’T! Don’t say it, or I’ll get a taxi!” Mermista cuts him short.

Adora looks back and forth between the two and desperately tries not to laugh, being on the very edge of failing. Hiding behind a cough, she asks: “So, Mermista, how did you meet?”
The woman unfortunately just rolls her eyes with folded arms, and hesitates a second too long to speak. Enough time for Sea Hawk to take over excitedly:: “I literally saved her life from the danger of perishing due to the treacherous ways of the seas!”
“Really? You don’t say!” Adora coos, fakingly, because she already heard the story from Glimmer, but teasing Mermista is just too funny. The last three times they met for talking and sharing gossip - uhmm… talking about donations, legal stuff and advice, of course! - Mermista complained about how Sea Hawk was stalking her. He seemed to appear out of nowhere on every conference she attended and showered her with compliments and attention. It was clear to everyone that she silently liked his overbearing attitude, but that would never stop her from lamenting in public..

“Yes, of course! One of her cargo ships was in danger of colliding with the Bayonne Bridge due to a failure at the helm, and I gave orders to one ship of mine to prevent that. Just think what could’ve happened to the Bay, if—"
“You were literally on the bridge, you idiot, steering it yourself. Don’t deny it,” Mermista accuses him loudly, her eyes shooting daggers.
His index finger points to the ceiling of the lavishly decorated room. “I do not deny anything, my dearest! I am proud to have prevented a disaster, and—"

“You had fun pushing my ship around!”
“I—"
“That was absolutely irresponsible. You could have sunk both our ships and drowned!”
That being said, Mermista rushes away, Sea Hawk in tow who has a puzzled look on his face, and Adora laughs about the ridiculous pair they both form. Glimmer strolls over, a glass of champagne in her hand, giggling: “It’s so funny to watch them. Mermista's still sticking to her attitude?” Adora grins at her friend: “Yup. She still thinks it’s not that obvious. She could’ve just said ‘thank you’ to the idiot, but what do I know?” Both women stand side by side, quiet for a moment, then Glimmer nudges Adora with her shoulder. “Did you think we would celebrate here today?”
“Sure,” Adora boasts, and has put on a cocky smile.
“Oh, do you, ma’am? I think I’ll have to ask your wife to deflate you a little, huh?”
Adora's face shows a slight hint of "Don't you dare", then Glimmer giggles, they laugh, and both of them watch how Mermista clings to Sea Hawk's arm while the man impresses two poor ladies with a story. "Never seen her so touchy before," Adora says and gets a nod. "Yeah, she never wanted to fawn over anyone, and she complains about him all the time. But if he spends even the tiniest piece of attention on anyone but her, she’s always at his side. The woman is just… ugh!"

"What are you two damsels talking about?", asks Catra who just appears out of nowhere in a sneaky attack. Adora is long used to her wife's liking for being a brat, but it still startles Glimmer funnily. "Mermista is sailing in uncharted waters with a compass that doesn't figure out North from South,” Adora tells her with a half-absentminded tone, because she still eyes the subject of her sentence out of curiosity, but focuses back on her friends when it’s suddenly so silent. She finds Catra and Glimmer staring at her with wide eyes. “Uhm, what?”
Catra’s face morphs into a smirk. “Oh, wow, Adora, how… poetic. Never took your goodness for such a literate woman."
It pulls a groan out of Adora. “See, Glimmer, what I’ve to deal with on a daily basis? My wife is cruel. It’s like constant betrayal!

We have to do something about that, I guess." Her friend just waves with her hands in denial, because Glim’s not going to do anything to let Adora out of Catra’s clutches. “Not my problem. You married her!”
The evil pair has just too much fun to occasionally fluster Adora like hell, and the blonde stares grumpily at them.

Her wife nudges her shoulder, saying tenderly: "That's just because I like you, babe."
Adora’s eyes go soft when hearing this. Catra slowly got a bit more open-hearted over the last years, but she still isn't very good at expressing her feelings to anyone. That is, to anyone but Adora. "Aww, you like me," Adora says, turns and lays her arms around her waist, drawing her in just a little. She can't display too much affection here, in this public space with all the guests and the subdued formality, but she can at least place a kiss on her cheek and whisper quietly: "I'd like it if you show me how much you do later.” She lets one of her hands glide over Catra’s butt, who looks amazing under the folds of the dress she’s wearing, not squeezing but just softly touching it, and the combination lets the woman blush.
"Y-you are the devil," Catra stutters, because she didn’t expect Adora to be so blunt.
"And you fell into my purrrfect trap," Adora rasps out quietly, smiling, cupping one of her wife's cheeks in a hand. Beside where they are and what day it is, Adora mostly just has eyes for the woman she loves.
"Ugh, get a room, you two. This is annoying,” Glimmer scolds them.

For the first or second time in her life, Catra actually listens to Sparkle’s advice, grabs Adora’s hand, pulls her over to a door and into an adjacent room. Adora closes the door behind her, just being able to stop Juliet from following them with a waving of her finger. It’s quiet in here, the lights are out, and only some brightness falls in between the curtains. Adora quickly feels pressed against the door they just came through. Her hands lay on the wood because she wanted to damp the thump. “What are you doing?”, she breathes between narrowed lips, looking at

Catra’s, trying not to get too heated, while feeling very cornered between the enticing body she got to know so well, and the wood behind her.
The purring Catra lets out nearly drives her crazy. “What do you think I'm doing?”
“Nothing decent, and nothing appropriate! We should—"
“Well, can you blame me?” Catra opens the first two buttons of Adora’s jacket and kisses the revealed skin of her plender gap. “You are really looking good in this suit, Adora, and I can’t wait to —"
“Don’t!” Adora puts a hand over Catra’s mouth, effectively shushing her, because they can’t start to make out in the Green Room, not now, but Catra's still a brat, and licks at the hand.
“Ew!” Adora pouts and wipes off her palm at the sleeves of Catra’s dress, while her wife smirks at her with a wicked grin, opening another button of Adora’s jacket. “You like it.”

Adora actually likes it, but what she likes even more is to pay it back, and so she puts her hand on Catra’s hip and slowly travels down to the side of her thigh, softly gliding over the thin fabric of Catra’s beautiful dress with her fingers. Luckily, there is a slit at the side that reaches up to the midst of the thighs. Her teasing earns her narrowed eyes and a hitched breath of the other woman, who has stopped doing anything. No, not everything, because now Catra’s breath gets more stammering while Adora’s hand glides malevolently between the folds of the fabric and reaches the bare skin of Catra’s leg, brushing over it with only her fingertips.
Adora knows since long how to turn Catra into a giddy mess and has put her hand back over her mouth, because what started as simple teasing and the usual back-and-forth is now getting more serious, as Catra starts to breathe heavily, letting out a soft moan. Catra puts a hand into Adora’s neck, drawing her head closer. “I hate you,” she murmurs between Adora’s fingers, making her chuckle. “I don’t think so, kitty. I think you miscalculated, because you actually like me, and you wanna let me do this to you. You teased me the whole evening, didn’t you?” Her eyes are burning with joy, and they drill into Catra.

Distracted as she is, Catra doesn't resist when Adora quickly flips their position. Now it's Catra who is pressed against the door, her eyes already unfocused, half-closed. Adora lets her fingers travel upwards Catra's thigh, touching the bare and soft skin there, slowly gliding to the middle, and now she reaches this delicate place between her wife's legs and puts her hand firmly over the fabric of Catra's panties. Adora seeks for a sign of confirmation, of consent in Catra's eyes, because she always does it. Despite they often tease each other relentlessly, they always try to ascertain themselves before escalating things too far. Catra nods with a low humming and shuts her eyes again, then things get a bit heated for some minutes.

After she whited out for a few moments, Catra has her head laying against Adora's chest, who curls a hand into the brunette's mane, striking her scalp softly and whispering several "love yous" and other nonsense into her wife's ear. She holds her steady against the door, with her arms wrapped around her stringy body, a leg still slipped between her thighs to hold her firm until Catra's breath has finally calmed. "You're such a brat," Catra murmurs softly, not really complaining when she complains, "I wanted to do that to you."

Adora kisses her forehead and says: "It's okay, my love. I really love doing this for you. Reward me later? We should go back and pay some attention to our guests, huh? What do you say?"
Catra collects herself. "Hmm… I say that this isn't over. I'm gonna make you moan my name tonight." She heaves a breath while Adora kisses her head and disentangles from her. "But for now I think I can tolerate Glimmer for an hour or so. She's okay, when we can mutually tease you or Mermista, so it won't be so boring, huh?"

Adora lets out a little laugh, then both women arrange their ruffled clothes again and Adora opens the door to the banquet hall. She finds Juliet standing guard in front of it. The woman has a face like stone and doesn't even recognize what she must know has happened right behind her in the last minutes, and so Adora has the decency to blush and to not say anything. Catra on the

other hand is not so discreet when she walks past her, grinning. “Hey Juliet, how’s it hanging?” It gets her nothing else than a raised brow.

Later in the evening, while the party is slowly dying down as people leave one by one, Adora has settled onto a comfy chaise lounge. Together with some armchairs and a broad sofa, the ensemble makes up a nice seating area for a dozen people beside a window gallery. She has a drink in her hand and talks to her friends. They just chit-chat about nothing of importance, until Catra plops down on her from behind, rolling over the backrest and into Adora’s lap. It interrupts whatever Adora was talking about, and her sentence ends with useless stuttering, because Catra’s cleavage distracts her. “Concentrate, Adora!” Glimmer says and grins, and Catra repeats nastily: “Yeah, concentrate, Adora.”
“Ugh, you are incomparable. Both of you, actually.”
Catra’s best smirk plasters her face: "That might be, but someone has to take care that your ego doesn’t explode or gets bigger than your forehead. I assume that’s my humble duty, and I accept the position with disgust.”
“Some people would consider that treason,” Adora grumbles, but she also hasn't taken back her hand from Catra's small of her back, slowly fondling her. She's expecting - desperately expecting - that Catra will take care of her later, but anticipation is the greatest joy. And so the evening fawns out in an easy conversation between friends, mocking and teasing each other, carefully avoiding what's going to happen tomorrow. The next months will be turbulent, they deserve this quality time, Adora thinks, sips in her drink and slings her arms around Catra, basking in the touch. She doesn’t really know why she’s not back in her office, preparing her speech *another* time, but, actually, she finally thinks that she’s as ready as she’ll ever be.

Mermista is splayed across the couch, her date - ride! - standing behind the backrest and slowly massaging her neck. She seems to be a little drunk, because for the first time this evening, she doesn’t even complain upon the public display of affections, she just lets it happen, reveling under his touch.

“Shall I ask Juliet to have a room prepared for you? They're probably ready anyway. The staff here is really excellent. Can do anything.” Adora says, uplifting the corners of her mouth. She doesn’t mean it in a vulgar way, she just wants to offer them an easy accommodation, because even if the Hay-Adams Hotel is just over the street, she has better service here, and they don’t have to leave the house.
Mermista glances at her and doesn’t even ask Sea Hawk before she answers: “Yeah, sure. Another thing to cross off my bucket list, or whatever.”
Catra laughs. “Really, sleeping here is on your bucket list?”
Maybe it’s because of all the champagne she drank, what gets Mermista babbling. “It’s not exactly sleeping what’s on it.”
Everyone stares at her with wide eyes. Behind her, Sea Hawk has stopped his massaging and gets deeply red. When she realizes what she just admitted, Mermista clasps her hand over her mouth, blushes furiously, and Glimmer and Catra break out in loud cackling.
Adora also hides her chuckling not very well, raises a hand to wave at Juliet, and asks her to ready what presumably is already done, before she returns to the giggling round. “Well, I think we shouldn’t let the opportunity pass. So, you’re welcome to cross things off your bucket list. Or whatevaaaa.”

Mermista still hides her face between her hands.

“Lucky Man” *Youtube*[5]

She waits.

It’s the next day, and Adora waits. It’s like if running the whole track in a circle comes to a close. She has done the full thing, and now she has reached the end. Or rather, the beginning. Because this *is* a beginning, in many ways, for Adora, for Catra, for their

friends and allies, for the people, for everyone.
She will walk through the door before her, and it will be the first time that a woman does it.
She will walk through the door before, and it will be the first time that someone her age does it.
And she will walk through this door, and it will be the first time that someone with her aims does it.
She'll step into the unknown, uncharted territory that lies ahead. This is a first time in so many ways. She will shake hands, give friendly nods, wave, and walk with measured steps to the podium. There, she will unfold the paper with her speech, which she won't need, because she has memorized everything. Adora looks down at the notes and grins to herself, because Catra made her learn it, then the damned bitch rearranged half the sentences, put in some new, and told Adora that it would work better this way. When Adora read it again, it made her furious that it actually did, then she threw a vase after a cackling Catra, and they got into a very sexy brawl. Oh man, Catra had been such a brat about it. Teased her for two days. *The witch*, Adora grins quietly and is so proud of the damned woman.

She waits.

The hallway she's standing in stretches wide to the left and right, as well as behind her, from where she approached the door a minute before. Everywhere, the walls are lavishly decorated, and when they walked up the staircase up here in front of her entourage, Adora shortly paused before the six by nine meters large mural 'Westward The Course Of Empire Takes Its Way' and took it in. It's maybe ironic how, in a few minutes, she'll take the whole underlying concept of *'Manifest destiny'* of this painting and this very building and throws it onto the floor to shatter it. She, they, all of them have to remold this into something new, and she will when she explains her course of action for the next eight years.
Surely she planned for that long. The alliance, they all did.
The thought makes her smile, even if it's a pretty grim one. Catra smirkes at her, puts an arm on hers, and then a kiss on her cheek. "You got this, babe. When you come home tonight, half of the

nation will be in uproar, but the other half will be wrapped around your fingers, that much is for sure. I'll have to think of some ways to put you into your place, then. Your ego is already big enough." Behind them, the head of the detail groans audibly. For the last time, Catra gives Adora a runover, making sure her suit and appearance is immaculate. She mustn't have worried. Adora looks perfect. Then they part, and Catra is led away to her seat.

Now, Adora's alone, besides her personal guards and the man who will open the door before her when it's time. Catra will sit in the gallery, because that's the traditional place. Adora ponders if she should change this rule, but on the other hand, the trouble may not be worth the gain. This is not her house, and it's not that Catra will be here often. She's no policymaker, nor an incumbent, and she would be bored watching Adora talking to people quick enough. Besides, she has a job where she's needed and not so much leftover time to just gush over her wife. She can do this at home, when they're alone. Okay, they are never alone today, but Adora can tell Juliet to *back off* for an hour or so.

It's time. *Her* time.

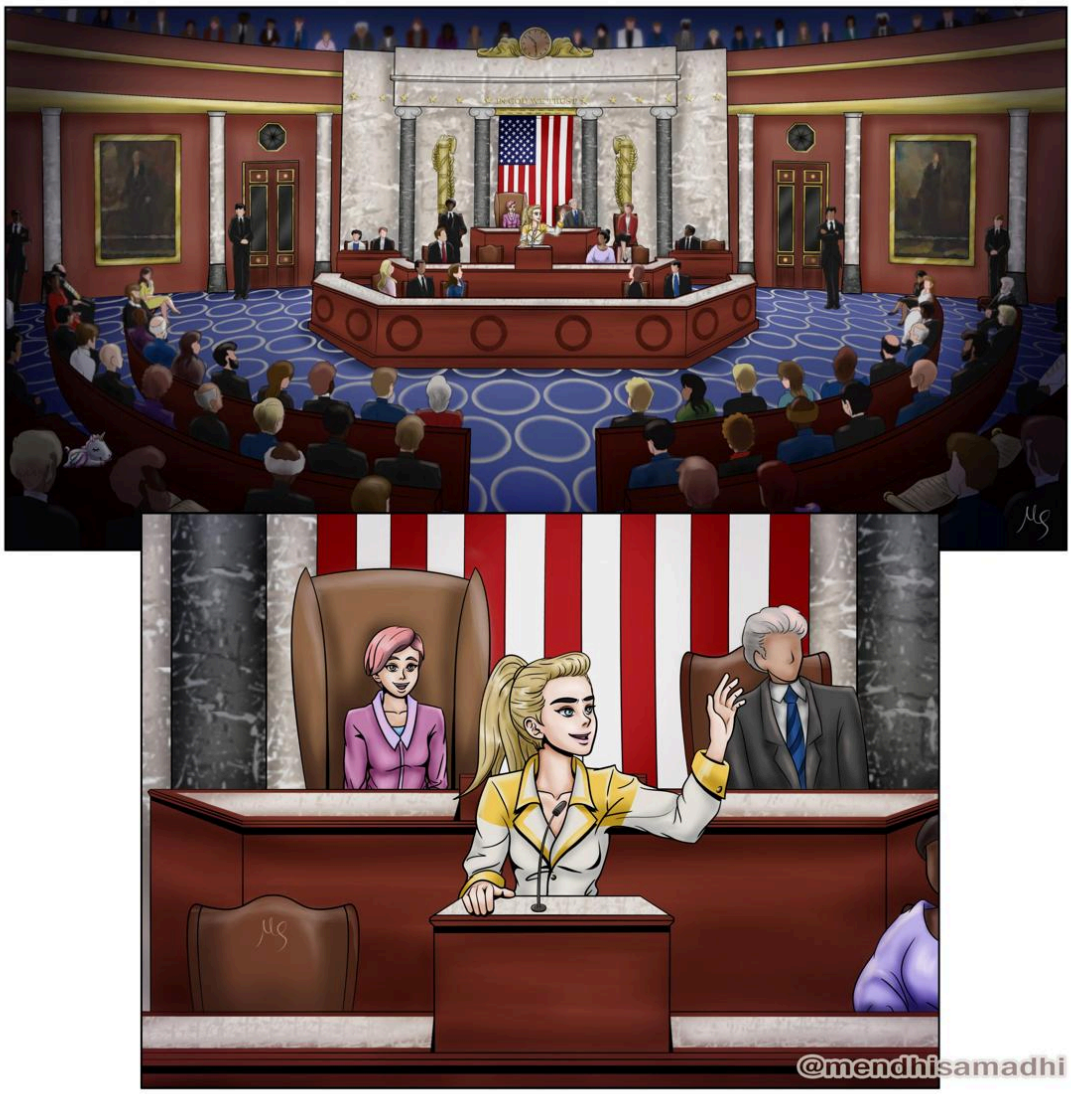
The door is pushed open by the man, and he smiles at her friendly. She returns him a warm nod, then the *Sergeant at Arms* announces her as she starts walking into the chamber. Down below, she sees the large flag, hanging behind the podium, and it's a strong reminder of what she's going to do today. Two people stand before it, and one of them smirks at her with pride and a silent, warmhearted amusement. And although she has a bit of foreshadowing that coming times may change the meaning of all of this, as they will be enduring and hard, she's also proud. Proud of herself, her wife, her friends, of what they have achieved in the last four, no eight years.
Adora is actually happy. And excited.
Left and right of the aisle, people are standing and clapping. Not all of them, sure, but many. She distributes some hand kisses and hugs while she walks down the aisle. There are so many people who want to handshake, but she can't do all. A dozen must be enough.

When all the noise and the applause dies down as Adora takes place behind the lectern, she curtly waves one time at Catra at the gallery. Her wife rewards her with a hand kiss, and she smiles, looking into the semicircle and the faces of over five hundred expectant people. Behind Adora, the Speaker of the House clears his throat. She looks around, and next to the elderly man stands Glimmer, as this is the traditional place of the Vice President, and she grins at her a lot.
Adora might be lucky that Glimmer doesn't burst out laughing. They share a knowing look, and barely hold back a fist bump, then the Speaker hits his table once with the wooden hammer, sending a loud sound through the House of Representatives Chamber, and he calls:
"Members of Congress, I have the high privilege, and the distinct honor of presenting to you, for the State of the Union Address, the President of the United States. For the first time, *Madam* President."

Adora smiles at the gathered members of the United States Congress in the House Chamber. *This is going to be a home run. I needed two elections, not four. So much for the loose cannon*, Madam President smirks at herself, as the applause dies down.

Her voice is firm, clear and confident.
"Thank you. Mr. Speaker, Mrs. Vice President, Members of Congress. My fellow Americans, I'm glad to be here today. Because I want to talk to you about the state of our union. And about hope. And about our *Manifest destiny*. So, brace yourself, because this is going to be—", she heaves a breath, glances shortly at Catra who gives her a well hidden thumbs up and a knowing smile, then she continues, "a long walk. Fortunately, we're in this together when I present to you the next age of our global society. And it will start with you."

There she is, Adora Grayskull, 39, President.
This? This is just the beginning.



The Drawing was made by [MendhiSamadhi](#)) and I recommend her highly. She was very professional while also kind and made thoughtful ideas while we discussed this drawing. Working with her was a delight, and I am grateful for how it turned out.

Chapter End Notes

[5] The following paragraphs are tailored to this piece of music, and it underlines the meaning perfectly. ↑

So, here comes the thing: this isn't really my story. Please, do me a favor, go back to the first chapter and read the first few paragraphs. Then watch [this](#). I'll wait for you.

You got that there is a whole movie you can watch, huh? Yeah, because I literally retell it for most of the plot. I didn't realize how much overlapping there is story wise, when it comes to "The Adjustment Bureau (2011)" and Catradora, until I tried to give the movie a rewatch recently. But when I saw Matt Damon standing in the hall, waiting to give his speech in the first seconds, a single thought overwhelmed me. "How cool would it be if that was Adora? In the real world, Adora as a politician makes perfect sense to me." And despite I wanted to return to my other SPOP story, I picked up writing this one instead, because I'm a fool.

The plot lines of Adora & Catra as well as David & Elise have many things in common. Adora and David are both orphans, they are both destined by certain powers for greatness, but they also *want* to have a greater destiny, they crave to prove themselves. Both find someone to whom they are attached but not allowed to be with. Catra and Elise share that the powers who control the lives of their significant others do not like and want to get rid of them. They find themselves in a dire situation, drawn to the person they love, while trying to protect themselves, and therefore unable to live a happy life. And Emily Blunt would make a perfect Catra, while Matt Damon isn't so far away from a male Adora, in all her sweet, stubborn clumsiness - at least in this movie.

For those of you who know the movie, you'll easily notice how absolutely detailed I copied the whole scenery and the dialogues to the point. That is, because I actually played the movie stop and go and typed down all dialogues, then expanded them with my own stuff and made alterations. It can't be denied, and I don't do it, that I took the plot of the movie 1:1 and added to it. Overall, I think only around half of this entire thing is my doing, but I didn't count, and I don't care. However, I added plenty of internal monologue that we don't see or hear in the movie, and I added some completely new scenes, just because I can. The last chapter as well as all of Shadow Weaver is completely my doing.

I actually worked out the baseline for another chapter that would elaborate on how Adora and her alliance would like to change the world. It revolves around a concept of how we can steer our societies and balance out the needs for freedom and opportunity with the needs for sustainable development and fair usage of our ecosphere for everyone I loosely developed since my teenage years. But this would actually lead heavily into politics and society, economics and environmental issues, and it doesn't fit the tonality of the story. So, I set it aside and ended with the positive note of Adora becoming President. I like these kinds of open while closed endings and the pathetic tonality it has, and, after all, this is Catradora and not a politics book.

I allow myself a few personal words, as you seldom hear from me in that way: with the conclusion of this fic on New Years Eve 2021, I published a word count of more than threehundredfourtythousands words in 2021 within the four stories you see at AO3. With another around onehundredthirtythousand in a yet unpublished story and some dribbles and an unpublished, shameless smut fic I wrote, I'm nearing a word count of half a million, put out since February, the 5th. This equals, just in words, the Lord of the Rings trilogy. All of this is thanks to watching *She-Ra and the Princesses of Power*, and I'm grateful for this unbelievable, inspiring work. It's still the best drama series ever made.

Because, I'm not proud of many things in my life. I'm just an average guy making his way through this world, and I've come to accept that slowly. This word count, though, is one of those few things I'm proud of.

I'm also a little proud to have written the longest story on AO3 in the fandom "The Adjustment Bureau," but that isn't surprising. Ah, and I renamed the Cedar Lake Ballet Company into Two Pines because the ballet ceased in 2015 or so and "Two Pines" is from Back to the Future. ;-)

I hope you had fun reading this. As always, comments are greatly appreciated. Thank you for staying with me and the girls until this pathetic finale.

So, see you around next year.
I wish you a nice New Year's Eve, and a Happy New Year, and I hope 2022 will be better for all of us. Be well.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!